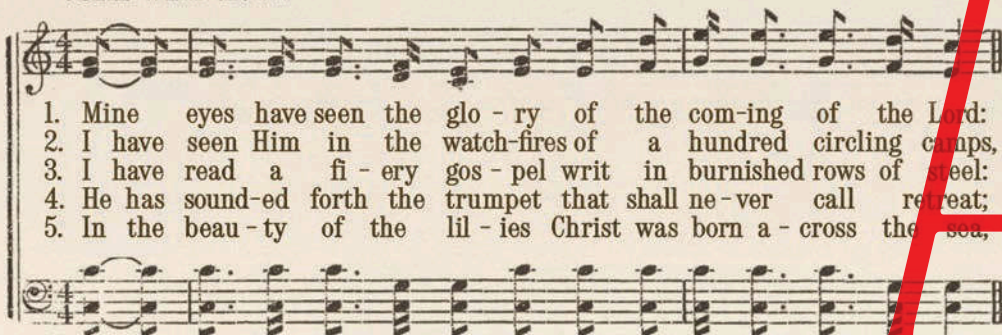
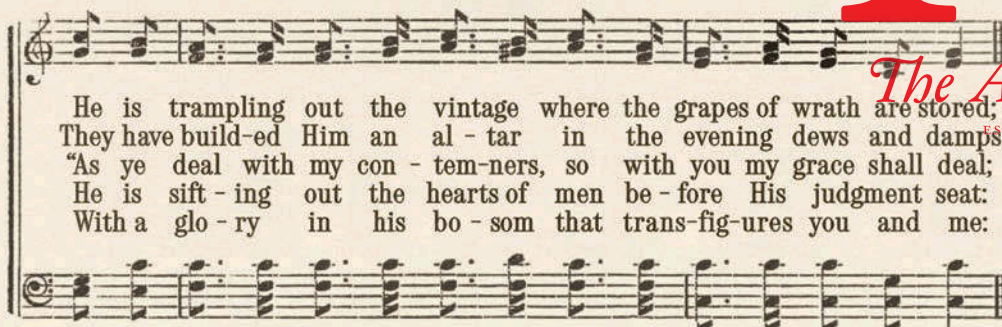


Battle Hymn of the Republic

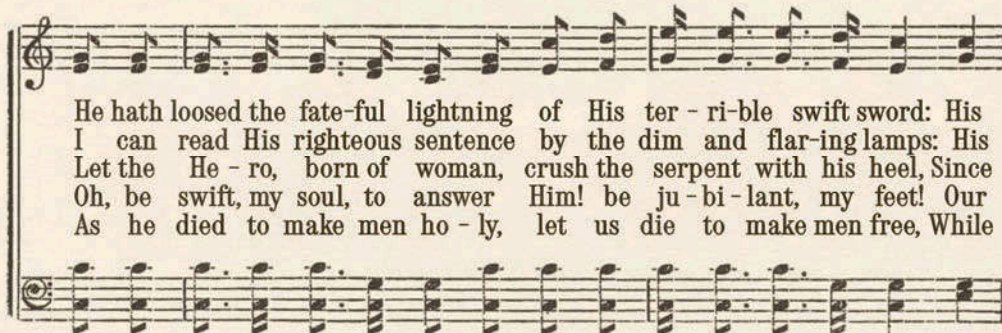
JULIA WARD HOWE



1. Mine eyes have seen the glo - ry of the com - ing of the Lord;
2. I have seen Him in the watch - fires of a hundred circling camps,
3. I have read a fi - ery gos - pel writ in burnished rows of steel:
4. He has sound - ed forth the trumpet that shall ne - ver call re - treat;
5. In the beau - ty of the lil - ies Christ was born a - cross the sea,



He is trampling out the vintage where the grapes of wrath are stored;
They have build - ed Him an al - tar in the evening dews and damps;
"As ye deal with my con - tem - ners, so with you my grace shall deal;
He is sift - ing out the hearts of men be - fore His judgment seat;
With a glo - ry in his bo - som that trans - fig - ures you and me:

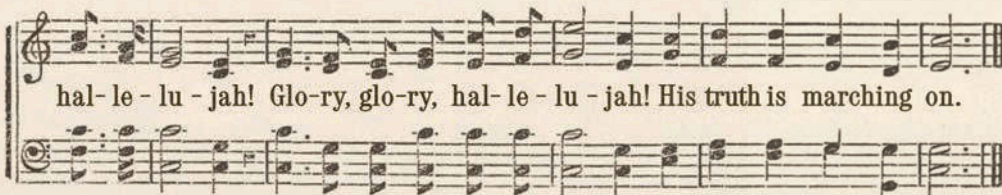


He hath loosed the fate - ful lightning of His ter - ri - ble swift sword: His
I can read His righteous sentence by the dim and flar - ing lamps: His
Let the He - ro, born of woman, crush the serpent with his heel, Since
Oh, be swift, my soul, to answer Him! be ju - bi - lant, my feet! Our
As he died to make men ho - ly, let us die to make men free, While



CHORUS

truth is marching on.
day is marching on.
God is marching on." Glo - ry, glo - ry, hal - le - lu - jah! Glo - ry, glo - ry,
God is marching on.
God is marching on.



hal - le - lu - jah! Glo - ry, glo - ry, hal - le - lu - jah! His truth is marching on.

The Atlantic
EST. 1857

Joan Mitchell, Trees, 1990 – 1991, oil on canvas, diptych, 220.3 × 400.1 cm / 86 ¾ × 157 ½ in, 2 parts, each 220.3 × 200 cm / 86 ¾ × 78 ¾ in © Estate of Joan Mitchell



HAUSER & WIRTH

JOAN MITCHELL

TREES, 1990 – 1991

ON VIEW AT ART BASEL 2026





America,

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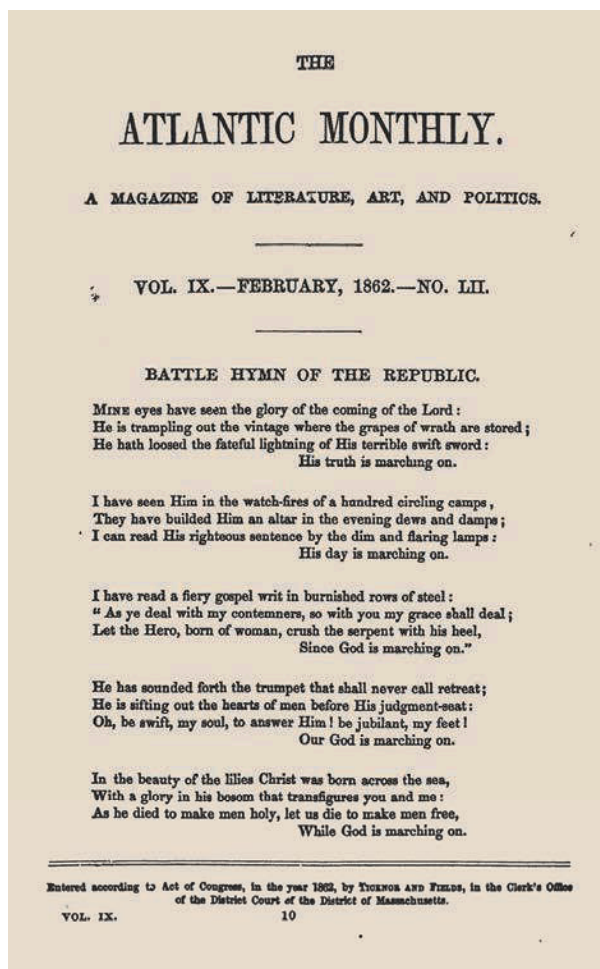
AMERICA'S PROMISE

It is quite interesting, and somewhat chastening, to realize that the most important piece of journalism published across the 169-year history of this magazine was not journalism at all, but a poem, and that it was published so early in the life of *The Atlantic*. And it is particularly humbling to know that we will almost certainly never again publish something that so powerfully transcends space and time. The poem, “Battle Hymn of the Republic,” is one that, to borrow from its final stanza, “transfigures you and me.” We are featuring it on our cover this month in celebration of the 250th anniversary of the founding of the republic.

Julia Ward Howe, the author of the “Battle Hymn”—she wrote it in one fevered night at the Willard Hotel, in Washington, D.C.—received either \$4 or \$5 for her submission. It was published in our February 1862 issue without her byline, as was then the custom. One of the many reasons we wanted the “Battle Hymn” to represent *The Atlantic* on the semi-quincentennial anniversary of American independence is that it would allow us to print the poem with Howe’s byline on our cover for the first time. It’s the least we could do, given all that she did for this magazine, and for her country as an abolitionist and a suffragist. And also because writing seemed, at times, so difficult for her.

In a note to the editor of this magazine, James T. Fields, that she attached to her submission, Howe wrote: “Fields! Do you

want this, and do you like it, and have you any room for it in January number?” She went on, “I am sad and spleeny, and begin to have fears that I may not be, after all, the greatest woman alive. Isn’t



this a melancholy view of things? But it is a vale, you know. When will the world come to end?”

Fields, to his credit, accepted the poem (we do not know if he also tried to soothe Howe’s anxiety). He also gave it its grand, martial, and commanding title.

The question arises: What does the “Battle Hymn,” written to prepare the Union and its soldiers for the terrible fight ahead, say about America itself? Our in-house historian, Jake Lundberg, writes in this issue that the poem is both an explication of the promise of America and an exhortation to persevere on behalf of the country. The “Battle Hymn,” Lundberg argues, is our unofficial national anthem, one more relevant through the ages than the actual anthem, the difficult-to-sing by-product of a minor war. “By the time of the Great Depression,” he writes, “the ‘Battle Hymn’ had achieved a truly national character. The song’s stature

is such that it can be used to make a statement in a way that the official anthem never can.”

You will see in this issue (and, I hope, in everything we do) that our journalists are engaged in worthwhile struggles with the meaning, promise, achievements, and shortcomings of our singular nation. In an article that explores the betrayal of Black military officers, Clint Smith calls out the forces of reaction for misunderstanding the nature of patriotism. And in an essay that examines the tortured debate—inside and outside the academy—over how to tell the American story, Yoni Appelbaum writes about the special challenge inherent in unifying a polarized nation around a common understanding of our history. “For more than two centuries, our creedal nationalism has been a source of strength, binding together Americans of diverse faiths and backgrounds,” he writes. “But lately, we have discovered that it is also a vulnerability.”

The ambition of *The Atlantic*’s founders was that this magazine would be the preeminent home for arguments about the American idea, and that we would endeavor to tell the truth about the grandness of America as well as its imperfections. That ambition animates this issue—and all of our journalism.

—Jeffrey Goldberg



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Behind the Cover: This month's cover features sheet music for "Battle Hymn of the Republic," by Julia Ward Howe. The poem was originally published in the February 1862 edition of *The Atlantic*. As the staff writer Jake Lundberg writes in this issue (p. 18), Howe composed the poem

as new lyrics for the Union marching song "John Brown's Body." The "Battle Hymn" itself soon became an unofficial anthem of the Union Army, and its rousing chorus has inspired movements for freedom and liberty ever since.

— Paul Spella, *Senior Art Director*

THE

The Plot Against the Humanities

*In the March issue,
Tyler Austin Harper
considered what the
Andrew W. Mellon
Foundation is doing to
higher education.*

Letters

T

Thank you to Tyler Austin Harper. Though certainly critical of the Andrew W. Mellon Foundation, his story hit upon a deeper problem facing the humanities: our culture's insistence on things of immediate "worth," and the Faustian bargain the humanities made in

an attempt to prove that they were one of those things.

Lane Sunwall
Mequon, Wis.

Tyler Austin Harper suggests that the Mellon Foundation has yoked arts and letters to the wagon of social justice, subordinating pure inquiry to political fashion. But there never was a "golden age" in which scholarship floated above the turbulence of history. Universities were built alongside empires and on the backs of the working class. Libraries were endowed by industrial fortunes and the robber barons. Canons of literature were curated by gatekeepers who mistook their vantage point for universality. The "neutrality" that Harper mourns was not the absence of politics; it was the comfort of an unexamined center.

To ask who was excluded from that center is not to corrupt the humanities; it is to practice them. Harper treats "social justice" as though it were a contaminant, a solvent dissolving rigor into activism. Yet what is literature if not a sustained inquiry into injustice and freedom? What is philosophy if not a struggle with power and responsibility? What is history if not the patient excavation of conflict, suffering, aspiration, and revolt? Frederick Douglass did not separate moral clarity from intellectual seriousness. Albert Camus did not believe that lucidity required indifference. Both understood that describing the human condition honestly is a first step in confronting injustice. Scholarship that refuses this confrontation is not neutral—it is evasive. The anxiety that expanding

representation will displace Lincoln or Washington betrays a curious fragility. Greatness does not diminish when others are acknowledged. Monuments, syllabi, grant priorities—these are not sacred relics but civic choices. They announce whose stories are worthy of endurance. If those choices change, it is not evidence of conspiracy. It is evidence that democracy is still alive enough to argue with itself.

Harper is right about one thing: The humanities are at a precipice. But the danger does not arise when foundations ask scholars to engage with the wounds of the nation. The danger arises when the humanities retreat into a nostalgia for an authority they once possessed and mistake that authority for truth. A field that studies the human condition cannot afford to fear the full humanity of its subjects. The humanities will survive not by defending an imagined past of disinterested purity, but by demonstrating their necessity in a fractured republic. They survive when they clarify rather than obscure, when they widen rather than narrow, when they refuse both dogma and denial. There is no plot against the humanities. There is only the perennial struggle over what it means to be human—and who gets to say so. And that struggle, uncomfortable though it may be, is the humanities themselves.

Rafael C. Castillo
San Antonio, Texas

In recent years, more and more students from lower-class

COMMONS



DISCUSSION
&
DEBATE

families have been able to attend universities. I suggest that this may be part of the reason fewer students are studying the humanities. We don't have family businesses for our kids to inherit. Our kids need to find a job that pays the bills; they don't have the luxury of getting an education for education's sake. Encouraging kids to choose STEM- and business-related majors just makes sense for the changing student body.

Rosie Gaede
Oak Hills, Calif.

I read Tyler Austin Harper's article on the Mellon Foundation with a mixture of recognition and exasperation. I lead a local family foundation. Harper's argument resonates with all of us who work in private giving. The argument is not really about Mellon—it is about America.

American culture struggles to value anything not immediately and aggressively useful. We live in a society that financializes nearly everything it touches. Art, scholarship, democracy itself—all are subject to the quarterly-earnings logic. That is a genuine cultural sickness. But the cure is not to demand that one private foundation become the counterweight to three centuries of capitalist common sense. That expectation asks the impossible and, more important, asks it of the wrong party.

Private institutions are entitled to set their own missions and follow their own values. If we find that troubling, and perhaps we should, the answer is a more just and equitable public infrastructure for culture and learning, not a set of obligations imposed on private grant-makers. Ironically, building that infrastructure is precisely the kind of work that would likely attract Mellon funding.

Mellon's president, Elizabeth Alexander, has said that the foundation's mission is oriented toward a "more fair, more just, more beautiful society." That that idea is somehow political is troubling. Only within the logic of an authoritarian or deeply reactionary culture can justice and beauty become controversial aims. If we have arrived at a moment when equity is coded as ideology, that is the emergency—not Mellon's program priorities.

Jennifer Koladycz Beatty
Seattle, Wash.

I was a grant administrator at an Ivy League school and am currently the director of a conservation nonprofit. I am always surprised at the amount of progressive orthodoxy and lip service required for successful funding acquisition.

To be clear, I find the pursuit of social justice to be a worthy cause. But does every grant request for research or poetry or land preservation need to include a stated commitment to equity and inclusion?

Riley Schwengel
Sloatsburg, N.Y.

Tyler Austin Harper is right to worry about the collapse of support for the humanities. But his critique of the Mellon Foundation's emphasis on social justice turns a structural crisis into a zero-sum grievance—as though funding historically under-supported fields must come at the expense of "real" humanistic inquiry. That framing is backwards. The deeper emergency is the long retreat of public investment, the market logic governing higher education, and the evaporation of a diverse philanthropic ecosystem. In that landscape, Mellon's choices do not "control" the humanities so much as reveal how precarious they've become.

Ann Jacobs
New York, N.Y.

TYLER AUSTIN HARPER REPLIES:

For years, progressive academics have defended the naked politicization of their curricula

by countering that "everything is political"—that there is no neutral, ideology-free way to run a university or produce knowledge. This is certainly true—and a rather banal truism. When 20th-century English professors taught syllabi with no novelists of color or women, they were driven by ideological biases, and I do not wish to return to a world in which such syllabi are de rigueur. But there is a difference between recognizing that the academy cannot be truly apolitical and deciding—as the Mellon Foundation has done—that the most valuable forms of scholarship are those that instrumentalize knowledge in the service of direct political impacts.

To respond to *Atlantic* articles or submit author questions to The Commons, please email letters@theatlantic.com. Include your full name, city, and state.

A Note to Readers: This issue marks the end of the 22-puzzle run for the "Caleb's Inferno" crossword. We owe a special thanks to Caleb Madison and his editor, Kelsey Dixon, who together provided readers with devilishly difficult puzzles on the magazine's back page. To keep up with *The Atlantic's* crosswords, and to explore other games, visit TheAtlantic.com/Games.

Correction: "I Found It: The Best Free Restaurant Bread in America" (May) included an imprecise allusion to Willy Wonka candies. The article suggested that the Everlasting Gobstopper can convey the sensation of eating an entire meal in every bite. In Roald Dahl's *Charlie and the Chocolate Factory*, it is a chewing gum that offers the sensation of eating an entire meal, not the Everlasting Gobstopper, though a real-life candy called the Everlasting Gobstopper does feature multiple distinct flavors.

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DISPATCHES

OPENING ARGUMENT

USE IT OR LOSE IT

*Freedom of speech,
and of the press, can
be guaranteed only
if Americans exercise
their rights.*

BY ADRIENNE
LA FRANCE

Even in an age of unintended metaphors, few can compare to the scene that unfolded one winter morning five years ago on a street corner in downtown Washington, D.C.

A group of men gathered in front of the seven-story building at Pennsylvania Avenue and Sixth Street Northwest, just a short walk from the Capitol, and prepared for an act of careful destruction. Their task was to do away with the colossal facade overhead. Slab by slab, they removed the Tennessee pink marble. The

45 words of the First Amendment had been there for years, giant letters carved in stone. Now that message was gone.

Although the symbolism was impossible to ignore, the backstory bordered on mundane: The Newseum, a museum devoted to the history of journalism, had run out of money and closed. So down went the tribute to the First Amendment, sent in pieces to Philadelphia. The marble was reconfigured by the National Constitution Center, which is all well and good for those who want to pay \$24.95 to bask in freedom's most glorious words. But those words are no longer displayed on Pennsylvania Avenue, where anyone traversing the street that connects Congress to the White House would once have seen them.

The facade was only ever a blip on the radar screen—installed in 2007, dismantled in 2021. And if you're looking for razed history, there's plenty more at that exact intersection. A century before the First Amendment (briefly) towered over passersby, two rival hotels stood at the corner of Pennsylvania and Sixth. One had a tavern that held the distinction of being the first public place in Washington where "The Star-Spangled Banner" was sung, in 1814. The other, the National Hotel, was where John Wilkes Booth slept the night before he assassinated Abraham Lincoln, in 1865.

My point is: America is in a constant state of change. Anything that persists for a time does so only through a combination of fortune and choice. Our core freedoms may be enshrined in our founding documents, but they are guaranteed to us only in principle.

Advancing the cause of freedom in practice is another matter.

Americans must try to better understand what freedom demands of them. One requirement of self-governance is the relentless pursuit of truth, which necessarily involves questioning people in positions of power in order to prevent tyranny. Yet misconceptions about what *free speech* and *free press* actually mean are everywhere. Too many people assume that *freedom of speech* means freedom from consequences—whether reputational, social, or professional—for what they say. (It does not.) Others conflate the role of privately run companies with that of the government, arguing, for example, that a social-media company's moderation decisions amount to state censorship. (They do not, and in fact the individuals who run social platforms have their own First Amendment rights as publishers—even if they don't like to concede that they themselves are publishers.)

Far too many people behave as though *freedom of the press* refers only to freedom for professional journalists. But journalists are not in some special category. The right to free press is, like free speech, a basic freedom that applies to all Americans who choose to exercise it. The First Amendment tells the government that it cannot encroach on *any* American's right to speak and publish. Freedom of the press is not about the press; it's about the freedom.

So when you encounter an American cheering on the notion that the "fake-news media" should be jailed, or punished, or destroyed, what you're actually seeing is someone cheering for the government

to trample on their own First Amendment rights. And if you're the one excoriating "the media" for their failings, consider not just complaining but competing: Exercise your own right to free press. The barriers to distributing information have never been lower. What once required an expensive printing press can now be done

MISCONCEPTIONS
ABOUT WHAT
FREE SPEECH
AND FREE PRESS
ACTUALLY
MEAN ARE
EVERYWHERE.

with a smartphone—paper, a pen, and a copy machine still work in a pinch too.

It is no coincidence that President Trump has conditioned his followers to attack their fellow citizens as enemies of America for questioning him. He makes himself available to the public far more readily than other modern presidents have, a quality that offers a simulacrum of transparency—until you observe how he interacts with people who dare speak words that upset him. He kicked the Associated Press out of the White House for not calling the Gulf of Mexico the "Gulf of America." His administration replaced the Pentagon press corps with MAGA lapdogs, influencers, and a disgraced former congressman

turned podcaster. All the while, Trump routinely lashes out at citizens for posing basic questions that the American people deserve answers to. When one woman asked him when the Iran war would end, he called her a "disgrace." When another woman asked him why he's focused on beautifying the Reflecting Pool in front of the Lincoln Memorial during wartime, especially as gas prices soar, he snapped that it was a "stupid question." When a woman asked the president about his administration's handling of Afghan refugees, he interrupted her, saying, "Are you stupid? Are you a stupid person?" To yet another woman, who'd asked him about Jeffrey Epstein, the president responded, "Quiet! Quiet, piggy." He has told other Americans that they are "horrible," "obnoxious," "terrible," "stupid and nasty," simply for asking him serious questions on behalf of the public.

TRUMP, GIFTED SHOWMAN that he is, understands that insulting citizens on camera is a tactic that serves his interests. It distracts people from the fact that he hasn't answered the question. And it is chum for his propagandists, who eat up this debasement of American freedom and share clips with breathless commentary such as "Trump absolutely bodies a CNN reporter" and "annoying anti-MAGA brat gets HUMILIATED LIVE." Trump has effectively cast journalists as a separate special-interest group—apart from ordinary American citizens. But this is a lie.

The tech barons who run the platforms where these indecent clips proliferate are pliant cogs in Trump's

machine. So it's not entirely surprising how many of them share his disdain for Americans who happen to work as journalists. Nevertheless, it is alarming that Silicon Valley is now emulating the president and establishing its own "editorial" teams that please and flatter tech leaders, who in turn refuse

to subject themselves to serious questioning.

Power doesn't like to be checked. Peter Thiel has declared anyone who criticizes his vision of AI "the anti-Christ." The venture-capital firm Andreessen Horowitz—co-founded by Marc Andreessen, a man who infamously blocks every journalist he can

find on social media—has an "editor in chief" for one of its funds and an in-house media team designed to bypass independent outlets. Elon Musk bought Twitter and turned it into a right-wing propaganda network. Anthropic has an "editorial team." So does Apple. Meta has an "editorial" leader, whom it hired away

from *The New York Times*. At OpenAI, which also has an "editorial lead," Sam Altman claims that *TBPN*, the podcast he recently acquired, will be fully editorially independent. (As of this writing, Altman has refused to speak with any journalist at *The Atlantic* for years despite our many, many, many requests. We will keep asking.)



From 2007 to 2021, the facade of the Newseum reminded passersby in downtown Washington of their First Amendment freedoms.

Like Trump, the tech industry's most powerful and illiberal figures want to replace those who seek truth in the public interest with sycophants who cheer on their consolidation of power and self-enrichment. They believe that the American people won't notice, or don't care, and in plenty of cases they are right.

I should note that every last one of these people is exercising their own First Amendment rights. If someone wants to do "editorial" work for a tech company that involves publishing only stories advancing the mission of the company and the worldview of its owner, that's their right. Corporate public relations and marketing are, like any other form of publishing, protected under the First Amendment from government interference, as they should be, even if they aren't guided by the same values and standards as journalism.

I should also note that working journalists bear an awesome responsibility. Anyone who is charged with seeking the truth and reporting it, and is lucky enough to spend their days asking questions of powerful people, should remember that journalism is first and foremost a public service, and that it is a privilege to serve. Journalists are not above reproach. Americans have a civic obligation to demand the highest standards from anyone who promises to represent their interests—regardless of whether that person is an elected official or simply a fellow citizen. Journalists should receive good-faith criticism with humility and appreciation.

Although every American is entitled to exercise the right to free press, no one is entitled to

be trusted or believed—that, you have to earn. The nose-dive in trust in journalism is multifactorial, and journalists themselves are not without blame. All journalists make mistakes. And those mistakes are never acceptable. But pay close attention to the difference between how a reputable news organization acknowledges its mistakes—namely, by transparently correcting them—and how Trump or Musk reacts to being called out for getting something wrong.

IN THE UNITED STATES, we like to tell ourselves that freedom is as natural as sunshine and as American as bubble gum. But American freedom has always been simultaneously conditional and aspirational—available to some and not to others, and at times diminished for all.

The cause of freedom has advanced only because of those who have been willing to stand up against government overreach. On September 25, 1690, in Boston, Benjamin Harris published colonial America's first newspaper, *Publick Occurrences Both Forreign and Domestick*. Harris was a refugee from England, where he'd faced harsh government censorship in his failed attempts to establish a free press. The first issue of *Publick Occurrences* contained a few items of local news and, notably, one salacious sentence speculating that King Louis XIV of France was sleeping with his son's wife. Colonial authorities shut down the newspaper immediately—citing the fact that Harris, along with the printer, Richard Pierce, had disseminated information without first seeking government approval. They ordered Harris not to publish

another edition and destroyed all remaining copies of the paper. (A single copy is known to have survived, and it is now in London, of all places.) Harris and Pierce had no constitutional protection of their right to free press; the government believed that it had total discretion over what information

ALTHOUGH
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IS ENTITLED
TO EXERCISE
THE RIGHT TO
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NO ONE IS
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OR BELIEVED—
THAT, YOU HAVE
TO EARN.

was allowed to reach the public. *Publick Occurrences* existed for exactly one issue. The next newspaper would not be printed in the colonies for 14 long years.

The paper often credited with being the first true daily in America, *The Pennsylvania Evening Post*, was founded generations later, in the months leading up to the American Revolution. (The *Post* was the first to publish the text of the Declaration of Independence, on July 6, 1776.) And although the Bill of Rights came soon after, ever since the First Amendment was ratified, Americans have had to continually, sometimes aggressively,

insist on their right to free expression in the face of political pressure.

Alexander Manly did so when he continued to publish his newspaper, *The Daily Record*, in Wilmington, North Carolina, after racist backlash to an anti-lynching editorial. A former congressman led a mob in burning the *Record's* office to the ground in 1898. Manly was just one target in the wave of post-Reconstruction violence that erased hard-won freedoms. Ida Tarbell and Ida B. Wells pushed for freedom through their relentless reporting, exposing the predatory practices of the oil baron John D. Rockefeller and the horrors of white mobs lynching Black Americans across the South. Oliver Wendell Holmes Jr. defended free expression when he argued for a competitive marketplace of ideas. Lenny Bruce did it from the stage in a comedy club. And Fannie Lou Hamer did it when she refused to be silenced by presidential intimidation and described the brutality she'd faced for simply trying to vote.

Every human deserves the five basic freedoms protected by the First Amendment: religion, speech, press, assembly, and petition. But freedom is not promised to any of us, not really. American freedom is a continual achievement that is secured by those willing to defend and perpetuate it. And it is a choice we must make, again and again and again, knowing that the forces aligned against the pursuit of truth are inherently working against the cause of liberty too. *A*

Adrienne LaFrance is the executive editor of The Atlantic.

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THE SECOND OPINION PEOPLE

NEVER CALL RETREAT

*How “Battle Hymn of the Republic” was born—
and why it endures as a sacred national song*

BY JAKE LUNDBERG

We tend to think we have one national anthem, but to me, we have always seemed to have two. The first is the official one, “The Star-Spangled Banner.” The second is “Battle Hymn of the Republic.” The two are different on every level. Only one of them provokes us to ponder our identity as a nation.

When we sing the first, we sometimes forget that we’re actually asking a question, and not a very important one. “O say can you see,” “The Star-Spangled Banner” begins, in search of an affirmation about the flag: It was there in the evening, when we saluted it; it was there through the night, when we saw it in the flashes of battle; is it still there now, as the day breaks?

The second brooks no doubt. When we sing it, we don’t ask a question. We testify. “Mine eyes have seen the glory of the coming of the Lord,” we proclaim, before working through four more stanzas of earnest witness—seeing, hearing, and feeling God’s wrath on the way to service in a great national cause.

The difference between the two songs is more than a matter of syntax. Though notoriously difficult for vocalists, “The Star-Spangled

Banner”—recalling a single battle from a little-remembered war—is not a challenging text. The “Battle Hymn” is easier to sing, but harder to reckon with. Truly a hymn rather than an anthem, it is a song for serious movements and solemn occasions. It is stirring in its driving tune, but unsettling in its sanctified vision of violence. When Julia Ward Howe wrote it in a single blaze of inspiration, in November 1861, she captured the upright, abolitionist cast of mind common among many northerners: the idea that the Civil War was a holy crusade to end slavery and save the nation—a narrative of sin and redemption. When *The Atlantic* published her poem in February 1862, it quickly became a staple of American patriotic observance that would, in time, transcend its origins in the horrific destruction of the Civil War.

“It is a misfortune of popular songs that they spoil their own effect by constant repetition,” Oliver Wendell Holmes Sr. remarked in an 1865 lecture on war poetry. The opposite is true for “Battle Hymn of the Republic.” It has existed in a state of constant repetition since the Civil War, but its effect has remained undiminished and in fact has grown, though the song’s purpose has shifted over time. We will surely be hearing

it throughout this year, as the nation marks its 250th birthday. The rousing urgency of the lyrics and music can’t be ignored—they seem to possess a power, according to the lyrics themselves, “that transfigures you and me.”

THE “BATTLE HYMN” was part of an almost desperate lyrical effusion in the early phases of the Civil War. In the face of a cataclysm they were only beginning to understand, poets and songwriters poured out verse. Most of the work is now forgotten, its sentimental and romantic nature wildly unmatched to the grim reality of the conflict taking shape. In 1861, a group of prominent New Yorkers launched a competition for a new national anthem, arguing that “The Star-Spangled Banner,” with its impossible vocal range and vague patriotic message, was “almost useless.” The promised \$500 prize elicited many submissions—all of them, according to the organizers, characterized by “decent dullness” or “fantastic folly.” The prize was not awarded.

Walt Whitman grasped that something entirely different was called for. In “Eighteen Sixty-One,” he produced not merely a poem about the war but a poem about what war poetry should sound like. He

addressed his words directly to a personified 1861: “No dainty rhymes or sentimental love verses for you terrible year,” Whitman wrote. “Not you as some pale poetling seated at a desk lisping cadenzas piano, / But as a strong man erect, clothed in blue clothes, advancing, carrying rifle on your shoulder.” Whitman offered the poem to *The Atlantic* for \$20. The magazine declined.

Julia Ward Howe didn’t fit Whitman’s description of a manly war poet, but by her own admission she had held from youth the keen sense that she was destined to produce a great, age-defining work. Howe could scarcely have imagined that it would be a war poem. She had published two collections of verse in the 1850s, both of which tilted toward more personal themes, including the struggles of her difficult marriage to the dour physician and reformer Samuel Gridley Howe and the torments of her affection for a male friend in Rome. Like Whitman, though, Howe recognized the transformative effects of wartime. In “Our Orders,” published in *The Atlantic* in July 1861, she acknowledged that it was now the writer’s job to “wage the war of words,” though the poem itself is treacly stuff that hardly portends what was about to come.



Howe would tell the story of her own enduring contribution to the war of words for the rest of her life, and the legend of the otherworldly inspiration behind the “Battle Hymn” grew with the song’s stature in American culture. In 1861, Howe accompanied her husband and a group of Massachusetts dignitaries on a trip from Boston to Washington, D.C. While Samuel busied himself with the affairs of the U.S. Sanitary Commission, a soldiers’-aid organization, Julia immersed herself in the wartime life of the capital. Her encounters with soldiers in camps acquainted her with a Union Army marching song, “John Brown’s Body,” that had originated among Massachusetts soldiers but spread quickly through the ranks. Set to the tune of an old southern hymn, it was what Holmes called “a strange song”—perhaps as strange as the wild-eyed abolitionist who inspired it; he was hanged in 1859 after a failed raid on the federal arsenal at Harpers Ferry. Three times it repeats the line “John Brown’s body lies a-mouldering in the grave” before proclaiming that “his soul’s marching on.” Then comes the thunderous “Glory, glory hallelujah” of the chorus.

Howe had an operatic singing voice and was known in her circle as “Diva Julia.” One day, hearing her sing “John Brown’s Body” with soldiers on the road back to Washington after a troop review, a member of her group suggested that she write her own words to the song. That night, in a room at the Willard Hotel—looking out on an advertisement for a company in the booming, war-driven business of embalming—Howe did just that. The words came to her all

at once, she maintained, as if through a visitation. Rising in the half-light of dawn, she rapidly scrawled out the poem in a fervid moral burst.

Howe removed John Brown from the song while enlarging his mission to the broader Union cause. She stirred in great heaps of the venerated biblical language—from Isaiah and Revelation—in which 19th-century Americans were fluent. The ease with which she composed the “Battle Hymn” may be explained in part by her connection to Brown himself: Her husband had been one of the “Secret Six” who had helped fund and plan Brown’s scheme to incite an insurrection aimed at destroying slavery. She herself had once met Brown, remembering him as “a Puritan of the Puritans, forceful, concentrated, and self-contained.”

Although Brown was absent from Howe’s lyrics, his specter glared from between the lines, apocalyptic and militant. Whose soul was marching on with the Union Army? Who was wielding that terrible swift sword? Who had died to make men free? Brown had notorious associations with the sword; in Bleeding Kansas, he and his followers attacked and killed five pro-slavery settlers, including some by the blade. And Brown had animated at least some northern soldiers to understand their service as an extension of his crusade. Upon his death, he came to be seen as a Christlike figure by many, making “the gallows as glorious as the cross,” as Ralph Waldo Emerson is reported to have said.

At the same time, the obscurity of the connections—there for those who knew enough (and wished) to see them,

absent for those who did not—was vital to the success of the “Battle Hymn.” It didn’t have to be seen as being about Brown, a discomfiting figure in many eyes. Immediately upon its publication in *The Atlantic*, the “Battle Hymn” was reprinted in newspapers throughout the northern states as a rallying cry. A *New York Times* article remarked on the

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power of the words, “warming and nerving the soldier’s soul like the notes of a trumpet.” The writer’s only criticism was that the “marching on” refrain called to mind a certain other song that the writer refused to name. Although the “Battle Hymn” would never supplant “John Brown’s Body” in popularity among Union soldiers, its diffusion into the culture was rapid. Only a few months after publication, it was sung at Fourth of July celebrations from Pittsfield, Massachusetts, to Marysville, California.

Charles McCabe, known as the “singing chaplain,” was a Methodist attached to the 122nd Ohio Volunteer Infantry. He and others in his unit had been captured at Winchester, Virginia, by the

Confederates and were being held as prisoners in Richmond. In 1863, upon learning of the Union victory at Gettysburg, McCabe led his fellow prisoners in a rendition of the “Battle Hymn” so spirited that, as he recalled, the prison’s walls “quivered in the melody.” In February 1864, after his release in an exchange, McCabe brought the “Battle Hymn” to a meeting of the U.S. Christian Commission in the House chamber in the Capitol, with Abraham Lincoln in attendance. Leading the chorus, McCabe brought the president close to tears. “Sing it again,” Lincoln is said to have called out.

THE SONG TOOK on a life of its own—or rather, many lives, and not always ones that could have been foreseen. As the historians John Stauffer and Benjamin Soskis observe in their book about the song, Howe’s words were deeply sectional, aligning God with the northern side. But after the Civil War, the “Battle Hymn” came to occupy a curious and awkward position, with consequences that gave it national meaning. The original “John Brown’s Body” continued to be popular among Black Americans and many northern veterans, and continued to be widely sung. By comparison, the stately and transcendent language of the “Battle Hymn” made it seem more anodyne, less threatening. It was certainly more palatable in the former Confederacy. Among the gestures of goodwill and fellow feeling that featured at veterans’ reunions and other war memorializations—common throughout the country in the decades after the war—was the performance of both the “Battle Hymn” and “Dixie,”

the unofficial Confederate anthem, one after another. It is an abiding irony that post-Civil War reconciliation culture and its repressive racial politics helped lay the foundations for the nationalization of the “Battle Hymn.”

The song had grown out of a bloody domestic conflict, but later in the century its rhetorical force appealed to those with foreign ambitions. In an emotional appeal for military intervention in Cuba a little more than a month after the sinking of the USS Maine, in 1898, Senator John M. Thurston found a justification for war and an imperialist mission in Howe’s words. He invoked the final verse of the “Battle Hymn”—“In the beauty of the lilies Christ was born across the sea”—as he urged his colleagues to advance the cause of humanity “under the American flag” beyond the nation’s shores. Theodore Roosevelt, who came to national prominence during the Spanish-American War, deployed the song in his return to presidential politics ahead of the 1912 election; he invoked it again while beating the drum for American intervention in the Great War, claiming that only those with “cold and timid hearts are not stirred by the surge of the tremendous ‘Battle Hymn of the Republic.’”

Others found very different applications for the song. The International Workers of the World repurposed it into “Solidarity Forever,” which would become the enduring anthem of the modern labor movement. Black Americans kept alive the ancestral connections between “John Brown’s Body” and the “Battle Hymn,” and the words of the hymn were woven throughout the story of

the civil-rights movement. In one notable moment in 1932, the NAACP convened at Harpers Ferry for its annual meeting and dedicated a memorial marker to honor Brown. The historians Stauffer and Sosskis describe how the group declined to perform “America” at the meeting’s close and broke into the “Battle Hymn” instead.

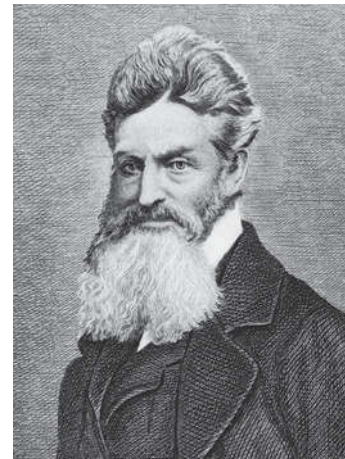
By the time of the Great Depression, the “Battle Hymn”

Georgia capitol building as the body of Martin Luther King Jr. passed by. King had invoked its words after the march to Selma, and the last sentence of the last speech he gave before his assassination was this: “Mine eyes have seen the glory of the coming of the Lord.”

AS HE WAS finishing his Dust Bowl epic in 1938, John Steinbeck didn’t have a title.

book it has a large meaning.” It was also true, Steinbeck said, that “people know the Battle Hymn who don’t know the Star-Spangled Banner.”

On official occasions, the “Battle Hymn” is today mostly performed adagio—the song’s grandeur can live at a slow tempo. But Steinbeck was right to think of it as a march. Its origins are there, in “John Brown’s Body” and the rhythmic



Julia Ward Howe, who wrote the lyrics to “Battle Hymn of the Republic,” and John Brown, the abolitionist and insurrectionist, who inspired the song that Howe adapted to her purpose

had achieved a truly national character. The song’s stature is such that it can be used to make a statement in a way that the official anthem never can. The acclaimed opera singer and civil-rights pioneer Marian Anderson performed the hymn, not the anthem, for a television audience of 60 million people in 1953. The hymn is a staple at presidential inaugurations and at the funerals of presidents and other national figures—Robert F. Kennedy, Ronald Reagan, John McCain, George H. W. Bush. It was sung in 1968 by mourners outside the

Upon reading the manuscript, his wife, Carol, suggested one: *The Grapes of Wrath*. Steinbeck argued for it in correspondence with his agent. Its roots were biblical, but what Steinbeck had in mind was “Battle Hymn of the Republic” and its vivid elaboration of “trampling out the vintage where the grapes of wrath are stored.” The “Battle Hymn,” Steinbeck knew, was a march, and as he explained to his agent, “this book is a kind of march—because it is in our own revolutionary tradition and because in reference to this

advance of men going to war in 1861. Those men were only vaguely aware of the horrors that awaited them, but the commitment they expressed, in song, on foot, is the well-spring of the hymn’s enduring effect—its faith in American promise, its exhortation to persevere. Julia Ward Howe cast their commitment in the eternal language of a sacred text in order to create a sacred text of her own, and our own. *A*

Jake Lundberg is a staff writer at The Atlantic.

Disneyland With No People

*Photographs by
Diane Arbus*

By Steve Martin

When I was 17, I worked at Fantasyland's magic shop as a magician demonstrating Svengali decks, cups and balls, and the Incredible (their word) Shrinking Die. I loved working to exhaustion, and I was proud to become the shop's youngest night manager. When Disneyland's summer hours were extended to 9 p.m. on weekdays and midnight on weekends, I was in heaven. I could watch date night unfold, allowing me to observe and absorb teen romantic norms. One night, however, a chance encounter with a renowned artist was to grip me more than 60 years later, setting my nostalgia for Disneyland in dramatic black and white.

A summer evening in 1962: The fireworks were over, the crowds dwindled, and the store emptied. I counted out the registers, turned out the lights, and locked the hand-carved sorcerers' doors behind me.

My usual route out was through Sleeping Beauty's castle, over the moat via a working drawbridge. But tonight, a security guard stopped me. "Can't go that way, gotta go out the side exit." "Why?" I asked. He said, "There's a photographer taking a picture."

I obediently took the adjacent side route (in those days, film was expensive, so no one stepped in front of even the most casual snapshot). I passed the photographer, a woman. I want to say I remember the camera, whether it was on a tripod or whether she held it, and what she was wearing. But I can't. I want to say I was there when the camera clicked as I strolled by, but I can't. I want to say I stopped and chatted. I didn't, but I wish I had. Because the photographer was Diane Arbus.

Arbus, among the most renowned photographers of the 20th century, is known for her photographs of the outliers next door—carnies, identical twins, exotic dancers, and weight lifters, among others. (It's sloppy to call her subjects "freaks," as some observers did, a term that slanders the subjects as well as the photographer.) She found people to photograph who were visually captivating and dignified, and who pulled us into fringe worlds that most of us know nothing about.

Her photos without people as subjects are rare and more rarely shown. There exist

only a dozen or so depopulated images, including a puddle on a sidewalk, a wax-museum axe murderer (I'm calling a waxen axe murderer a nonperson), a facade of a Hollywood movie set with scaffolding propping up its skeletal shell, and the creepy interior of a dark ride at Coney Island.

After a bus trip from Manhattan to Southern California, she decided to photograph what she called "pseudo places," an apt description of Disneyland's high, rampant whimsy. Her notebook from the period: "I have found the most wonderful



A rock in Disneyland, Cal. 1962

pseudo places at dawn in Disneyland, ruins of Cambodian temples which never existed, false deserts littered with bones of animals who never died, mountain like a shrine for unbelievers. And black swans swim in the moat of a castle which looks like the advertisement for a dream.”

The presence of Disneyland’s “guests” in the photos, I suppose, would have given the photos a souvenir context that would have rendered them flat, so Arbus arranged access in the off-hours, when the park would be empty. (The park’s rules were

more easygoing then. Remember, I started when I was 10 years old and was paid my day’s earnings—about \$1.50—in cash.)

She turned her camera on “Skull Rock,” a self-explanatory name describing an outcropping of plaster, where a Yo-Ho-Ho dead man’s skull emerges out of the volcanic upheaval (around the corner from Mr. Toad and just behind the Chicken of the Sea pirate ship). Arbus’s photo transforms a fake scary place into an actual scary place: The photograph is nightmare material for both children and adults.



© THE ESTATE OF DIANE ARBUS

She also shot a sunset scene of ersatz boulders, looking like a carapace army resting on transports, waiting to be moved into place. The image is officially titled *Rocks on wheels, Disneyland, Cal. 1962*. But it is undoubtedly misnamed: The setting is a mountainous terrain, probably the Anaheim Hills, whereas Disneyland's domain is as flat as Kansas. The rocks were traveling to, and had not yet arrived at, Disneyland.

The photo delivers a Daliesque strain of surrealism—as well as a dash of humor, but only if you want it. In Arbus's Disneyland series, humor was the last thing on her mind. The inevitable irony inherent in pointing out phony places—motels that look like tepees and giant roadside dinosaurs—is absent from these honestly delivered photos.

Her final Disneyland image is of Sleeping Beauty's castle, the perfect "pseudo place" and my home away from

home—where I heard Tchaikovsky's "Sleeping Beauty Waltz" on a loop. The castle's authority makes you believe it's real, despite being smaller than it should be, prettier than it should be. (If you turned your head to the right, you could see a TWA rocket ship ready for launch to the moon.) Arbus photographed the castle as though it were a delectable sweet—more akin to what it was to us Disneyland romantics than to a Manhattan ironist. There is no evidence

This page:

Rocks on wheels, Disneyland, Cal. 1962

Opposite page:

A castle in Disneyland, Cal. 1962



of mockery in the photo, and if there is, certainly the glowing white swan gliding on the moat's black water doesn't know it.

As the decades passed, I became more conversant with Arbus's work. But I remained unaware of the castle image until much, much later.

When I finally saw the castle photo, it was like being surprised by a snapshot of your toy box from when you were 5. A sudden yank back in time, pulled not just by

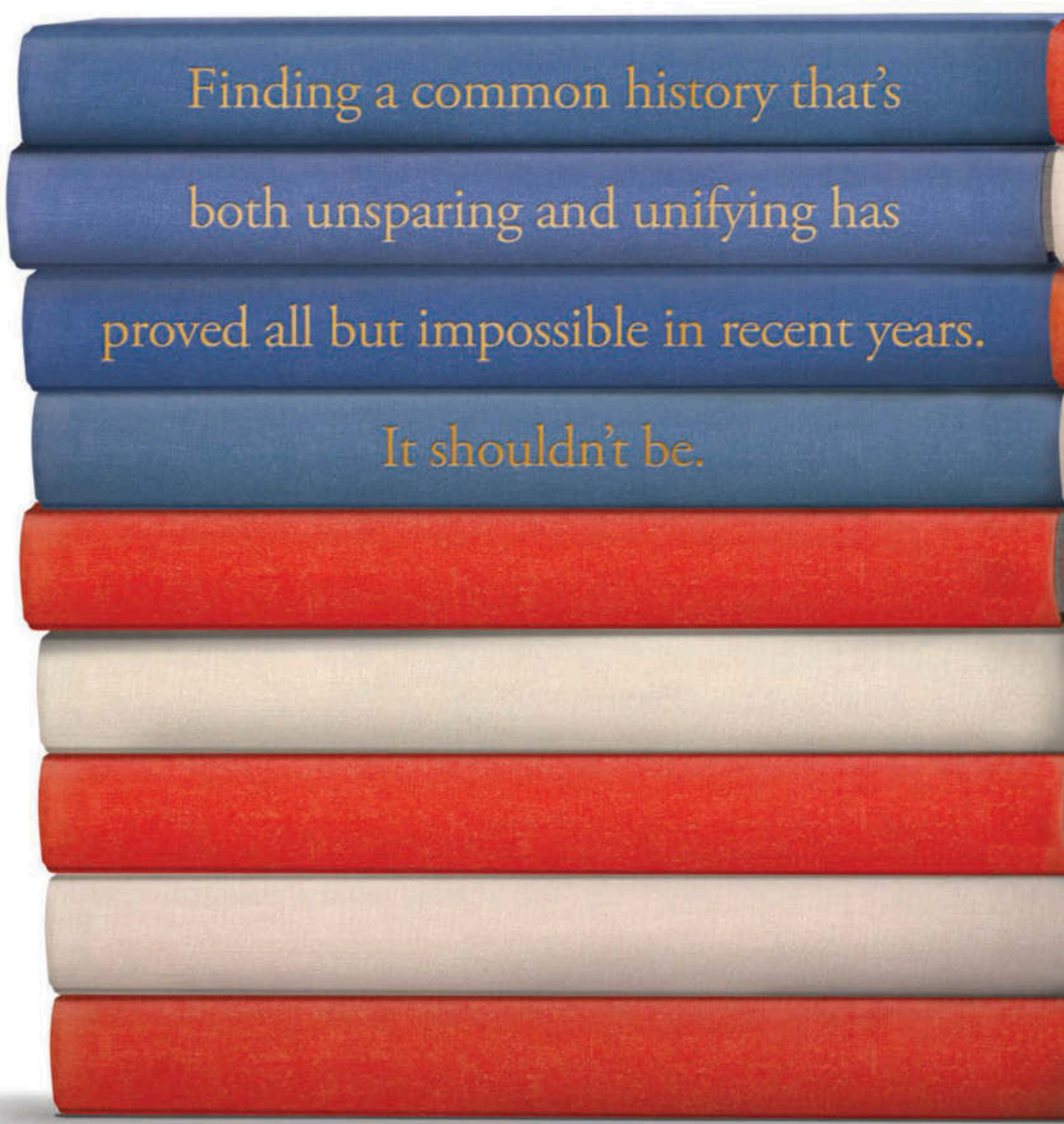
familiarity, but by a tangible recall of time and place, with the mood exactly right. For the first time in years, I remembered the incident with the mysterious photographer. Research showed that the dates lined up, the hours lined up, the location lined up: The after-hours lone photographer I passed was undoubtedly Diane Arbus.

My nostalgia—more like melancholy—for Disneyland has waned but is not absent. It has been replaced by a bundle of more

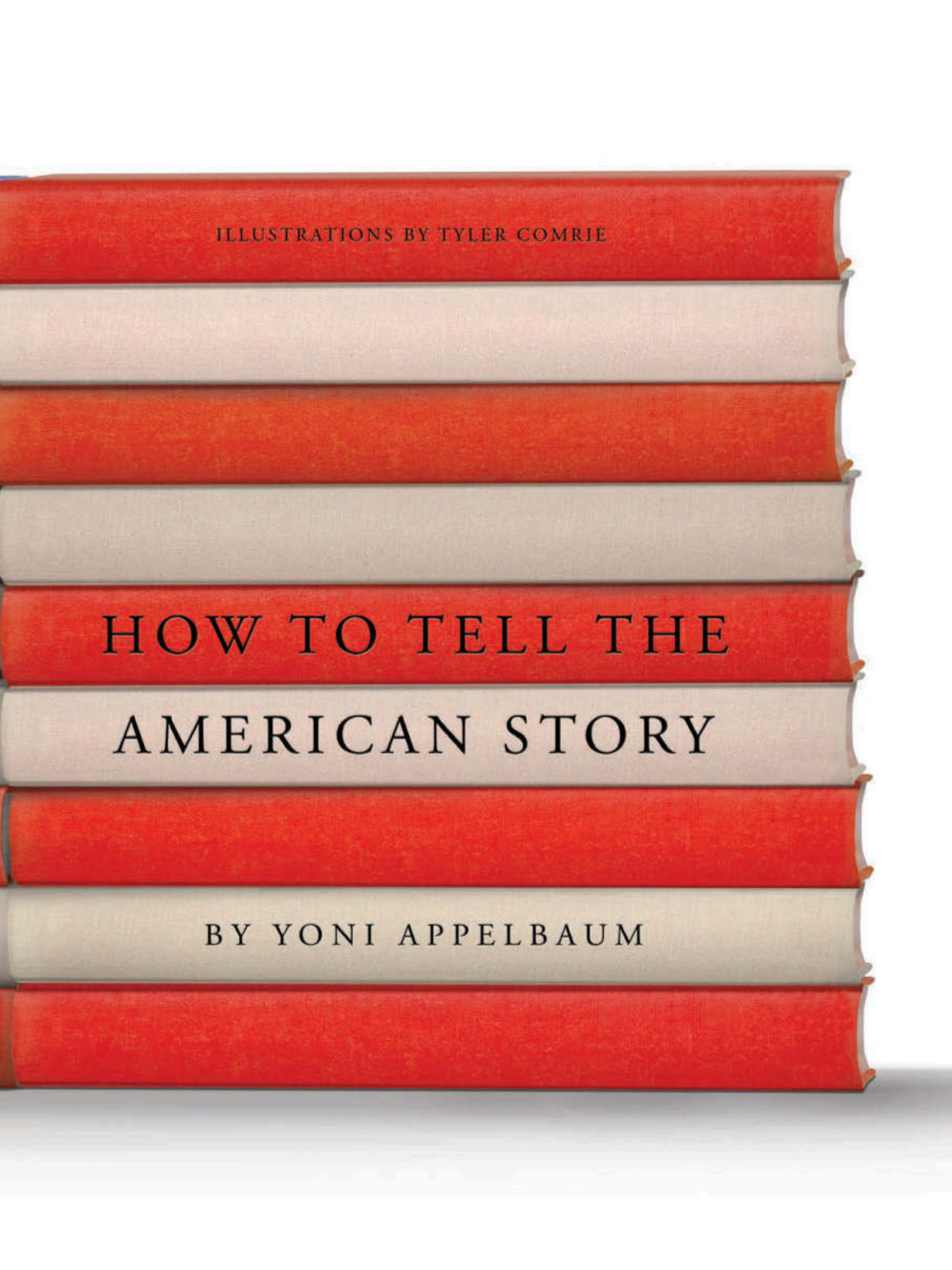
recent memories, of family and parenthood. But seeing the image now, nearly 65 years later, I am taken back to the castle undimmed, starlit, swan-lit. In Arbus's mind, I'm sure the photo was slightly bent, but to me it is accurate, straightforward, and ever so real, even if it is pseudo. *A*

Steve Martin is an actor, a musician, and a writer.





Finding a common history that's
both unsparing and unifying has
proved all but impossible in recent years.
It shouldn't be.

A stack of books with red and cream-colored spines. The books are arranged in a vertical stack, with the red spines alternating with the cream-colored spines. The text is printed on the cream-colored spines.

ILLUSTRATIONS BY TYLER COMRIE

HOW TO TELL THE
AMERICAN STORY

BY YONI APPELBAUM

On a July afternoon in 2019, I found myself in a large, sun-dappled room within one of America's great estates. An assemblage of distinguished jurists, Ivy League professors, nonprofit leaders, journalists, and theologians sat around me in a half circle. I was trying to be on my best behavior, but I blurted out a word dirty enough to make them blanch.

In my defense, I thought it was what I had been summoned there to do. An independent commission had spent the previous year contemplating the dismal state of American democracy. In dozens of focus groups that it had convened around the country, participants from across the political spectrum had been quick to identify sources of division—but requests to name the things that united them as Americans were generally met with nervous laughter. The commissioners themselves were convinced that the country needed a shared narrative, but were at odds with one another as to what it should be. And so they called in a handful of outsiders, myself among them, to help inject some fresh thinking into how to find one. The topic was so fraught that we all agreed, before attending, not to be quoted by name.

Our first exercise, the facilitator explained, was intended to build trust—listing words or concepts that all Americans could endorse, even if our definitions might vary. He uncapped his marker and looked around expectantly. I sat there, surrounded by an uncomfortable silence, searching for a word so anodyne that no one could possibly object. I thought about the acute improbability of my own existence. One of my grandfathers was born to Greek immigrants from a village in the mountains above Sparta, the other to Jewish immigrants from what is now Belarus. Other ancestors had fled aboard the Mayflower from the persecution of Puritans in England, aboard a steamship from pogroms in Ukraine, aboard a schooner from Spanish repression in Cuba. Where else would a life like mine even be possible?

But my loyalty to this country is not merely biographical. I've traveled widely enough abroad to acquire real gratitude for the liberties that Americans enjoy, and for what its ideals have meant to those in other lands. I've also seen enough of the United States to be painfully aware of how often we fail to live up to those ideals at home. I knew that we were there to figure out how to reconcile those realities, but our common love for this country seemed like the right place to start.

"Patriotism," I volunteered.

I had rolled a live grenade into the center of the room. One participant flinched, as if struck. Suddenly, everyone was talking at once, voices and tempers rising. One woman said the word made her feel excluded. Another said it connoted violence and racism. Still another participant was offended that anyone could be offended by the word. The facilitator declined to write *patriotism* on the easel. As the quarreling continued, I sat back, stunned. All of the people in the room had come here for the specific purpose of finding a common narrative. What hope did that project have if they could not even agree—each in their own way—on loving the country they were trying to save?

Americans, of course, have never exactly agreed on why this country was founded or what it stands for. Fierce arguments over those questions have long divided families and roiled politics, and even once produced a bloody civil war. But throughout the 19th century and well into the 20th, a simplistic patriotic narrative prevailed. "Providence designed that on this continent should be seen an example of democratic government," a textbook explained to young students in 1872, "which means government 'of the people, for the people, by the people.'"

Americans defined their nation in this way, by their commitment to a common creed—of equality, rights, and opportunity—and to a corresponding set of democratic ideals that they were modeling for the world. In practice, they generally fell short of those principles, sometimes seeming to pursue their abnegation more than their fulfillment. But the white men who built their fledgling republic around an idea, instead of around a common ancestry, opened the possibility that any who subscribed to its creed could become a citizen. Over time, other Americans demanded that the nation live up to its ideals and recognize their equality. For more than two centuries, our creedal nationalism has been a source of strength, binding together Americans of diverse faiths and backgrounds.

But lately, we have discovered that it is also a vulnerability. A nation defined by blood and soil—built around a shared religion or ethnicity—can survive divergent narratives. To a country built on an idea, though, and bound together by a shared understanding of our history, the inability to tell a common story might well prove fatal.

In recent decades, the traditional American story has come under sustained attack from both flanks. On the left, scholars and activists suspicious of nationalism have pushed to redefine the United States as a country exceptional mostly for its flaws and crimes. On the right, politicians and commentators hostile to diversity have sought to gloss over those sins and, more recently, lay claim to the nation on behalf of "heritage Americans." Unable to agree on how to tell our story, we have swiftly abandoned efforts to tell it at all. The hours devoted to social studies in schools are shrinking, and survey courses in American history are vanishing from college campuses. The signature event of the nation's 250th birthday might prove to be not a keynote speech or a patriotic pageant, but a no-holds-barred UFC fight on the South Lawn of the White House.

Most Americans are still proud of their country—although the percentage has been declining with each successive generation, and the decline is particularly steep among young progressives. If *patriotism* is going to be a word that can be used in polite company, then we will need to figure out how to tell the story of ourselves. Because without a coherent national story, we will fail to be a coherent nation.

Our present disagreements would have astonished the historians of the mid-20th century, who found America more remarkable for its consensus than for its conflicts. Americans, the historian Louis Hartz argued, embraced a common liberal tradition, built around a respect for democracy, property, and individual liberty. Many of the scholars in this Cold War—era

consensus school were, like Hartz, the children of Jewish immigrants who had found in America a vital refuge, and they wanted to explain its exceptionality. They held a flattering mirror up to the country. Their books became best sellers, they wrote for popular magazines, and they advised prominent politicians.

But theirs was hardly the whole story. In the 1960s, as women and people of color entered the academy in larger numbers, they set about telling the stories that the consensus school had glossed over or ignored. The explosion of scholarship they produced was a tremendous boon for history, the Harvard historian Jill Lepore told me, widening our understanding of our past. The focus of academics swung to class, race, and gender, to giving voice to the voiceless and documenting injustices. No single national story seemed capable of capturing the full diversity of America, and it seemed wrong to even try. “People were suspicious of any national story as the handmaiden of ethnic nationalism, or white nationalism,” Lepore explained. Patriotic histories, after all, had long been used to buttress the oppressive systems that these scholars now sought to unmask.

As professors pursued the separate histories of various groups, uncovering neglected stories and challenging facile assumptions, they made comparatively little effort to assemble the pieces into a comprehensible narrative. Scholars largely stopped writing single-volume histories of the United States.

The new histories disagreed with the mid-century consensus school less over the facts than over which ones to emphasize, and how to string them together into a story. Take the simple question of democracy. In Revolutionary America, the franchise was extraordinarily widespread; more than half of adult white men could vote, while in England only about one in seven could do the same. And in the young republic, enfranchisement quickly expanded further, with perhaps 80 percent of adult white men—90 percent in some states—coming to hold the right to vote. This was truly an unprecedentedly broad form of democracy. It was also one that almost entirely excluded women, who, under the doctrine of coverture, had their legal personhood merged into that of their husbands; Black Americans, most of whom were enslaved; and Native Americans, denied citizenship in their own land. The fight to expand the franchise produced a long, at times blood-drenched struggle that has not yet ended. Previous historians had tended to highlight the breadth of the franchise. Now a new generation instead tallied the damage of disenfranchisement, and told the stories of the individuals and groups fighting to secure the right to vote.

The history wars soon spilled beyond college campuses, spreading to high schools and even grade schools. In 1991, the George H. W. Bush administration set out to develop common history standards, and the chair of the National Endowment for the Humanities, Lynne Cheney, asked a center at UCLA to produce them. But when conservatives reviewed the guidelines, which reflected the latest scholarship, they did not like what they found. Cheney denounced the standards for emphasizing America’s failings over its achievements, and Rush Limbaugh said that they aimed to teach students “that America is a rotten place.” The Senate voted to reject the standards, 99–1.

By 2001, when Bush’s son and Cheney’s husband came into office, they were painfully aware of just how contentious a topic history could be. So as their administration worked with Congress to create the tough accountability framework of No Child Left Behind, they delicately set the question of how to teach history to the side. NCLB held schools responsible for their students’ performance on standardized tests, but only in English and math. There was no such exam for history—less because reformers cared too little about it than because, ironically, everyone cared too much to agree on what should be tested.

That’s been bad for American education, and worse for America. Schools that struggled to make the grade on math and English swiftly cut back on other subjects to compensate. At the elementary level, the largest decreases came in the time devoted to social studies,

The signature event of the nation’s 250th birthday might prove to be a no-holds-barred UFC fight on the White House lawn.

which within a few years dropped by a third, or 76 minutes each week. The high-school history classroom, meanwhile, became the safest place to park the football coach, so that he could earn a full-time salary safely removed from the subjects tested under NCLB. Within a decade, more than a third of social-studies educators were coaching sports or teaching phys ed. They had fewer years of experience and were far more reliant on textbooks and worksheets than their less athletic colleagues, who leaned more heavily on primary sources. Students joked that all of their history teachers had the same first name: Coach. States have since haltingly rolled out standards for history education, but after 30 years of reform, students’ performance on history exams has slightly declined—just 14 percent are rated proficient.

The abandonment of the effort to tell the American story is hardly limited to high schools or universities. Nowhere is it more evident, in fact, than in the preparations for America’s

250th birthday. When the Biden administration took over the nascent project, it simply punted on the question of how to create something unifying. The federal Semiquincentennial Commission instead invited people to record their personal history, on the theory that “your story is America’s story.” Local institutions were encouraged to plan events that would speak to their particular communities.

Donald Trump returned to office in 2025 excited to put his own stamp on the occasion. But he appears to have little notion of precisely what we should be honoring. It is hard to discern any message, beyond the president’s love of spectacle and celebrity, from a mixed-martial-arts bout on the South Lawn; or a Formula 1 race in Washington, D.C.; or a colossal archway near the entrance to Arlington National Cemetery. Trump’s proposal for a National Garden of American Heroes, where visitors could commune with statues of 250 historic figures, is simply bewildering. The list of honorees bears less resemblance to a pantheon collectively embodying the American idea than to the setup of a bad joke: Davy Crockett, Julia Child, and Kobe Bryant walk into a bar ...

It’s our 250th birthday, and no one seems to know what we’re celebrating.

Johann Neem was not quite 3 years old when his parents left Mumbai for San Francisco in 1976. He landed in a world of tantalizing possibility—that people could become better, freer, more prosperous. And as he grew up, eating masala dosas and also Thanksgiving turkey, he understood that he was at once an Indian immigrant and fully American. “Pretty astounding, right?” he told me. “A claim that someone from South Asia can come to this country and become American.”

That claim has astounded new arrivals from the start. President John Quincy Adams, a popular anecdote relates, once asked an Irishman how he liked the United States. “Indeed, sir,” he replied, “I like it very much. I like it so much, that I intend soon, to become a native!” The story was retold in jest, but it contained a deep truth. You had to be born an Irishman, but, as President Ronald Reagan put it, “anyone, from any corner of the Earth, can come to live in America and become an American.”

Neem is now a historian at Western Washington University, where he has watched the erosion of that promise in dismay. Last year, he delivered the annual lecture on the state of the discipline to the American Historical Association, lamenting the loss of a common and inclusive narrative. (It drew furious responses, including from one leftist scholar who accused him of “retreat, if not outright capitulation” to the fell logic of nationalism.) In recent decades, Neem told me, there have been three competing versions of the American story. The first is grounded in the notion that the United States is a work in progress. This approach mixes the self-flattery of some older histories with frank acknowledgment of the many ways in which America has fallen short of its ideals, incorporating the critical scholarship of recent decades. It approaches the American story as an ongoing struggle between our best impulses

The list of honorees sounds like the setup of a bad joke: Davy Crockett, Julia Child, and Kobe Bryant walk into a bar ...

and our worst. Neem calls this approach the mainstream school, because it is how most Americans still think about their country, even though it has fallen from favor on campus.

On the left, an approach that Neem terms *post-American* has taken root, pushing the arguments of the 1970s in an ever more emphatic direction. The United States was built on racism and genocide, it contends, a settler-colonial nation founded in white supremacy, irredeemably illiberal and oppressive. Many scholars who pursue this approach actively seek to decenter the nation in their narratives. They find no common inspiration to be taken from this history, only a litany of sins requiring atonement.

The right, meanwhile, is pursuing what Neem calls a *hyper-American* approach—fueled in part by opposition to the post-American turn on the left. In some ways, the histories of this school call back to those written in the 19th century, casting the country’s origin as providential—not quite an immaculate conception, but not far off—and emphasizing the morality and timelessness of America’s founding creed. Slavery, in their telling, was not a system on which the country was built, but a deviation from the immutable truths on which it was founded. To reckon too closely with the darker chapters of our past, they suggest, is to risk disenchanting the nation. Trump’s 1776 Commission, typically, called for approaching American history “with reverence and love.”

Last July, Vice President Vance joined the debate, attacking then-New York City mayoral candidate Zohran Mamdani for saying that he is “proud of our country even as we constantly strive to make it better.” To Vance, Mamdani’s words failed to display the gratitude and deference that he believes immigrants like Mamdani ought to show—not only to the American past but also to past Americans. “Who the hell do these people think they are?” he asked. Then he took things one step further. “America is not just an idea,” Vance declared, contending instead that “we’re a particular place, with a particular people.”

Neem discerns within all of this a strange convergence, as both the far right and the far left have come to agree that the history of the United States has been defined by whiteness. The left no longer believes that immigrants of diverse backgrounds should assimilate themselves into a national culture tainted by white supremacy, while the right views immigrants' very presence in the country as a threat to that same national culture. Naturalized citizens have a particular commitment to the American project—they tend to be more patriotic than native-born Americans, more trusting in our institutions, and more likely to believe that the world would be better off if people elsewhere resembled Americans. But as our national story narrows, it has begun to exclude them. "I've seen a change on both ends that makes it harder for someone like me to be an American," Neem said.

Amid all the fracture and contention, though, are some recent signs that Americans are again seeking a way to tell an inclusive national story. As progressives have begun to fear that the American system might in fact be lost, many have rediscovered its virtues. In 2016, as Trump barreled toward the White House, Khizr Khan brandished a pocket Constitution at the Democratic National Convention to raucous applause from Hillary Clinton and Bernie Sanders supporters alike. During Trump's first term, the Baby Boomers who once burned flags in youthful rebellion marched off to join the Resistance wrapped in the Stars and Stripes. In his second, the "No Kings" rallies have looked back to the founding era for inspiration.

Historians, many of whom had spent decades tearing apart patriotic myths and decentering the nation-state, awoke to discover that they had, in effect, ceded the task of telling the

American story to the likes of Bill O'Reilly and Newt Gingrich. A few, perhaps emboldened by the growing popular hunger for a narrative, began to produce accounts grounded in the mainstream school, wrestling with America's defects while still recognizing its ideals. In 2018, Jill Lepore published *These Truths*, the sort of sweeping single-volume history of the nation that no prominent scholar had attempted in generations. The following year, a Boston College history professor named Heather Cox Richardson launched a newsletter on the premise that "to understand the present, we have to understand how we got here," and swiftly became the most successful author on Substack.

This is not to say that any agreement on the American project is about to be found. From the vantage point of some on the left, Trump has looked less like a threat to America's virtues than a confirmation of its vices, decisive evidence that the United States has been a white-supremacist state all along. In *The New York Times*' "The 1619 Project," the journalist Nikole Hannah-Jones argued that the American story began not in 1776 but in 1619, with the advent of slavery. The contributions of Black Americans and the consequences of slavery belong "at the very center of our national narrative," she claimed.

Critics, some eminent historians among them, were swift to note that Hannah-Jones's history was reductive and, in places, simply wrong. Trump found in "The 1619 Project" a useful foil, attacking it as "toxic propaganda, ideological poison that, if not removed, will dissolve the civic bonds that tie us together." But although her account of America's origins was extremely gloomy, Hannah-Jones also offered a more optimistic view of the country's progress through the ensuing centuries. The project chronicled "the struggle of Black Americans to perfect these ideals of liberty, freedom, equality in the law, equality in society," she told me. "And that's a redemptive, unifying narrative," albeit not one that she is sure the nation is ready to accept. Notably, Hannah-Jones's essay



ends with her wish that she could tell her younger self to “boldly, proudly, draw the stars and those stripes of the American flag.”

Conservatives frequently warn that the close study of the darkest chapters of our past will erode any sense of patriotism. In Hannah-Jones’s case, at least, it had the opposite effect. One question she’d sought to answer, as she researched her essay, was why newly emancipated slaves did not leave the country that had so wronged them, as she assumed they would have wanted to do. She read their accounts and saw them argue that, at the moment they had finally gained rights and citizenship, they could not abandon the only land they had ever known. They resolved to stay and to make the nation what it could and should have been. “I actually did find that really inspiring,” she told me. “And I think that’s the first time I ever felt I could see a path to patriotism.”

After Lepore published *These Truths*, she was astonished by the number of readers who reached out to tell her what the book meant to them. One woman wrote to say that she had bought it to study for her citizenship exam but, enthralled, kept reading. “I really feel like I belong here now,” she wrote, “because I understand the whole journey that is the story of this land and this people and these ideas and this country.” Most significantly, Lepore found that readers wanted to know the full story of their country—the progress and the revanchism, the beauty and the ugliness, the racial massacres and the Indian New Deal.

The Trump administration seems allergic to this kind of complexity. Last March, it issued an executive order on “restoring truth and sanity to American history.” Among other measures, it instructed the National Park Service to remove signs that “inappropriately disparage” historical figures instead of focusing on the “greatness” of American achievements. A display on George Washington’s slaves came down in Philadelphia; an exhibit at the Grand Canyon was stripped of a passage noting that federal officials had “pushed tribes off their land” to establish the park.

Deleting accounts of the past not because they are false but because they are true betrays a curious lack of confidence. Do the censors fear that Americans will cease to love their country once they know the full story?

The evidence suggests otherwise. Large majorities of Americans prefer history that challenges what they know over accounts that reinforce it. By an almost nine-to-one margin, they think it’s at least as important to learn about other racial and ethnic communities as about their own. And they overwhelmingly agree on the importance of learning about past harms, even when doing so makes them uncomfortable. “I’ve been on the road, literally, for seven years since the project came out, in every type of community,” Hannah-Jones told me. “And I’ve never had someone walk away and say they hate this country. They say they’re ashamed of things this country has done, that they’re deeply disappointed, and they want to see the country be better.” Americans appear aligned not with the unquestioning patriotism of the naval hero Stephen Decatur, who was said to have declared, “My country, right or

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wrong,” but with the deeper patriotism of the Reconstruction-era Senator Carl Schurz, who added: “If right, to be kept right; and if wrong, to be set right.”

The American story—the whole American story—deserves to be told. People are hungry to hear it. History, Neem told me, shapes how we understand the moment we’re living in, and “makes it possible for us to see where we’re going.” As our understanding of the past constantly shifts, how we choose to retell our story matters. When the historical revolution of the 1960s and ’70s insisted that we contend with America’s bigotry and exclusion, Neem said, the mainstream narrative evolved to give us a story in which “overcoming racism was to become more American.” Our nation is still evolving; whether the story we tell ourselves can continue to evolve along with it remains to be seen.

I asked Lepore if the United States could cohere without a common narrative. “Everything ends,” she replied, “and this could be a part of what unravels it.” But Neem was more hopeful. “Realizing what we’re losing might enable us to remember the America we want,” he said.

Just down the street from where I live lies one of America’s smallest national cemeteries. On a bright July morning several years ago, I visited it with my daughter, on the anniversary of the Civil War battle it commemorates. Together with a handful of neighbors, we stuck small American flags by the marble headstones of 40 men and boys who, far from their homes, fought in defense of the idea that all are created equal, bound together in a common project. They won the battle but lost their lives. For us, the living, their unfinished work remains. *A*

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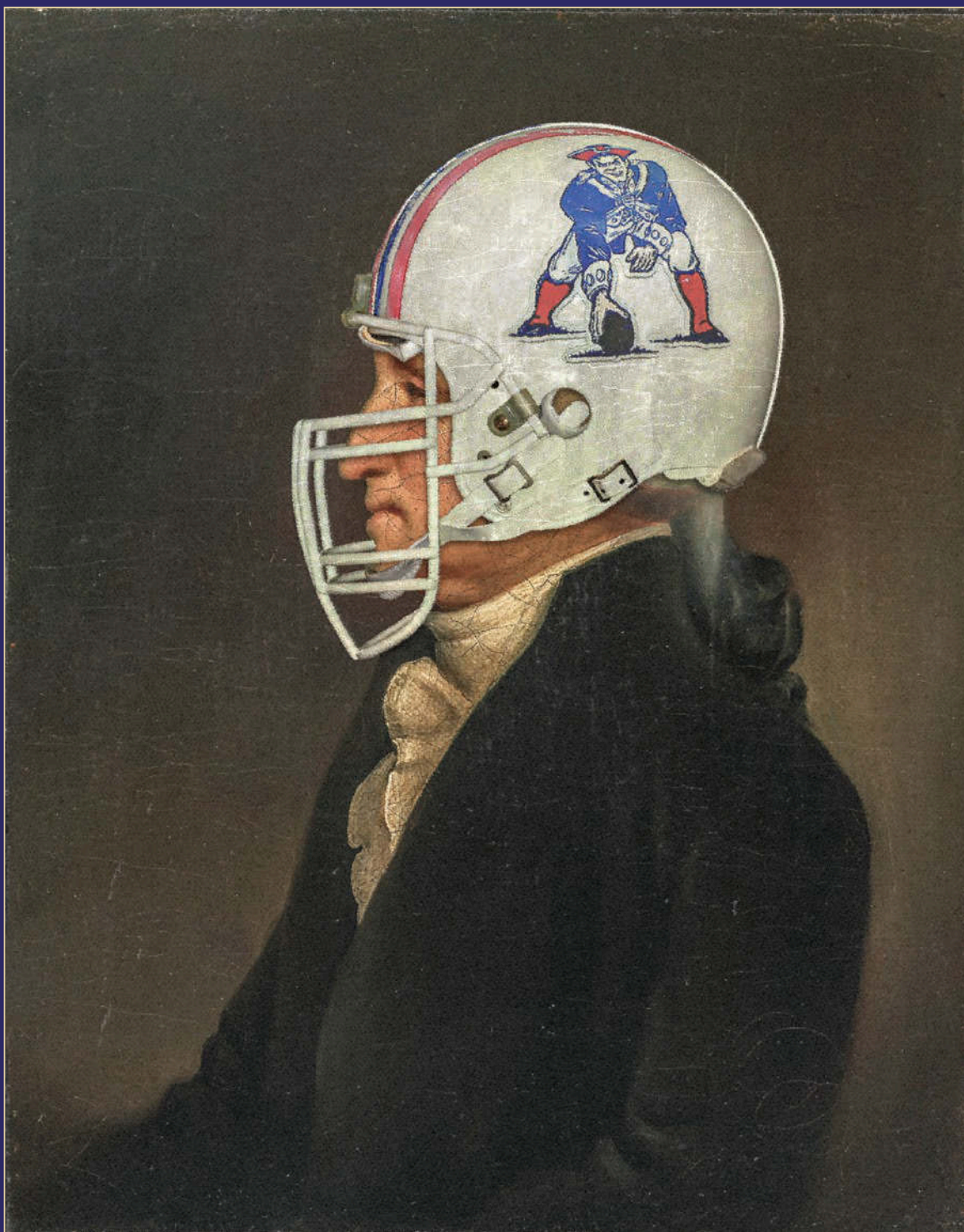


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THE REBELLIOUS ORIGINS OF AMERICAN SPORTS

FROM THE BEGINNING, PATRIOTISM AND PLAY
HAVE BEEN INEXTRICABLY LINKED.



BY SALLY JENKINS

ILLUSTRATION BY PAUL SPELLA

T

he sentry box at the royal governor's residence in Boston was a too-inviting target for young Americans with an urge to kick, throw, or swing at something British. The regiments who occupied the city to enforce the Crown's taxation were accustomed to dodging snowballs, oyster shells, and burning coals. Then, one January day in 1769, a gang of boys

found a novel form of harassment: They launched an unruly game of "foot-ball" in the street facing the sentry box. As the boys played, the action came ever closer to grazing the redcoat on duty. What happened next infuriated Royal Governor Sir Francis Bernard, a meaty-faced, tilt-chinned baronet. Somehow, probably by piling into it, the boys toppled the sentry box onto the street.

That foot-ball game was more than just a "little rude boyish trick," as a newspaper account, often attributed to Samuel Adams, put it. It was a barrier-crashing act, an early sign of a belligerently rule-testing national character. To Bernard, it was "another Proof of the Necessity of Regular Troops, to keep the Inhabitants in Order."

But keeping young Bostonians in order wasn't so easy. In February 1770, another throng of boys, which may have included Paul Revere Jr., amused themselves in the street by practicing their aim with rocks and snowballs, which they threw at a Loyalist merchant's windows. When their stones began hitting people *inside* the house, a British customs agent fired a shotgun at the boys, killing an 11-year-old named Christopher Seider. Just a week later, another street altercation resulted in the Boston Massacre, immortalized in Paul Revere Sr.'s engraving. "As Boston simmered on the eve of Revolution," the scholar Daryl Leeworthy has observed, "even little things like footballs kicked at soldiers could bring the city dangerously close to the edge."

Viewed from the present, these young athlete-patriots seem to possess a quintessentially American mix of pride, irreverence, and subversion. The Sons of Liberty channeled these energies in the fight for independence from England, but the energies hardly dissipated with the signing of the Treaty of Paris. Instead, our rebellious, rambunctious approach to athletic endeavor became part of the American ethos. You can see it in the sports we play and the way we play them. You can even see it in the way we spectate and celebrate. Victory is marked by the scaling of lamp-posts (Philadelphia), drunken parading through the streets (and a river, in Boston), and light property damage (everywhere). To understand America as it marks a big birthday, you could do far worse than consider its long history of sport, and of fandom.

LONG BEFORE THE WAR for independence began, colonists played with a streak of exploratory defiance, rebelling against the constraints of their own Puritan governors. The first mention of an athletic contest in colonial America comes from the separatist Pilgrim leader William Bradford, whose journal records that in 1621—just a year after the Mayflower landed—he disciplined a group of young men for evading work on Christmas to instead engage in games such as "pitching the bar," a contest to see who could throw a heavy rod the farthest.

Settlers may have been inspired to new forms of play by their encounters with members of the Wampanoag Nation, who had occupied coastal Massachusetts for some 12,000 years. In 1634, a colonist named William Wood wrote about their exuberant, rugby-like games of "footeball" that could last for a mile along the flat beaches, in which they displayed "swift footemanship" and "curious tossings of their Ball."

By 1735, rowdy games of foot-ball were already associated with political rivalries in Boston. During elections, these games were used to express "the animosities of several contending parties," *The New England Weekly Journal* reported. The newspaper added, "Whilst these opposite sets of angry men are playing at football, they will break all the windows and do more hurt than their pretended zeal for the nation will ever make amends for." The statement could apply today.

Once the Revolution was launched, even General George Washington had difficulty containing the games of his troops. According to soldiers, including the painter John Trumbull, who served during the siege of Boston in 1775, Continental Army officers offered small rewards (usually alcohol) for the retrieval of any cannonballs fired from British batteries at the American lines. This set off daring races to pick up the ordnance. During a British cannonade at Roxbury in July 1775, it became something of a spectator sport to watch Yanks vie to pick up the balls and carry them to officers. "It is diverting to see our people contending for the balls as they roll along," one witness wrote. Soon, however, the game became dangerous, as soldiers began trying to stop the cannon shot with their feet, like soccer balls. This led to terrible wounds. "Several brave lads lost their feet, which were crushed by the weight of the rolling shot," Trumbull related. The reward offer was withdrawn.

Washington himself was a formidable athlete. According to a French officer who visited the general's headquarters, Washington "sometimes throws and catches a ball for whole hours" with his men. On at least one occasion, he joined them at Valley Forge in a game of "wicket," a kind of poor man's cricket that didn't require a groomed lawn or special equipment. And he was apparently a champion at pitching the bar. The artist Charles Willson Peale related that one day, before the outbreak of the war, Washington was strolling around Mount Vernon when he came upon some young men playing the game. Washington asked where the farthest throw was marked and then, without taking off his coat, smiled and heaved the bar. It "whizzed through the air, striking the ground far, very far, beyond our utmost limits," according to Peale. As the other players gaped, Washington said, "When you beat my pitch, young gentlemen, I'll try again," and strolled away.

With Washington's encouragement, the men of the Continental Army became sports-mad. Diaries and letters refer to a dizzying variety of contests they played to break up the tedium of camp. A lieutenant named Ebenezer Elmer made repeated references to "ball play" and to a contact game called "whirl," in which another man gave him "a severe blow on my mouth which cut my lip, and came near to dislocating my under jaw." One of Nathan Hale's diary entries for 1775 simply recorded, "Clean'd my gun—pld some football, & some checquers."

PREVIOUS PAGE: HERITAGE IMAGES / GETTY; CONNECT IMAGES / GETTY; JIM DAVIS / THE BOSTON GLOBE / GETTY

These pickup games seem to have exemplified the spirit that the British poet W. H. Auden would later describe as “the peculiar American mixture of Puritan conscience and democratic license”: They were conducted according to agreed-upon rules, yet those rules were highly flexible depending on the players’ surroundings and the implements at hand. As the scholar Thomas L. Altherr wrote in an authoritative work on early American sport, “A Place Leavel Enough to Play Ball,” the games were makeshift affairs that married old English-village games to the New World landscape. Americans played “tip cat,” which involved using a long stick to flip a short piece of wood in the air and bat it. They played “long bullets,” a bowling contest. They played rounders, trap ball, base, baste, three o’cat, sting ball, barn ball. Game equipment was fashioned from whatever was available—tree branches; broom handles; planks; rocks; stumps; stakes; and balls of rags, feathers, or buckshot covered in leather.

By 1779, Washington had grown concerned that his men were finding excuses to avoid duty in order to play. Inspecting a camp near West Point during what were supposed to be drilling hours, he discovered that scores of them were instead rampantly chasing after balls. Washington issued an order saying that soldiers could not shirk military duty by claiming inadequate shoes or clothing when they had just been “employed at games of exercise much more violent.” Washington was late to notice what Abigail Adams already had. “This continent has paid thousands to officers and men who have been loitering about playing foot-ball and nine pins, and doing their own private business whilst they ought to have been defending our forts,” she wrote to her husband in 1777.

AMERICAN GAMES DIDN’T EVOLVE into the more formal exercises we now recognize, with demarcated fields, written rules, clocks, and sophisticated strategies and counterstrategies, until the late 19th century. With the West largely closed, and with machines outstripping bodies, how could American men prove their manhood? One answer: maul each other.

Beloved of boys and young men on Boston Common in the 1860s was “punk,” a version of dodgeball in which they hurled a semisoft homemade ball at fellow competitors with the intention of “plugging” someone, and scrimmaged for the ball until a new possessor turned on another human target.

Then there were the mass “rushes” that were early forerunners of American football, in which whole classes at Harvard, Yale, and Princeton battled for possession of a field. From 1862 to 1865, about 50 boys who frequented Boston Common belonged to a short-lived institution called the Oneida Football Club, most of them Brahmin sons bound for Harvard. For three years they reigned supreme on the Common, and they have been identified by some scholars as perhaps the first organized ball team in America. One of

their balls is preserved in Boston. It doesn’t resemble anything used in any other game; it’s seamed, but neither truly round nor oval.

Even basketball began as a game in which young men pushed others aside to reach a goal. James Naismith first presented it as a winter-semester activity at Springfield College during a blizzard in 1891. Growing up in Ontario, Naismith had played “duck on a rock,” a game that involved tossing a rock in high, arcing throws at a target stone set on a tree stump. Naismith improvised a version of it for Springfield students by nailing up two peach baskets

in the gymnasium, dividing the class into two teams, and telling them to throw a ball into their opponent’s basket. But as soon as he blew the whistle, “the boys began tackling, kicking, and punching in the clinches; they ended up in a free-for-all in the middle of the gym floor,” Naismith recalled in a radio interview toward the end of his life. “Before I could pull them apart, one boy was knocked out, several of them had black eyes, and one of them had a dislocated shoulder. It certainly was murder.” Naismith had to ban running on the court until he could develop some rules to curb the violence.

In the 20th century, there was an unmistakable sense of accelerated growth in American play that mirrored the country’s expansion. This was an era of empire. Every nation uses sport as an identity-forming exercise, but only modern Americans play with such an aggressive sense of clearing out space. The deepest point of the center-field home-run

fence at Boston’s Fenway Park, built in 1912, is 420 feet—150 feet deeper than the boundary of a cricket ground.

Cricket had never taken hold in America. According to James D’Wolf Lovett, a Boston athlete of the Civil War era, “Somehow American soil is not congenial” for it. But it was more than just the dirt: The length of a cricket match, which could last two days, was utterly impractical for hardworking, efficiency-minded Americans, especially as the nation’s modern economy emerged.

More congenial to the American mindset was football. In 1903, Harvard Stadium was completed; it used a new technique of reinforced concrete to accommodate crowds of 25,000 or more. In 1907, in the ultimate act of seizing ground, the forward pass was developed by the marvelously experimental Pop Warner-coached teams of the Carlisle Indian Industrial School, which opened the field to ever more creative strategy, and made football more popular. Every form of football, from Gaelic to Australian, involves gaining ground, but only in our version can a competitor gain 50 yards at a time by flinging the ball downfield—the forward pass, in all its wild optimism, is a purely American invention.

In 1908, all of America went aloft when the federal government contracted with the Wright brothers to produce the fixed-wing aircraft. At the same time, Henry Ford revolutionized the automobile with the first mass-produced Model Ts. This laid the groundwork for the great rituals of the American stadium experience: the parking-lot tailgate and the military flyover.



EVEN BASKETBALL, INVENTED BY JAMES NAISMITH IN 1891, BEGAN AS A GAME IN WHICH YOUNG MEN PUSHED OTHERS ASIDE TO REACH A GOAL.

Before Game 1 of the 1918 World Series, between the Boston Red Sox and the Chicago Cubs, 60 U.S. Army biplanes roared over Comiskey Park, in what is believed to be the first such demonstration ever performed above a stadium. It was intended to bolster Americans' morale, show off their combat strength in World War I, and evoke a fighting spirit. It succeeded: As Babe Ruth worked on a shutout for the Red Sox, feelings ran so high that the entire stadium joined in singing "The Star-Spangled Banner" during the seventh-inning stretch, long before singing the song at the ballpark was *de rigueur*. (Later in the series, soldiers at Camp Devens, near Boston, were so anxious for updates that a flyover of another sort was employed: Military carrier pigeons flew between Fenway and the camp, relaying the score.)

The first American tailgate may well have been at the Battle of Bull Run, in 1861, when civilians packed picnics to watch Union and Confederate troops fire on each other. But Ford's invention was what made it into an American pastime.

The New York Times described the pregame crowd at the 1906 Harvard-Yale football game: "Small parties of automobilists eating tempting viands that had been brought in hampers spread out in picnic fashion on a table cloth on the ground."

By mid-century, the mass stadium spectacle was a firmly established American ritual—for white Americans, at least. The breaking of the color line in the major pastimes, and the desegregation of bleachers, concessions, and bathrooms, was slow and painful work, sometimes slowest in the oldest cities.

Players themselves were instrumental in pressing their teams, leagues, and cities to live up to the nation's founding ideals. While delivering 11 NBA championships for the Boston Celtics from 1956 to 1969, Bill Russell led boycotts, marched on Washington with Martin Luther King Jr., protested segregation in Boston schools, and endured the vandalizing of his home; intruders smashed his trophy case, spray-painted epithets on his walls, and defecated in his bed. When the Celtics named him to succeed Red Auerbach in 1966, he became the first Black head coach in a modern major American sport.

TODAY, AMERICAN STADIUMS have become immense, many of them too large to be situated in the cities that their teams represent, moored instead on suburban plains or on the outer, warehouse-populated margins. It's therefore remarkable, the degree to which they're still hothouses of cultural memory, and not just through quaint reenactments, such as the New England Patriots' "End Zone Militia": men in tricorn hats firing muskets after touchdowns at Gillette Stadium (in suburban Foxborough). More is going on in the parking-lot tailgates than just swilling by hardy



A PHILADELPHIA EAGLES FAN CELEBRATES THE TEAM'S VICTORY IN SUPER BOWL LII.

fans huddled around weak charcoal-grill fires as they get day-drunk headaches. In 2025, attendance at Major League Baseball games was more than 71 million; 22 million at NBA arenas; and about 19 million at NFL stadiums. Why do so many of us go to such trouble and expense? A strong desire to relive our national story seems to be one answer.

American sports enact "the liturgy of empire," Tim Suttle, a Kansas pastor and essayist, has written. The modern stadium spectacle is rife with enormous flags, salutes to service members, and flyovers by supersonic warplanes. Fans feel they are active participants in the quest for victory. Roaring spectators are more involved than the word *fan* allows; we fervently believe that we're "contributing psychic and emotional energy to a prospective victory," as the scholars Tonya Williams Bradford and John Sherry have put it. Any fan of an opposing team who has dared to fly their colors at a stadium in Boston, Philadelphia, or New York can attest to this.

So can anyone who followed the celebrations after the Philadelphia Eagles' Super Bowl triumphs in 2018 and 2025. Even in victory, Eagles fans are their bellicose selves. Light poles were scaled (and traffic lights torn down) and windshields busted. During the team's most recent procession, up Broad Street toward Ben Franklin Parkway, general manager Howie Roseman was hit in the head by a beer, leaving a half-moon cut on his forehead.

Something else distinguishes our forms of play, too: the extent to which the contests lend themselves to retellings. American sports have "a special, intensified narrativity," in the phrase of the NFL player turned historian Michael Oriard. Play in soccer, rugby, and cricket is continuous, often indeterminate. American games tend to have neat structures with a beginning, a middle, and an end, and stakes that ratchet accordingly, with a "more pronounced rhythm or pace, and a dramatic structure (situation, rising action, climax, and denouement)," Oriard writes in his book *Reading Football*. In a sense, they're stories that we tell ourselves about who are—or would like to be.

But the simple truth is that American sports began as wildflowers. They were the products of seeds blown on the wind and buried in the mud until strange green shoots jumped up out of the ground. They were initially cultivated by men with foaming seas at their back and seemingly endless forests in front of them, who had an instinct to swat something—hard enough to sail over rail fences and into that unending wood. *A*

Sally Jenkins is a staff writer at The Atlantic.

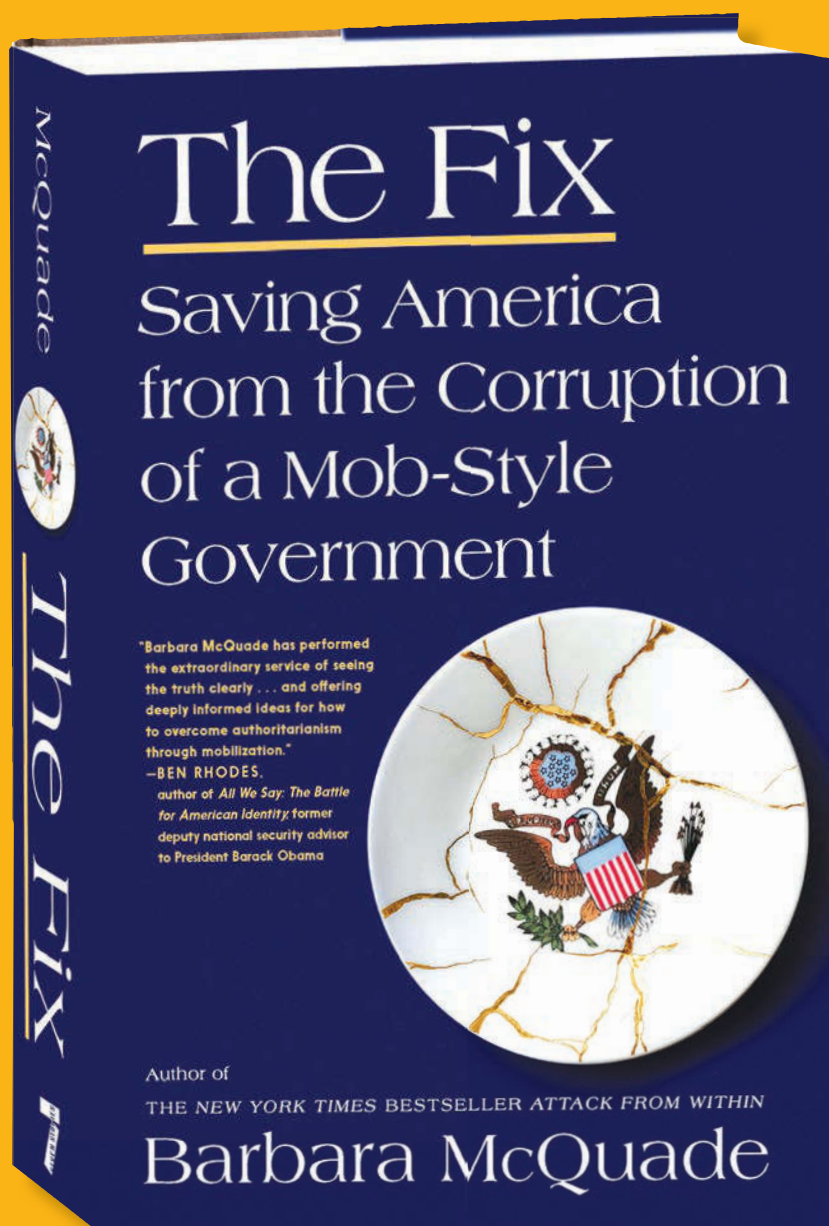
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HOW
BRITAIN
BECAME
AS
POOR AS
MISSISSIPPI

A case study in self-sabotage

BY IDREES KAHLOON

W

ho broke Britain? Someone—or something—must have. The past 18 years, enough time for a whole lost generation to be born and brought up, have yielded nothing but stagnation and mass disillusionment. In 2007, before the global financial crisis, Britain was at its postimperial zenith. Median household income had just surpassed that of Germany. A pound was worth more than \$2, and London was arguably displacing New York as

the center of international banking.

But since then, Britain has been left behind. The country's output per person is now only just above that of Mississippi, America's poorest state—and that slight lead is only achieved thanks to London. Outside the capital, in places where tourists do not visit, living standards fall well below Mississippi's. Brits visiting the United States find that their currency has depreciated to the point where the pound today buys only about \$1.35. British wages have lagged well behind those in the U.S., and also those in Germany, France, the Netherlands, Denmark; once you account for inflation, they've barely grown at all. Within the next decade, the typical Pole will have a standard of living equal to the typical Brit, if current trends continue.

One generation ago, Britain was a major global power; today, it is a middling one, gripped by sclerosis. Taxation is at the highest level since World War II, yet public services have deteriorated. The National Health Service, the celebrated pillar of the British cradle-to-grave welfare state, has a backlog of 6 million patients—almost a tenth of the population—waiting for treatment. The health service now has to spend more money settling maternity-malpractice claims than it does on actually providing maternity care. Many Brits can neither obtain an appointment with a publicly funded dentist nor afford a private one; in a 2023 survey, one in 10 reported doing DIY dental work, in extreme cases extracting their own teeth or gluing broken crowns back together.

Incomes can be shockingly low: Junior doctors recently went on strike for the 15th time in three years over their salaries, which start at just £38,800; the median salary for British civil servants is £35,680. In April, amid the Iran conflict, the *Daily Mail* pounced on Prime Minister Keir Starmer for vacationing in Valencia, Spain, at what the tabloid described as a luxury hotel, costing £200 a night.

Some in Britain blame rotten luck—the 2008 financial crash, the coronavirus pandemic, an energy crisis after Russia invaded Ukraine. But other countries endured these challenges too. What differentiated Britain was its self-sabotaging responses to these and other problems. Brexit is the most famous example, but hardly the only one. Bad choices, beginning just after the financial crisis, begot worse ones. As public disillusionment has grown, politicians have been rotated swiftly in and out of power, abruptly terminating whatever policies they had started. Six different prime ministers have governed since the 2010 general election. They do not seem to be getting more talented over time. Less than two years after Starmer's Labour Party took power, his net approval

rating has plunged to minus 42 points. He is widely expected to resign this year, and may have done so by the time you read this.

The country's downward slide has been consistent in one respect: As Britain has become more and more aware of its diminishment, it has retreated ever more fully into a defensive crouch. Politics have become zero-sum, descending into fights over who has robbed whom. Suspicion has fallen, above all, on immigrants, whom both major parties have turned against. There is still an enduring strain of British exceptionalism, quieter and more understated than the American version, which suggests that by retreating inward, Britain can make itself great again. Astonishingly, or perhaps predictably, it is growing stronger as the country's problems get worse.

IN FAIRNESS, the 2008 financial crisis hit Britain especially hard. In the 1990s, both the Tories and Tony Blair's "New Labour" Party made the same bet: Britain was to be a postindustrial, services-based economy, anchored in finance. Tax receipts from a booming London would be redistributed to lagging regions in the old industrial heartland, helping to renew them. Then came 2008, and London's financial industry cratered.

But the government's actions during and after the crisis compounded the damage. Rather than increase spending to revive depressed demand, as modern Keynesians would counsel, the government, then led by Conservative Prime Minister David Cameron, opted to slash budgets as revenue plunged. The theory was that fiscal discipline—cutting spending more sharply than Britain's peer countries—would inspire confidence and spur growth. At the time,

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deficits and debt were seen as immoral; unlike profligate Greece, Britain would manage its affairs prudently.

The promised growth did not materialize, and austerity left scars that linger still. Funding for day-to-day NHS operations was maintained, for instance, but only by cannibalizing the capital budget. A 2024 government report found that, as a result of austerity, Britain has “crumbling buildings, mental health patients being accommodated in Victoria-era cells infested with vermin with 17 men sharing two showers, and parts of the NHS operating in decrepit portacabins.”

After austerity cuts to welfare benefits took effect, the share of children who grew up in long-term poverty, meaning half their childhood or more, shot up from about 14 percent to 23 percent. Nutrition appeared to suffer, and doctors reported increased cases of diseases stemming from vitamin deficiencies, such as rickets and scurvy.

Local governments, called councils, saw their grants from the central government fall by 40 percent from 2010 to 2020. In 2023, Birmingham City Council, which is responsible for more than 1 million residents, effectively declared bankruptcy. One-third of all English councils could do the same within five years.

Austerity was felt most harshly by those who were already suffering after deindustrialization. The welfare state had partially compensated the losers from globalization. When it abruptly shrank—because the masters of the universe had miscalculated—anger erupted upward, at British elites, and also outward, at European migrants, who were competing for jobs and public services. It was because of this political pressure that Cameron made another fateful decision: to hold the Brexit referendum in 2016. This was a gambit; Cameron expected the vote to fail. He did not want to leave the European Union, but he wanted to arrest the rise of figures such as Nigel Farage, the longtime gadfly of British politics, who had been campaigning for withdrawal from the EU for decades. Left-behind Britain, the places especially harmed by austerity cuts, voted overwhelmingly to leave. The morning after he lost the referendum, Cameron resigned, ushering in a period of political instability that has now lasted a decade, and shows no sign of ending.

Settling the formal Brexit deal took almost four years of negotiations between Britain and the EU. The resulting uncertainty took a toll on British businesses even then. In 2018, one year before his ascension to prime minister, Boris Johnson was asked by a European diplomat about these adverse effects. He replied, “Fuck business.” And indeed, something like that happened. A recent paper on “The Economic Impact of Brexit,” by five economists, calculated that Brexit caused business investment to drop by 12 to 18 percent, productivity and employment to decline by about



Bottle kilns, used in the manufacture of dinnerware and other pottery, in Stoke-on-Trent, circa 1948

3 to 4 percent, and, most striking, GDP per capita to fall by 6 to 8 percent—twice as much as earlier estimates. The harms weren’t all immediately visible. As with austerity, they accumulated over time.

OUTSIDE LONDON, the consequences of almost two lost decades are unignorable. Stoke-on-Trent, in the West Midlands, about 150 miles north of London, was once the ceramics capital of Britain, and quite probably the world. It was geologically blessed by rich seams of both coal and clay; its wares were transported by canal to Liverpool for export. The whole area became known as the Potteries. Stoke once held some 2,000 bottle kilns—huge, bulbous structures in which crockery from companies such as Wedgwood were fired.

Today only 47 remain; the industry employs perhaps 5,000 people—down from some 300,000 in 1984. And because of Britain’s extraordinary energy costs, this number is still declining. Depleted oil drilling in the North Sea and a failure to invest in alternative energy sources have left the country reliant on imported energy, staggering consumers and industry alike. From 2004 to 2024, electricity costs for British businesses more than tripled (even after adjusting for inflation), and are now the highest in the world.

In March, I visited Middleport Pottery, the last remaining ceramics factory that has operated continuously since the Victorian era. A charming elderly guide named Phil Knott showed me around, pointing out the ceramics and crockery that the company supplies to the private residence of King Charles III. In most rooms we entered, he introduced me by saying, “This man here is from Washington to write an article about the ceramics industry.” Though the factory once employed some 400 workers, it now has only 18. Middleport uses smaller gas ovens today,

but its last bottle kiln (there once were seven) still sits outside, a vestige of a bygone time. All along the kiln's exterior—where heat and smoke and ash once escaped—small trees and plants have taken root in the dormant structure.

The deindustrialization of Stoke began a long time ago. In the 1980s, Prime Minister Margaret Thatcher ushered in her “supply side” revolution, emphasizing privatization and breaking the trade unions. This improved the country's fortunes, but not those of all its parts. Thatcherism hit Stoke hard, causing closures of factories, steelworks, and mines. Lisa Healings, who runs the charity Voluntary Action Stoke-on-Trent, lived through that as a young girl. VAST works with a network of charities to provide food, job training, and counseling, but the group is fighting economic gravity. “There's now a third generation almost coming through,” Healings told me, whose “parents were unemployed, their grandparents were unemployed, and they don't see any future for themselves other than living on benefits and being unemployed.”

Austerity was particularly brutal to places like Stoke, where a large share of the population was already dependent on government benefits. Two out of every five children in Stoke live in poverty, one of the highest rates in Britain, and in 2022, the city had one of the highest rates of infant mortality in the country.

Since the turn of this century, successive governments have tried and mostly failed to correct basic problems. In 2003, John Prescott, Blair's deputy prime minister, started a policy called “Pathfinder,” which aimed to demolish and replace worn-down housing in postindustrial places such as Stoke. Cameron's government abruptly defunded it in 2010, leaving empty eyesore lots where demolition had finished but building had not yet begun. In 2019, Johnson promised that a new economic-revitalization plan called “Leveling Up” would “answer the plea of the forgotten people and the left-behind towns.” But few specifics were forthcoming until three years later, only months before Johnson resigned. The funding it provided was a pittance compared with the support withdrawn from local governments under austerity.

It is in places like Stoke where discontent with London and Brussels is highest. During the 2016 referendum, 69 percent of residents voted to leave the EU—the highest share of any city in the country. Afterward, Stoke was branded “the capital of Brexit.”

MY TRAIN NORTH from London was, like many, seriously delayed—in this case because of a loose panel on a front car. “Hopefully it'll hold on until we get to Manchester,” the conductor announced. This information left me, rather like the panel, flappable, but it had no discernible effect on my fellow passengers. Although Americans should generally not cast aspersions on the rail services of other countries, the episode was yet another reminder of Britain's degraded state.

Recent plans to transform the country have rested in no small part on High Speed 2, a superfast rail line intended to connect London with Birmingham, Leeds, and Manchester. But since HS2 was proposed, in 2009, its costs have tripled, to more than £100 billion. It is the most expensive rail line in the world. (A special structure to protect a rare bat species near the rail line in Buckinghamshire required 8,000 permits and was built at a cost of £216 million.) The

most important sections of the proposed route have been lopped off. The rump line—going from Birmingham, Britain's second-largest city, to not-quite-central London—may be finished by 2040.

In Birmingham, a local named Gerry Moynihan walked me from the city center to the benighted HS2 terminus. Moynihan—a pleasant, white-haired former lawyer with a dyspeptic X account often focused on his hometown's troubles—was eager to show me what had gone wrong. He pointed out a large site called Smithfield, formerly the location of grocery wholesalers whose warehouses had been vacant for many years. We passed a few film studios along the canal, some of the more promising businesses that have sprouted up in recent years. Moynihan admitted that their existence poses some challenge to an oft-repeated remark of his—“I see nothing of merit in this city”—but then redirected my attention to the gargantuan potholes in the road, gouged so deep that you could see the Victorian-era cobblestones below; to the trash piled up in vacant lots; and to the discarded boxes for extra-large canisters of nitrous oxide, which is routinely abused in Birmingham.

To get to the HS2 terminus, at Curzon Street Station, Moynihan and I walked along the route of an attempted Birmingham-metro-rail extension, which has itself been beset by delays and cost overruns: a localized version of the HS2 debacle. I could see crawler cranes and excavators moving busily around; huge Y-shaped piers that will, perhaps in a decade, hoist the high-speed rail stood disconnected from each other. HS2 has been delayed for so long that two swiftly built towers near the terminus now themselves look derelict and in need of demolition. “If you're a developer, why would you invest here? The only reason is HS2, and it is moribund,” Moynihan said.

Building infrastructure, or much of anything else, has become all but impossible in the United Kingdom. In addition to having the world's most expensive (not yet built) train line, Britain also hosts the world's most expensive (not yet built) nuclear-power plant, Hinkley Point C. Its environmental-impact assessment ran 31,401 pages; the plant will feature a £700 million “fish disco,” which will pulse sounds underwater to deter animals from its intake pipes. The government spent 32 years and £179 million planning a tunnel beneath Stonehenge to relieve traffic, only to officially scrap the plan this year. Even basic tasks, such as obtaining power, can be nightmarish. “In the U.K., you can be waiting for five years to get any kind of energy-intensive project connected to the grid,” Sam Bowman, a founding editor of the magazine *Works in Progress*, told me. These failures are all self-imposed. Parliament, by design, could exercise broad authority over these matters—yet rather than wielding this power to confront Britain's problems, it has chosen instead to smother the state with veto points, proceduralism, and endless reviews.

Britain suffers from a housing crisis significantly worse than America's. The problem cannot even be blamed on zoning, because Britain does not have a zoning regime to speak of. Rather, every attempt to build is a painful, ad hoc negotiation with local government councils and NIMBY residents. As a result, housing costs per square foot are among the highest in Europe. In the words of one report, “Our housing stock offers the worst value for money of any advanced economy.” France has roughly the same population as the U.K., but almost 50 percent more

homes. And yet, since the financial crisis, the U.K.'s rate of housing production has only fallen.

Britain's building problems are not limited to the periphery. In London, the typical house sold in 2024 cost 11 times median earnings. And although London remains an alluring global city, it, too, is stagnating—since the financial crisis, worker productivity there has been essentially flat. Even so, London today is almost 50 percent more productive than the West Midlands, which includes both Stoke and Birmingham. Anna Stansbury, an economist at MIT, told me that the gaps between London and other British cities are comparable to those between cities in West and East Germany. In regional terms, the problem of the past two decades is essentially that London has hardly grown, yet Britain's smaller cities remain so far behind it.

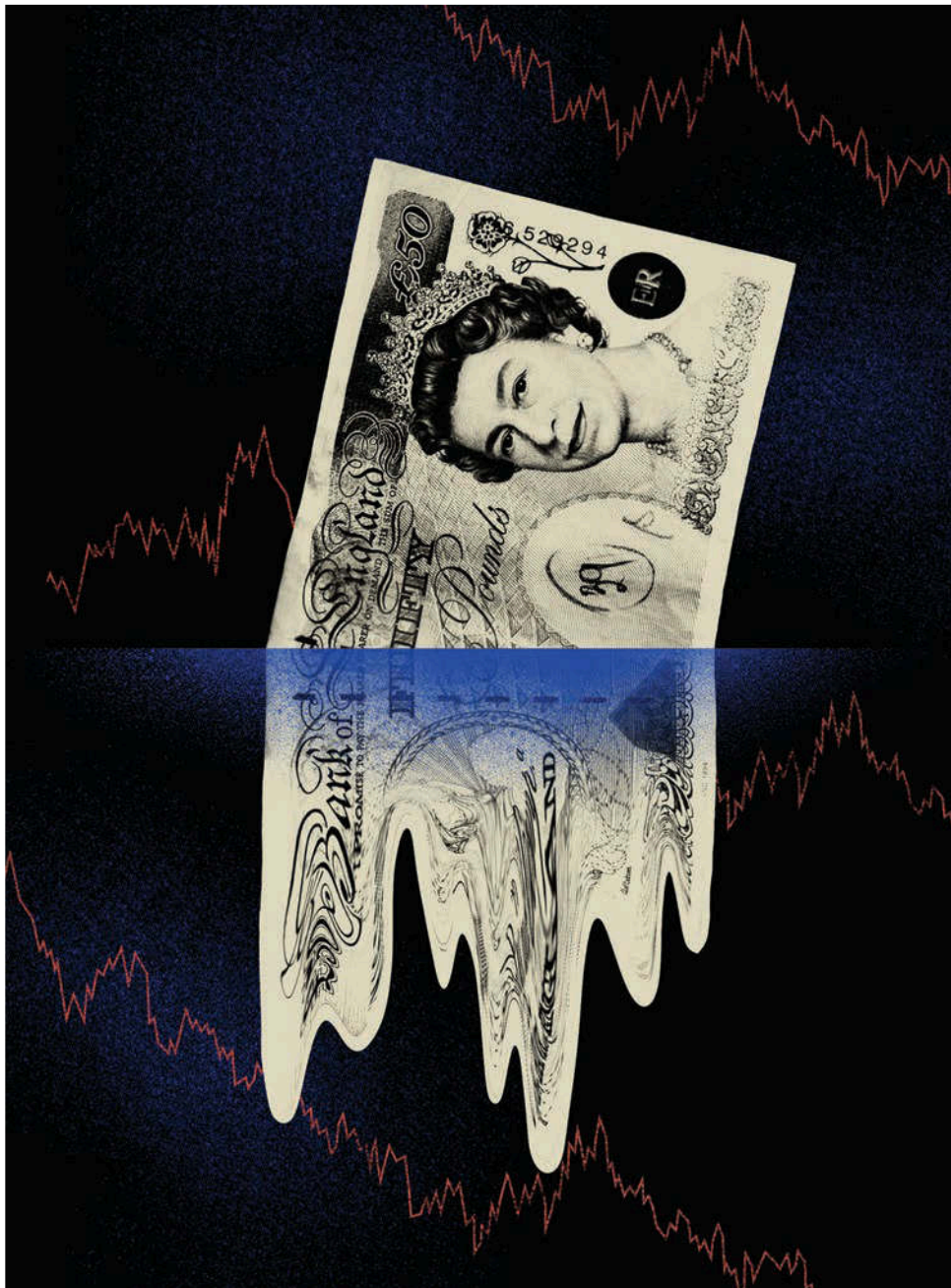
THERE ARE SOME EXCEPTIONS to the general pattern of British malaise: Oxford and Cambridge, world leaders in science for centuries, are belatedly becoming hubs for start-ups, though they are close enough to London to share its housing afflictions. The most optimistic place I visited outside London's orbit was Manchester, where growth has consistently been double the U.K. average. Downtown Manchester was once almost totally depopulated; today, approximately 100,000 people live there. After working hours in the city's pubs, you will hear conspicuous southern accents: In 2024, more Londoners moved to Manchester than vice versa.

Manchester has succeeded in part because it gained some independence from the shambolic central government in London. In an experiment in devolution begun in 2011, London granted the

city more power over taxes and transportation. The bus network was brought under public control, and a local £1 billion "Good Growth Fund" was set up to distribute investments across the city. Manchester, as a result, is now better able to set its own economic course. "You can't order growth from the top down," Andy Burnham, the mayor of Greater Manchester since 2017, told me. "The U.K., for most of our lives, has been an overly centralized country."

Many Labour supporters wish that Burnham, rather than the hapless Starmer, was prime minister. But for that to happen, Burnham would first need to return to Parliament (where he had previously served for 16 years). He attempted to do so in January, when a parliamentary seat became vacant in Greater Manchester, but he was blocked by Starmer's allies, who did not want to elevate a potential rival (already called the "King of the North"). In May, after Starmer's grip on power had loosened even further, a Labour member of Parliament in Macclesfield, another Manchester seat, voluntarily resigned to offer Burnham another avenue to challenging the party leader. He will not be blocked this time.

Yet Burnham's path to power is not guaranteed. Even Manchester is not immune to the country's anti-establishment



JOAN WONG

mood. In Makerfield, recent elections have seen significant improvement for the Green Party, the populist left party on the rise in Britain. The Greens are run by Zack Polanski, a former hypnotherapist and a self-described “eco-populist” who wants to legalize drugs and implement a wealth tax. But the strongest performance has been put up by the Reform Party, the populist hard-right party that’s rising nationally even faster than the Greens.

Both of these parties, once relegated to the fringe of British politics, have done exceptionally well in recent national surveys. Reform has in fact been out-polling all the others for months—the first time in more than 40 years that neither Conservatives nor Labour has led. No matter who in the Labour Party replaces Starmer, presuming he resigns, Britain must hold another general election within the next three years. The odds-on favorite to be the next prime minister after that election is Reform’s leader. His name is Nigel Farage.

HOW COULD the prime instigator of Brexit now find himself in a position to be promoted to prime minister?

Farage is ascendant because he has an enticing answer to the question “Who broke Britain?”: the feckless elites, the ineffective civil servants, and the unwanted immigrants. Even if the country’s problems are beyond his capacity to solve, he at least can promise their reckoning.

I met Farage in March, right before he took the stage at a campaign rally in Milton Keynes, a commuter town outside London

most famous for its many roundabouts. He and his merry band of insurgents were touring the country ahead of the local elections in May, in which Reform would gain some 1,400 municipal-government seats (30 percent of the total seats contested), while Labour would lose about 1,400 and the Tories about 500. Farage was in character: besuited, with a pink-and-purple tie immaculately matched to his shirt, and sporting his trademark Union Jack socks. When he leaned forward, I smelled tobacco and possibly a faint whiff of the pint of lager that he is so often pictured holding. He sunnily told me how he was preparing, upon his election, to wrest power from the deep state and deploy it to enact the will of the people. “We have to make sure within the civil service that we have people who are not willful obstructors,” he said: His government would not be like Donald Trump’s first administration, initially unsure of how to wield power, but like the second, ready to go from the start.

Several hundred people had come to see Farage speak. Political rallies in England are more civilized than the American ones I am used to: People drink pints before the event, sit patiently in chairs during it, and leave in an orderly queue afterward. After everyone took their seat, Farage delivered his speech, which was a rhapsody of declinism. “It is a period of complete political failure; economically, we’re going down the drain,” he said. Every current and recent political leader was to blame. The Conservatives had delivered Brexit too slowly, allowed mass migration anyway, agreed to net-zero-emissions commitments. Labour was responsible for Britain’s humiliation on the world stage, through its weak response to the war in Iran and its general dithering. The message was clear: Only Farage could fix it.

Farage’s plans to consolidate power, through a defanged civil service and constitutional reform, are detailed. Cuts to the civil service are not just being promised in a general way; a “Project 2025”—style ministry-by-ministry road map is being discussed by Reform’s allies. Quasi-constitutional laws that have restrained the power of the central government, such as the 1998 Human Rights Act and the 2010 Equality Act, will be redrafted. So will the 2008 Climate Change Act, which enshrined Britain’s net-zero commitments. Danny Kruger, a Conservative MP who defected to Reform last year and is now a part of its brain trust, told me that fixing the country’s problems requires first restoring parliamentary sovereignty. That would mean limiting the ability of independent government bodies to direct policy, and of courts to exercise judicial review on acts of Parliament.

Greater power for Parliament could indeed enable needed reforms. The accumulation of legal clutter is in no small part responsible for the country’s inability to build housing, infrastructure, and industry. And Parliament’s ability to self-govern, after decades of delegation to EU committees, has atrophied. Even after Brexit, a sort of learned helplessness has prevailed within the political class, Fred de Fossard, a former Tory political adviser now at the Prosperity Institute, told me. If Farage is elected, perhaps that will change. But Brexit proved that a sweeping assertion of sovereignty is by itself insufficient to ensure growth—and, indeed, can be self-harming.

Many of the details about how Farage would restore Britain’s place among wealthy nations, and a sense of opportunity for its

HOW COULD THE PRIME INSTIGATOR OF BREXIT NOW FIND HIMSELF IN A POSITION TO BE PROMOTED TO PRIME MINISTER?

people, are hazy. I asked him how he would spur the kind of strong economic growth that the Conservative and Labour Parties had failed to achieve. He answered by saying that he and his future ministers were successful businesspeople, unlike the current lot, and would therefore do better. The Reform Party has promised to slash government spending and national deficits, though it has promised to cut some taxes too. Farage told me that shock therapy for the British state would be necessary. “There is no question the state has to shrink in size, and this is going to be very, very tough,” he said, adding that he anticipates protests when he unveils plans to cut welfare benefits. “But if we don’t do it, we are going to go bust.”

Because of such statements, Reform is often accused of being austerity rehashed, or Thatcherism rewarmed. But Reform’s most specific economic pronouncements have largely been of the crowd-pleasing, non-Thatcherite variety: cutting fuel taxes, keeping the NHS free at the point of service, and preserving the “triple lock”—a policy effectively ensuring that state pensions increase faster than ordinary wages.

Being cryptic about hard economic choices is electorally advantageous, particularly when the general election could be years away. This was in fact the strategy that Starmer employed in his election campaign, repeating the word *growth* like a mantra without revealing how he would achieve it. His political capital proved fleeting. Reform may ascend to power only to find itself snared in the same trap. Still, even well-connected Westminster types who served in prior governments told me they did not really dread a Reform government. Reform, in their view, is the only party iconoclastic enough to attempt major structural repairs on the foundations of the British state and economy. “To believe that something is broken doesn’t mean that it’s irretrievably broken,” James Orr, a Cambridge theology professor who leads policy for Reform, told me. “But we think it’s becoming increasingly obvious that we’re the only political movement with a chance.”

The most detailed plans released by Reform involve immigration—the one issue that evokes as much anger among voters as living standards do. The Conservatives broke their pledges: Johnson promised to reduce the net inflow of migrants, but his policies, meant to bolster health-care staffing and stabilize falling university enrollment, led to the legal arrival of more than 3 million non-EU immigrants, who now amount to one out of every 25 people in Britain. Later, Prime Minister Rishi Sunak struggled to deal with the arrival of more than 150,000 migrants who’d crossed the English Channel on small boats. Even the current Labour government, sensing the anger in the electorate, has pledged to reduce migration.

It is on immigration that Farage offers the starkest choice. He has put Zia Yusuf, a wealthy businessman and the son of Sri Lankan immigrants, at the helm of his immigration agenda. Yusuf’s major policy pitch is “Operation Restoring Justice,” which calls for the deportation of all unauthorized migrants in Britain (through a new ICE-style agency called UK Deportation Command). Yusuf is the kind of zealous and paradoxical convert whom Reform, and other parties of the global New Right, revel in—a practicing Muslim who strenuously campaigns to keep churches from being converted to mosques. He is to Farage what Stephen Miller is to Donald Trump: a hard-faced nativist, always aware



*Nigel Farage, campaigning in Romford in April.
His Reform Party has surged in national polls.*

of the latest heinous offense committed by an immigrant and always warning of impending civilizational collapse—next to whom the boss looks moderate and relaxed. “Never again will British people be a second-class citizen in their own country,” Yusuf declared in a speech on the night I saw Farage in Milton Keynes. “Under a Reform government, His Majesty’s Parliament will be sovereign once again, and the rights of the great British people will reign supreme!”

Given the anger over broken border promises, it’s no surprise that Reform’s clearest message has been on restricting migration. It resonates because Britain’s economic failures have contributed to a growing cultural precarity, too. But unwinding migration is unlikely to solve Britain’s deepest woes—most of which are domestically manufactured, not imported.

With every disappointing year, with the failure of every backfiring government policy, the nostalgia for British exceptionalism has grown stronger. Restoration to global hegemony is impossible. Stabilization is achievable, but only if Britain’s next ruling class does something that its governments over the past two decades have not managed: stop choosing the self-harming option. Arresting the current trajectory of decline will require the recognition of a hard truth. What broke Britain was not Brussels, bad luck, or bankers. The British broke Britain. To mend it, they must first stop breaking it further. *A*

Idrees Kahloon is a staff writer at The Atlantic.



Queen of the Skies

The Boeing 747,
the world's
first jumbo jet,
has started its
final descent.





By Ian Bogost



I. The Boneyard

Through the heat haze, airplane tails rose from the desert. As I steered off the interstate toward Pinal Airpark, in Marana, Arizona, I got my first view of a corpse in full: a stark-white Boeing 747, its wings sheared off, its passenger doors open to the dust and wind, a rickety set of airstairs inviting no one aboard. The plane was a memory, a ruin, but its swooping, humped nose was still striking—a visage that signaled the freedom of movement in the Jet Age.

I was arriving at this desolate site north of Tucson, where airplanes go to die, to mourn the 747, the original jumbo jet—a.k.a. the Whale, the Longreach, the Sky Cruiser, the Mother of All Airliners, the Queen of the Skies. For 50 years, the aircraft was the principal host of Important Journeys: a young student's trip to study abroad in Paris, a first-generation American's pilgrimage to their ancestral home in Hungary, an Iranian family fleeing the 1979 revolution. Combining the immensity of an ocean liner and the elegance of a swan, the 747 is the only commercial jet that deserves to be called beautiful. Over the past two decades, airlines have stopped using it as a passenger plane and replaced it with smaller aircraft that are more efficient, but far less majestic and memorable. The 747 was once a symbol of American might, invention, progress, and populism. Now it embodies the decline of all of those values.

Jim Petty, the airpark's manager, led me out the back door of his small office to his truck, and we peeled out toward the long rows of forsaken aircraft. I had been calling Pinal a boneyard, but Petty told me that he doesn't like the term. Some planes get brought here for a checkup, others for intensive care or storage. Some ailing vessels are delivered here with every intention of flying again, like an elderly relative sent to a short-term-care facility. But if rehabilitation proves impossible, Pinal becomes their final destination.

Petty parked us under a TWA 747 that had been sitting there for almost 30 years. Its enormity eclipsed the hot desert sun. The tires alone were more than four feet tall, a memorial to outsize ambitions. From 1970, when the first 747 entered service, to 2023, when Boeing stopped building the plane, the company manufactured 1,574 of them, including the two that still serve as Air Force One. Most 747 routes spanned oceans and continents, giving travelers a speedier option than the Queen Mary had across the Atlantic, or the California Zephyr across the West. For generations, these jumbo jets flew to London, to Osaka, to San

Francisco. But more recently, 747s have been flying to Pinal—drawn here by their own obsolescence.

"Some day," Petty said, "there's just going to be one left."

II. Birth of an Icon

Starting the engines brings a sudden hush followed by a smooth roar. At 300-some metric tons, fully loaded, and with a wingspan that would cover two-thirds of a football field, the plane could be tricky to drive but was supple to fly. On the ground and about three stories up, pilots were aware of all they couldn't see. Once airborne, though, a sense of infinity dawned out the cockpit windows, and of sheer mass behind the pilots. In the cabin, the heft makes the plane feel almost still, even at 500 miles an hour and 35,000 feet; it is the only plane I have ever flown in whose takeoff and landing were imperceptible to the senses. Paul Galaher, a longtime 747 captain, told me he couldn't remember a hard landing. He said that it was the plane every pilot wanted to fly, the top rung of a commercial-aviation career.

Like most technological innovations of the 20th century, the 747 project was catalyzed by the military. In the early 1960s, Boeing produced designs in response to a government request for a large military transport aircraft. Lockheed won that job and produced the C-5 Galaxy. Boeing's loss steeled its resolve and freed up engineers to work on the biggest airplane ever built for commercial service. Boeing acquired 780 acres of land in Everett, Washington, just north of Seattle, and erected an assembly complex that included the largest building in the world by volume—at a cost of \$200 million (\$2 billion in today's dollars)—to house up to eight 747s under construction. About 2,700 engineers labored on the project.

Aviation executives called a risk like this the "sporty game"—a shameless mid-century, flannel-suit euphemism for staking an entire company on a single long-odds bet. Had the 747 project faltered, Boeing would likely have gone down with it.

Thomas Gray, who joined Boeing in 1961 as an electrical engineer, calls himself the "first passenger on the first 747," responsible for in-flight testing. "Whether it was strain, arrows, airspeed, whatever," he told me, "we had to measure all that data onto a tape machine." Gray, a lanky man with a gray mustache, volunteers as a docent at the Museum of Flight in Seattle, just across from Boeing Field. For 17 years, the 747 served as his office. This was the Wild West of commercial aviation, after planes had been proven but when the Jet Age was still new and exciting.

Watching the plane's first flight from the blast fence, in 1969, Gray remembers telling a fellow engineer beside him, "One of these days, there are going to be 747s lined up to take off." He was right. Boeing's earlier jets—the 707, 727, and 737—carried fewer than 200 souls. The 747 could carry north of 490 passengers, plus a massive amount of cargo, and still fly thousands of miles farther than most existing jets. Juan Trippe, who ordered 25 747s

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for Pan Am in 1966 at a cost of \$5 billion in today's dollars, saw the plane as an instrument of human flourishing. "The new era of mass travel between nations may well prove more significant to human destiny than the atom bomb," he said at the time, calling the aircraft "a great weapon for peace."

The jumbo jet would make the world smaller in the same way that railroads and ocean liners had in the century prior. This was the age of seemingly impossible endeavors undertaken and accomplished despite extreme risk; five months after the 747 first took flight, Neil Armstrong set foot on the moon. This spirit of rarefied American invention, fueled by both government investment and private capital, was meant to serve all humankind.

It worked. From 1969 to 1979, the number of people flying every year more than doubled, to 640 million. Flying was glamorous—in part because it was expensive, but also because the 747 was built for human comfort as well as fuel efficiency.

Speed was expected to supplant comfort, eventually. In anticipation of supersonic flight, the 747 was designed to shift into cargo duty sometime by the end of the '70s; its cygnine hump allowed containers to be loaded through its nose, which opens like the mouth of a cartoon shark. But the supersonic passenger jet was a bust, and the 747 persisted. Its accidental longevity defined an era.

III. Legroom and Caviar

The British architect Norman Foster once called the 747 his favorite building of the 20th century. Like the ocean liners and railcars it replaced, the 747 is more than a vehicle. It is also a dwelling.

The upper-deck lounge became the first and most important room in this building—though somewhat incidentally. The charge to make the plane capable of loading cargo through its nose required the flight deck to be situated above the main section. Once the flight deck was placed high, over the cargo slot, the plane needed to sweep back accordingly for aerodynamics, one retired Boeing engineer told me. What to put in that space?

A cocktail bar, obviously. Air France and United installed lounges with rotating seats to allow passengers to mingle. Air India put in bright-red carpeting and sofas, with images of *apsaras* on the bulkhead behind them. Qantas offered the nautical-themed Captain Cook Lounge, with lantern sconces, intricate woodwork, and rope-wrapped swivel seats and cocktail tables.

Boeing named its first 747 the City of Everett, after its birthplace, and painted it in Boeing's corporate color scheme: white with a red cheatline, a gray belly, and a black glare panel. Gray and his colleagues used the City of Everett for testing; it was never outfitted with an interior. The aircraft now lives at the Museum of Flight. Visitors can take a tour inside but are generally not allowed up the spiral staircase to the upper deck and cockpit.

I negotiated an exception. When I ascended the tight stairwell, I was surprised to see it decorated as a lounge, complete with

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antiqued mirrors on the rear bulkhead, blue carpeting, and vivid, mod-printed seating. At some point in the City of Everett's long life, an upholstery shop had redone the upper-deck seating with old Braniff Airways fabric.

Peggy Verger and Cheryl Grimm, two former United flight attendants, met me in the lounge to share memories of service on early 747s. For Verger, luxury wasn't really the point of the plane's interior design. "We've lost the personality of flying," she said. At first I thought she was talking about the style—the Pucci-designed Braniff uniforms, or Eero Saarinen's modernist terminals. But she meant personalities. She meant *people*. "We loved talking to the people," Verger said. "The lounges, the wide aisles. We were tight with the passengers. 'So how's your dog?' We were much more social."

Travelers turned in their seats to their neighbors. They stood up and chatted with someone across the aisle. They moved through the cabin to a lounge, or to ask for a coffee. Sometimes, after giving children pin-on airline wings, the stewardesses—as they were called at the time—would recruit them to help pass out nuts or matches. "It just was all so different," Verger added. "The passenger was a person."

The food in first class was rich: hand-carved meats, lobster, caviar. Even fliers in the back ate like royalty; on a 1970 Pan Am flight from JFK to Heathrow, a coach-class passenger would have enjoyed filet mignon. Small sofa lounges were tucked into the front or rear of some aircraft. One Continental Airlines 747, called the Proud Bird of the Pacific, had a spacious Polynesian Pub in the coach cabin, with floral-print seats around low-slung pedestal tables. American Airlines built a coach lounge with black-and-white geometric carpet and red upholstered seating that anyone might mistake for a hotel lobby. American installed a piano bar there, too, although it used an electric organ (pianos are hard to keep in tune when subjected to the forces of takeoff and landing).

Features like these inspired Continental, in 1971, to advertise its 747 flights as "Air Cruises." Grimm recalled constant activities and contests. Passengers celebrating a birthday or an anniversary could order a cake or a bottle of champagne. "It was just a nice party," she said.



A first-class lunch served in the nose of a Boeing 747, 1970

The cabin's ceilings rose to eight feet—even at the window seats—and the exterior walls stood nearly straight up and down, allowing even the tallest passengers to stand upright, like a human instead of a sardine.

Use of the whole space was encouraged. Why make a building for people to remain seated in? A TWA pamphlet about 747 service from the early 1970s encouraged passengers to exercise on their flight: "Walk 13 times up and down the cabin and you've actually covered one mile." Continental once boasted of removing 41 seats for four extra inches of legroom in coach. Even on a three-hour domestic flight, the experience of the airborne building was deemed as important as the transportation itself.

Wide-body airliners made global flight accessible to many people, but industry growth slowed by the mid-1970s. The 1973 oil shock made fuel more expensive, altering the fundamentals of the airline business. Hijackings surged, leading to the invention of airport security. In 1978, deregulation transformed the economics of the domestic airline industry. Fares dropped dramatically, and more people began to fly. As the clientele became more pedestrian, flying felt less cosmopolitan.

And the comforts started to vanish. The social spaces and coach lounges began disappearing so the airlines could cram in more

passengers—including into the upper deck, which became certified for passenger seating during taxi, takeoff, and landing. The new hub-and-spoke model of air service started displacing milk-run paths. Domestic flights on the 747, such as the Chicago-L.A. leg of the Proud Bird of the Pacific, became rarer. Instead, the aircraft mostly flew people over oceans. The most beautiful building of the 20th century was becoming just another vehicle.

IV. Metal Tubes With Wings

Before the September 11 attacks closed terminals to the unticketed, anyone could pass through the metal detectors and go right up to the gate. You could do this to welcome or send off a loved one. You could meet up with a friend on a layover. Or you could just see the planes.

Cheryl Grimm remembers passengers bringing their friends to the gate, just to see her 747 taxiing. Pilots remember it too.

Mark Vanhoenacker flew 747s for British Airways out of London until 2019, just before the airline removed the plane from service. He told me about disembarking at his favorite destinations—Cape Town, Tokyo, Vancouver—and looking over his shoulder in childlike wonder. *I can't believe I flew that airplane a third of the way around the world*, he'd think to himself.

The aircraft began service in the middle of the Vietnam War. In 1975, after the tragic crash of a C-5 Galaxy military transport aircraft meant to evacuate Vietnamese orphans, two chartered Pan Am 747s stepped in as a part of Operation Babylift. That effort was accused of both propagandism and abduction. But many citizens were desperate to leave Vietnam, and they did so voluntarily, in the bosom of the Mother of All Airliners.

For that reason, Peggy Verger understood crewing the 747 as a patriotic act. She remembered a group of Vietnamese refugees boarding a flight of hers in Tokyo. “And when they got off—they were doctors and lawyers, and a lot of them spoke English—they would say things like *Thank you for letting me come into your country*,” she said, stopping to press her heart. “Tears coming down.” Grimm remembers similar scenes, on flights to Vancouver before Hong Kong reverted to Chinese rule. Or Russian immigrants on flights to New York: a whole family, from the grandmother to the children, taking up an entire row of the airplane, each with just a little sack of belongings. Grimm would think to herself: *Thank you, Lord, for letting me be born in America*.

The 747's fusion of aeronautical ability and symbolic power earned it many roles beyond passenger liner and freighter. By 1977, Thomas Gray, the Boeing engineer, was running test flights for a heavily modified Whale to carry the space shuttle Enterprise atop it. NASA used the plane to shuttle the shuttle from its landing sites back to the Kennedy Space Center, in Florida. One icon of America had settled the global skies, and on its shoulders sat another, set to conquer the cosmos. The sight of the pair mated together suggested that the 20th century's progress would never end.

It did, of course. The shuttle program closed in 2011, as 747s were already disappearing from the skies. Today, beholding a 747 in person has become harder, especially in the United States. The charter carrier Atlas Air flies some, as does the freight operator Kalitta, but even their numbers are dwindling as companies move to more efficient two-engine aircraft. Lufthansa flies the most scheduled passenger flights on the 747—between Frankfurt and destinations that include Chicago, Los Angeles, and Washington, D.C.—and Korean Air also still runs the plane overseas. But the 747 has moved downmarket: China, Iran, and Russia use them for bus-like domestic routes. Even when foreign carriers fly 747s, though, the sight of one of their planes invokes American ingenuity, because the aircraft was designed and built by America.

When the 747 is gone, other aircraft will service high-capacity, long-haul routes: the Boeing 777, for example, and the Airbus A350. But none of those planes will symbolize global access and renewal, because nothing about any other plane is symbolic. They all look and feel the same. They are just metal tubes with wings. When we are on a plane these days, we are really inside our headphones, sewn into our seats, yearning for it to end. The miracle of flight itself goes unnoticed, as even daytime travelers

draw their shades. They do so to sleep, or to increase the contrast on their screen. Striking up a conversation is taboo. Six miles aboveground, you feel buried rather than aloft.

V. The Flying Oval Office

The last 747 on Americans' radar is the one carrying Donald Trump. Air Force One has been a 747 for nearly 36 years, since George H. W. Bush first ascended its staircase on September 6, 1990, to fly from Andrews Air Force Base to Topeka, Kansas, for a fundraising luncheon.

Air Force One is heavily modified and highly customized—its 4,000 square feet of interior space include a medical facility and two kitchens that can serve 100 gourmet meals—but from the outside, it still looks the same as any other 747, from Pan Am onward, apart from the color scheme and presidential seal. In previous eras, the most powerful person in the world boarded the same equipment that you might use to take a Hawaiian vacation. But there was something regal about a president descending those steps, or waving from the top of them, on foreign soil. The plane is a literal ship of state. On September 11, 2001, amid a nationwide ground stop while the country was under attack, Air Force One was George W. Bush's “flying Oval Office,” to borrow Boeing's phrase. Trump loves to do domestic flyovers—of his rallies, of a Washington Commanders game in November—and show off the sheer size of the plane at low altitudes.

But Air Force One has aged. The two 747s that currently share the duty are the same ones that Bush 41 flew on. In 2018, the first Trump administration struck a \$3.9 billion deal with Boeing to make two new planes, based on the 747-8, the aircraft's final variation. The planes were meant to be delivered by 2024, but they have not arrived. The project has been plagued by technical issues, supplier disputes, and alleged tomfoolery—empty mini tequila bottles were reportedly discovered on one of the airplanes under construction. Boeing has absorbed more than \$2 billion in cost overruns on the project. (“We continue to make steady progress” on the project, a Boeing spokesperson told me.)

The stumble couldn't have come at a worse moment for the company. Around the same time that Trump ordered the new Air Force Ones, Boeing 737 Max 8 aircraft began experiencing software problems that eventually led to disaster, including two accidents that killed 346 people. All planes in the fleet were grounded. Boeing paid large penalties and settlements in the ensuing years, and faced increased competition from Airbus, its European rival. In January 2024, an Alaska Airlines 737 Max 9 suffered a door-plug blowout due to improper installation. The company that once played the sporty game to invent the jumbo jet couldn't seem to make new versions of its bread-and-butter mid-range aircraft.

By spring 2025, still without his new Air Force One, Trump began to consider accepting a luxury-appointed Boeing 747-8 as

a gift from Qatar instead. Despite concerns about corruption and national security, the government took the gift, valued at \$400 million. Only a “stupid person” would decline a “free, very expensive airplane,” Trump said at the time. The cost of modifying the plane for presidential use is classified; “probably less than \$400 million” is what Air Force Secretary Troy Meink told Congress last year. The Air Force announced on May 1, 2026, that the aircraft is scheduled to fly this summer, with a new red, white, and blue livery. Will the American taxpayer end up paying for both the retrofitting and the new planes? “Yes,” an Air Force spokesperson told me.

Another problem plagues a presidential 747, whether or not an emir delivers it: It is not a plane of the people anymore. It is a rarity, more often an opulent private palace than an instrument of common carriage. The likeliest way for me to fly on a 747 in the United States, at this moment, would be in a press seat on the president’s plane.

A common route for Air Force One these days is from Andrews Air Force Base to Palm Beach International Airport, for Trump’s weekends at Mar-a-Lago. I figured that the White House, and even the president himself, might welcome me aboard, to experience the greatest passenger plane in the sky over the greatest country in the world. The White House nearly gave me a seat in late January, but then the trip filled up. On one of the flights I was not aboard that weekend, Trump told reporters that he had opened airspace in South America so that some immigrants could “go back to Venezuela and stay, perhaps.” America has traveled a long way from Peggy Verger’s huddled masses yearning to fly free.

In recent years, the 747 has amounted to an old plane for an old-man president. What will its next iteration symbolize? If a new Air Force One finally rolls off the beleaguered Boeing line, it will still be a fully American lodestar, however faded its shine. If instead Trump flies on a gift from a foreign power, it won’t matter how American its bones are.

VI. Farewell Tour

Flying is more a part of life than ever, but it feels disappointing at best, and inhumane at worst. This year, a Homeland Security shutdown created hours-long security lines; an elective war with Iran spiked the cost of fuel and ticket prices. Old dreams were forgotten too. The possibility of supersonic passenger travel has been abandoned in favor of trim-tab adjustments, such as Boeing’s 787 Dreamliner, with its bigger windows and less arid cabins. The competition that deregulation once spurred has all but dried up. The few airlines that are left, having been allowed to consolidate into oligopoly, have abandoned the medium-size cities that were their former hubs, such as Cincinnati, St. Louis, Pittsburgh, and Memphis. The big four U.S. carriers—United, Delta, American, and Southwest—have effectively become banks: The difference between profit and loss comes down to the loyalty points they sell to their credit-card partners each year. Cramped passengers are ruled not by bonhomie but by hair-trigger aggression, while

flight crews seek compliance rather than kinship. No frills are left to entice or distract passengers. The main benefit of sitting in first class is that you might still be served free cocktails, while a coach passenger is left with a puny bag of carbs, one cup of soda, and complimentary (for now) trash collection. Forget about power and freedom. Commercial airplanes no longer symbolize anything except a desire to be anywhere else. Nobody cares what kind of plane they fly in anymore, so long as they are on it as little as possible.

A quarter of the 21st century has now elapsed, but the 20th century, its engines cut, has managed to stay aloft. It is now finally landing, at Pinal Airpark in Arizona. “I flew the last passenger U.S. airplane to the desert,” Captain Steve Hanlon told me by phone from Atlanta, where he works for Delta as a flight-simulator pilot instructor. In 2017, Delta retired the aircraft (Ship 6314) and the rest of its 747 fleet for the same reason every other airline did and will: A four-engine jumbo jet is more expensive to operate than newer, if less striking, alternatives. Ship 6314 went on a farewell tour of former Northwest and Delta hubs, including hangar parties in Seattle, Detroit, Atlanta, and Minneapolis and a more somber affair in L.A. “Don’t say it’s ‘sad,’” Hanlon remembers the Delta corporate reps telling him. They also changed how he referred to the vessel—“she,” as sailors have done since antiquity—in an interview for a corporate press release. “Instead they put ‘it,’” he said, scoffing.

The scene aboard Ship 6314 was celebratory. A pilot and a flight attendant, who had met on a 747 military charter years earlier, were married in the air. But Hanlon, who had been flying 747s for 20 years, felt the pull of an ending as he held the Whale’s yoke, setting the aircraft down gently on the Pinal runway, with his co-captain, Paul Gallaher, by his side. “It was sad,” Hanlon told me. “Like putting my favorite dog down.” It was the last time either man would fly a 747.

Ship 6314’s phantom neighbors include the 747 that once transported the Ohio televangelist Ernest Angley, who used the plane to spread the good word before financial issues brought him back to Earth. Japan’s equivalent to Air Force One is also here. So is a 747 that was intended for Saudi Crown Prince Sultan bin Abdul Aziz and cost \$300 million; it flew for less than 50 hours





and is now being scrapped at Pinal—the aviation equivalent of parting out a brand-new Bugatti.

When Jim Petty, Pinal's manager, parked us under the long-forsaken TWA 747, he pointed out the grid of missing skin where aluminum from the fuselage had been cut in tidy rows to make plane tags, a type of aviation collectible. Nearby, a former Korean Air vessel's nose cone had been removed clean, as if seared off with a hot knife. A galley intercom phone hung from a chasm in the tail of another 747, swinging as if dropped from a phone booth in a film noir. Just above it, Petty pointed out a hawk roost. "For five years they came here," he said. "I always thought it was cool that a bird made its nest in a plane."

When all of the useful parts have been claimed from a corpse, industrial scavengers tug the remains to a cement pad, where excavators tear the vessel into bits of metal, Petty explained. The scrap gets loaded onto 18-wheelers and hauled away for recycling. "It's never used again to make an aircraft," he said, "but it goes

Planes sent to Pinal Airpark, in Marana, Arizona, for repair, storage, or scrapping

into wheels for cars, or beer cans." Pointing at the Diet Coke he gave me upon arrival to quench my desert thirst, Petty noted that it might once have been a small piece of the Queen of the Skies.

Almost all of the engines had been harvested from these planes. Removing the weight can cause the planes to tip upward, and point their noses to the sky. The blades of one abandoned engine, lying at Pinal since 2014, issued a tinny clatter as they spun in the breeze. "It makes me think that the plane wants to head out," Petty said. "It wants to go." But both of us knew better. It was a death rattle, and for more than just a type of airplane.

In the faux-Braniff lounge aboard that first 747, at the Museum of Flight, I had asked Cheryl Grimm and Peggy Verger for their best memory of the aircraft. The former flight attendants couldn't summon a story, and instead fell back on a feeling. "You were just happy to be there," Verger said. Grimm could only echo that bygone affection: "You were just happy to be there." *A*

Ian Bogost is a staff writer at The Atlantic.



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SO YOU WANT A COAT OF ARMS

*Why America, a country founded on rejecting
aristocratic traditions, secretly loves them*

BY HELEN LEWIS

The first thing you notice upon entering the College of Arms, in London, is a small and incongruously blue statue of a kiwi, clutching a gold axe in its right claw. Sorry, let me try that again: In the odd historic language of heraldry, this is “a kiwi Azure grasping in the dexter foot an ice axe bendwise Or.”

The bird belongs to the coat of arms of Sir Edmund Hillary, a New Zealander, who was part of the first team to conquer Mount Everest. (Penguins are also involved in Hillary’s arms, as is the hearty if ungrammatical motto NOTHING VENTURE NOTHING WIN.) No one could tell me why the kiwi statue ended up in this beautiful brick building around the corner from St. Paul’s Cathedral, but the college is a magnet for this sort of historical detritus. Next to the kiwi is the cushion on which Queen Elizabeth II sat during her coronation. I lean in closely to see if any impression of the royal buttocks remains visible. It does not.

Founded in 1484, the College of Arms operates as part of the Royal Household, answering to the monarch. Its main functions are determining whether someone is entitled to use an existing coat of arms,

and granting new arms to individuals and corporations. In Britain, having a coat of arms is still part of public life; you cannot join the Order of the Garter, a personal club of worthies curated by the sovereign, without one. For a fee of about \$12,000, the college will perform the genealogical research and design work necessary to grant you arms. But the college also caters to an unlikely group of would-be knights-errant: Americans. “We get so many genuine inquiries—it’s a huge amount,” Dominic Ingram, a herald at the college who conducts such research, told me. Of the 120 or so arms the college grants each year, it estimates that up to 10 percent are honorary grants for non-British citizens, and the bulk of those go to Americans.

“I loved how the application and vetting process was essentially the same protocol that has been used for centuries,” Angelo Sedacca, from the Bronx, told me. He was granted his honorary arms—which feature castles and a lion on the shield, and a swan resting atop a pair of scales—when he was working as a sergeant in the New York Police Department, and he hopes that his descendants will appreciate using them.

During the Middle Ages, heraldic disputes could become so animated that a Court of Chivalry was called upon to resolve them. You know the sort of thing—your noble house of Scrope is using a blue shield with a gold diagonal stripe in battle, and then some arriviste dorks called the Grosvenors roll up and do the same. (This really happened: The court ruled in favor of the Scropes, and the Grosvenors had to change their arms.) The college’s workload expanded after the Industrial Revolution amid demand from the newly rich mercantile and professional classes. A coat of arms meant tradition and legitimacy.

Today, if you can find an ancestor who was “armigerous”—noble enough to bear arms—then you have an inherited right to their coat of arms. Otherwise, you can design your own, complete with chevrons, castles, and all the heraldic animals that you desire. Ingram said his heart “sinks a bit” when someone wants a lion: “There’s so many lions already.” He appreciates those who choose something unusual, such as a frog or a flamingo. A more traditional choice might be a mythical beast, such as

a unicorn, a griffin, or an enfield—“sort of like a fox but with the legs of a chicken.”

The demand for arms is so high that scammy companies have sprung up online, claiming to award arms and even titles. “I went to several different vendors on the internet only to be let down in the process,” Harry Rossander, a retired Army Corps of Engineers lieutenant colonel in Rapid City, South Dakota, told me. He eventually ended up with a design of a bald eagle perched on a tower, registered with a college of heraldry in America.

As a Briton, I sometimes find the American mania for our island’s history baffling. Then again, growing up in a place that’s lousy with old stuff will do that to you. One of the most important battles of the English Civil War was fought in what is now a park near my parents’ house in Worcester, England. In 1786, John Adams and Thomas Jefferson visited the site to see where, almost a century and a half earlier, their forebears had fought to dethrone a king, showing the world that another system of government was possible. “Tell your Neighbours and your Children that this is holy Ground, much holier than that on which your Churches stand,” Adams later wrote. “All England should come in Pilgrimage to this Hill, once a Year.” Sadly, it does not; instead, teenagers go there after school to smoke weed.

THE COLLEGE CURRENTLY consists of 11 officers of arms, who undertake the genealogical research and act as custodians of the records. (They include kings of arms, heralds, and their apprentices, who are called pursuivants.) When I emailed the college to request an interview, the response came from Ingram, who was then the herald on call. I found this concept as amusing as the other Friends find Ross having a pager, given that he’s a paleontologist. (“Is it, like, for dinosaur emergencies?” Monica asks. “Help, come quick, they’re still extinct!”) Ingram is 33; he joined the college after completing a doctorate in history at Oxford. Why did he choose this profession? I asked. “Lack of common sense?” he replied at first, but

later acknowledged that “the main advantage is you don’t really answer to anyone—well, apart from the King, I guess.” The heralds operate like independent contractors, with their own caseloads. Most of their income is from research fees, but each herald also receives an annual salary of £18 (\$24) from the King.

When the design process is complete, the precise form of the arms is recorded in giant leather-bound books. Turn to almost any page in the college’s records and an intriguing human story will jump out. Ingram showed me the legendary Admiral Horatio Nelson’s arms and family tree, which features his left-handed signature—his right arm having been lost in the Battle of Santa Cruz, in Tenerife.



As a baroness, Margaret Thatcher was entitled to “supporters,” figures on either side of her design. She chose the scientist Isaac Newton and a generic Falklands War admiral, who bears a passing resemblance to Colonel Sanders.

The first American arms began to be drawn up hours after the signing of the Declaration of Independence. In a gesture reflecting the move from monarchical privilege to democratic consulting, a committee was convened in the new country to create the Great Seal of the United States. (Like most committees, it took ages to come to any decisions. A finalized version, involving an eagle, an olive branch, and stars, was presented for approval six years later.) Even after the unfortunate

incidents of 1776, many Americans, including George Washington, still looked to the college back in London for validation. In 1791, it confirmed that the hero of the American Revolution could use the heraldic arms of the splendidly named de Hertburn family—three red mullets and two red bars on a silver background.

Ingram also showed me the arms of the Hollywood actor Douglas Fairbanks Jr., who was such an Anglophile that he trained with the Royal Navy during the Second World War and received an honorary knighthood in 1949. His blue-and-gold—sorry, azure-and-or—shield has a ribbon connecting its two halves, presumably to indicate his appeal on both sides of the Atlantic. Incidentally,

in case you are ever quizzed on this, the other heraldic colors are purple (purple), gules (red), sable (black), and vert (green). The entire language of heraldry is “a sort of pseudo-abstract, corrupted northern French,” Ingram said, reflecting its creation soon after the Norman Conquest of England. The drapery or scrollwork around a shield is called a lambrequin, a five-petaled flower is called a cinquefoil, and an emblem or animal that puns on the bearer’s name is called a rebus. Heralds are very into puns, which presumably provided endless amusement during cold medieval nights. The arms of the late Queen Mother’s family,

the Bowes-Lyons, feature bows and lions. The royal arms of Princess Beatrice—the former Prince Andrew’s daughter—have three bees on them: Bee-thrice.

Until the mid-20th century, Ingram told me, the college took a relaxed attitude toward Americans who wanted arms, and typically trusted their claims to English ancestry. But the rules have gradually tightened. When Joe Rudé, from Atlanta, was granted arms in 1995, he had to prove direct male descent from a British citizen, including those who lived in the American colonies. He came up with one Thomas Rood, an attorney from Glastonbury, in the west of England. “We don’t know a great deal about him, except that he had an unfortunate end,” Rudé, 82, told me.

"His wife died, and so he was left with several kids. After a long, hard winter, his oldest daughter turned up pregnant, and he was arrested."

And Thomas was the father? "That's what was decided by the very religious people back then," Rudé said. "And he was hanged. He is the only person hanged for incest in the history of the United States." Everyone wants to find an ancestor who's remarkable, but they don't tell you which flavor of remarkable you're going to get.

IN MY EXPERIENCE, some Americans with an overly keen interest in English aristocratic traditions seem motivated by disdain for their fellow citizens who are not descended from white Europeans. In March, the White House anti-immigration czar, Stephen Miller, posted in disgust after Britain removed the remaining 92 hereditary peers from the House of Lords. *Sir, I wanted to reply, your country rebelled against being governed by noblemen like the 12th earl of Dundee and the 24th earl of Erroll!*

But the American arms holders I interviewed cited only a sincere and nerdy interest in history, plus a passion for graphic design. "My last Simons ancestor in England was a master of the horse for one of the dukes of Rutland," Brenton Simons, from Boston, told me. He had blended the dolphin and scallop shells of the Simons arms with elements from the arms of his mother's family, the Fitches: "three leopards' heads and a chevron in gold against a green background." He had also commissioned a heraldic badge, of a fox with a sprig of strawberries in its mouth. "Some people try to squeeze too many things into their arms," said Simons, who used to be the president of the genealogical society American Ancestors. "Or create arms that look like steampunk designs. Simpler is better."

George Cobb of Gastonia, North Carolina, told me that his arms represented ancestors from Scotland who had immigrated to Appalachia. He had chosen a green background to represent "the

mountains of both Scotland and North Carolina, geologically the same mountain chain separated eons ago." He also has a golden lion and the North Star beneath a flame, which symbolizes the search for truth. "My wife's initial response was to ask where her family was represented, which led to an explanation that arms are granted to an individual rather than a couple—so now I know I will one day be designing arms for her as well," Cobb told me, adding that his best friend immediately asked

her and her two siblings) bisected by a gold chevron (for her mother's maiden name, Goldsmith). Many married women squish their arms onto a shield alongside their husband's, although this is not obligatory. Britain's legalization of same-sex unions in 2013 did not faze the heralds; in fact, Ingram told me he is eager to do a joint design for a gay couple.

Once someone has been granted arms, what do they actually do with them? "I have a vast number of paintings of my arms, but I also display them in carvings on my gateposts, on custom ties, cuff links, my cars," Brady Brim-DeForest told me. "Pretty much anywhere I can integrate them, I do!" He is such a heraldry obsessive that he petitioned for arms as a 15-year-old, only for the college to tell him to come back when he was 18. Brim-DeForest, who splits his time among Texas, Maine, and a castle in Scotland, now serves on the Committee on Heraldry at American Ancestors.

As I listened to stories of men searching for their roots, it occurred to me that even white Americans who can trace their forebears back to England are part of a diaspora. Irish Americans who have never set foot in Cork or Donegal may find themselves tearing up on St. Patrick's Day, so why wouldn't the descendants of an incestuous lawyer from Glastonbury or the duke of Rutland's servant want some connection to the old country?

By the end of my time at the college, I had begun to wonder whether a coat of arms was just an extremely upmarket version of a social-media bio. We love to put labels on ourselves, to take personality quizzes, to ruminate on what it means to be an ENTJ or a Scorpio. Creating a coat of arms is an attempt to distill your heritage, hopes, and hobbies into a striking visual form: *Here's where I came from—and what I've made of myself.* *A*

Helen Lewis is a staff writer at The Atlantic.



Opposite page: Margaret Thatcher's coat of arms.
Above: The coat of arms of Brady Brim-DeForest, a heraldry obsessive who serves on the Committee on Heraldry at American Ancestors.

if Cobb would design arms for him. "He is of Mexican and Spanish descent, and the final arms became a beautiful representation of both Aztec and Spanish ancestry."

The ancient traditions of heraldry evolve with the times. Women can bear arms, although unmarried ones traditionally display them on a diamond (known as a lozenge) or oval shape, rather than a shield. Before joining the Royal Family, Kate Middleton was granted her own lozenge, featuring three acorns (representing



*Colonel Gerald
Curry, now retired,
holds up his uniform,
which reflects his
decades of service
in the U.S. military.*

Photographs by Nate Langston Palmer

The Betrayal of Black Patriots

*They devoted their
lives to serving
the United States.
Now the nation's
top military leader
is sending the
message that they're
not welcome.*

By Clint Smith

Daniel “Chappie” James Jr. became commander of the Wheelus Air Base, near Tripoli, just after rebels under Muammar Qaddafi took control of Libya in a coup in 1969. In the midst of the insurgency, Qaddafi led an effort to break into the U.S. air base, but James managed to close the gate in time to prevent the young rebel from entering. The incident, which James recounted in a 1978 interview, would come to be the stuff of Air Force lore. As the two men confronted each other, the story goes, Qaddafi got out of his vehicle and reached for his gun. James had a .45 in his belt. He told Qaddafi that he’d better not pull the gun, or he’d regret it. They stared at each other for a moment as the future dictator considered James. Then Qaddafi pulled his hand away, got back in his vehicle, and drove off. The rebels never attempted a similar stunt again. One reporter later referred to James as a “black John Wayne.”

By the time he was facing off with Qaddafi in Libya, James had already served in the military for 26 years. During World War II, he’d trained at the Tuskegee Institute, before joining the 477th Bombardment Group—the first unit of Black bombers in U.S. military history. He then flew 101 combat missions in the Korean War, and 78 more in the Vietnam War.

James was eventually promoted to four-star general, becoming the first Black American in the history of the U.S. military to reach that rank. “If my making

an advancement can serve as some kind of spark to some young Black or other minority, it will be worth all the years, all the blood and sweat it took in getting here,” he said at the time. The general became a hero to Black Democrats and white Republicans alike. At a 1987 ceremony dedicating an aerospace-science and health-education center at Tuskegee University to James, Ronald Reagan called him a “darned good pilot and a revered military officer and a truly great American.” In 2020, the state of Florida named a bridge after James; the bill was signed by Governor Ron DeSantis.

But last year, after Donald Trump signed executive orders gutting DEI programs across the federal government and the military, people in the Pentagon noticed that a painting of James had been taken down from its prominent location in the Air Force Art Gallery. Instead of putting a new painting in the spot where James’s portrait had been, the Pentagon kept the space empty, leaving employees with the impression that, in spite of his many achievements, the new administration viewed the general as a symbol of unearned advancement, unworthy of recognition.

James, who died in 1978, might not have been surprised. “One of the most insulting questions that gets asked to me sometimes is *Did they give you your fourth star just because it’s the bicentennial year coming up and they wanted to say we got a*

Black general?” he said in a 1975 interview. “They didn’t give me anything. And they don’t give away stars in my service. You got to earn them.”

He may as well have been responding directly to Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth, who derided “affirmative action promotions” in the military in his 2024 book, *The War on Warriors*. “Our strength,” Hegseth wrote, “is not in our diversity.” At the Pentagon, Hegseth has directly intervened to block or delay the promotions of more than a dozen Black and female senior officers; he has dismissed or pushed out several high-ranking Black and female officers; he has presided over the restoration of tributes to Confederate soldiers, traitors to the United States who fought a war predicated on maintaining and expanding the institution of slavery. All of these actions are extensions of the same project: delegitimizing the accomplishments—and the very presence—of Black people in the military. Some Black service members have chosen to quit or retire early in response to what they see as a newly hostile environment; others are still serving but feel deeply demoralized.

In interviews with two dozen currently enlisted, civilian, and retired Black members of the military across the armed forces, person after person told me they have watched in dismay as a new administration has diminished and erased a proud history. Many of the officers I spoke with were the second or third generation in their family to serve, and had children who were serving as well. Racism in the military, they were quick to remind me, is not new. Those who came before them had it much harder. At the same time, it has been difficult to see the gains of their forebears undermined so starkly in such a short period. They are concerned about the cost of this administration’s actions for individual Black service members, and for Black Americans more generally.

“Right now,” one retired senior Air Force officer told me, “I’m questioning whether it was all in vain.”

WHEN COLONEL GERALD CURRY was a child, he and his family visited a cousin who lived on Fort Knox, in Kentucky. The base had a movie theater and



Daniel “Chappie” James Jr. during the Vietnam War. James became the first Black American to be promoted to four-star general.

a shopping center, and the house, to his astonishment, had a basement. “In my small mind, this was luxury,” he told me. Curry looked at his cousin standing in his beautiful home, in his pristine Army uniform, and saw security and pride. He began to imagine himself in a uniform and a house just like those.

That trip to Fort Knox stayed with Curry. At Tennessee State University, a historically Black university in Nashville, he joined ROTC; later, after graduation, he joined the Air Force. Most of the men in Curry’s family—including his father and grandfather—had served, but they had been drafted and had not remained in uniform long enough to procure the same benefits that his cousin had. If he stayed in the service for 20 years, he would receive a pension for the rest of his life. Service would provide not only stability, he understood, but also mobility: a chance to see the world, educational opportunities (Curry would go on to earn a Ph.D.), the kind of house he’d dreamed of since he was a kid, a safety net for future generations. A chance to follow his father’s and grandfather’s lead and prove that the country belonged as much to them as it did to anyone else; going back to the Revolution and the Civil War, military service for Black Americans has been a powerful symbol of their commitment to a country that has not always shown commitment to them.

Curry also understood that racism was still present in the Air Force. In the early 1980s, during basic training in Wichita, Kansas, at McConnell Air Force Base, Curry’s roommate, a Black man from Ohio, had been asked by a white captain to help prepare a meal. When the white captain found out that the roommate had blown off the task, he slapped him “and called him a fucking nigger.” Curry, who at the time was a top-ranked kickboxer in the United States, glared at the captain and stepped toward him, daring him to do or say something else. The captain backed off, but Curry never forgot the look in his eyes, or the venom in his voice.

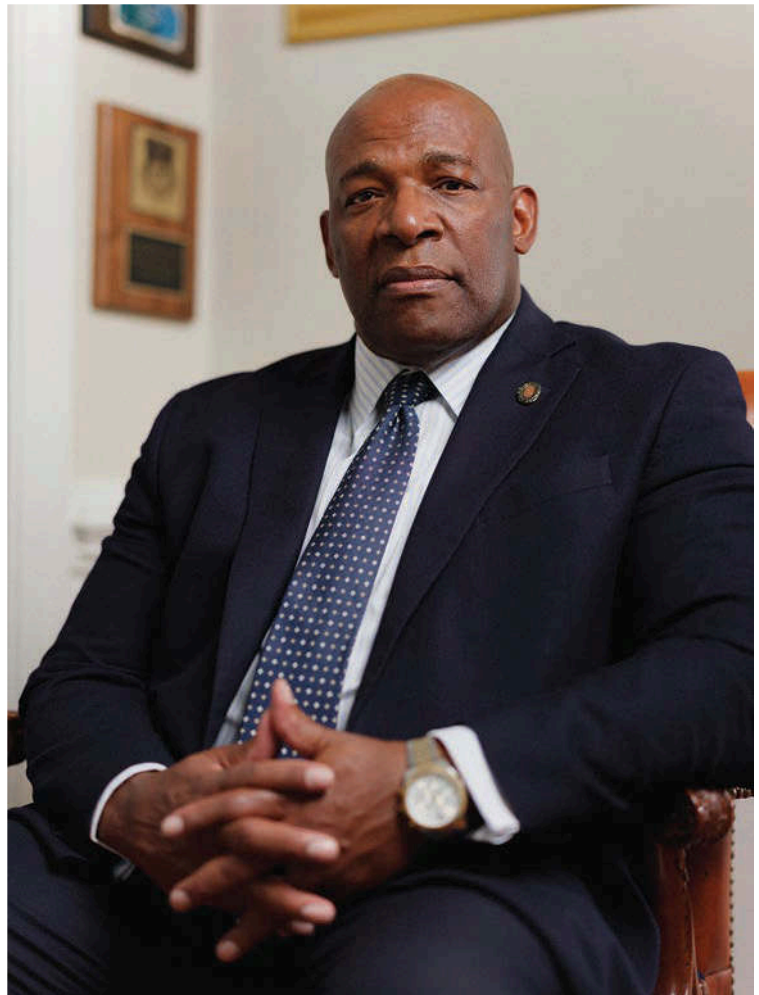
Curry graduated and received his officer commission in 1983. He was smart, athletic, and likable, and he ascended the ranks quickly. By 1989, Curry had become

a squadron commander, responsible for law enforcement for the entire Hahn Air Base, which had about 10,000 people, in Germany. At 28, he told me, he was the youngest Air Force squadron commander in all of Europe. “The Cold War was still going on, and we had medium-range nuclear missiles that were pointed toward Moscow,” Curry recalled. His job was to protect these tactical nuclear weapons and the F-16s on base. The job brought prestige, but also a sense of isolation. It was not uncommon for Curry to be the only Black officer in meetings.

He and the few other Black officers on base made a point of getting to know the more junior Black service members and their families; they would all get together at one another’s homes after church,

bonding over shared culture while far from home. “It was important to build a community that would support you in your career,” Curry said, “because oftentimes you had to navigate hostile waters.” During meetings where promotions were decided, white officers would sometimes make disparaging comments to Black airmen, Curry recalled. Sometimes they wouldn’t say anything at all. “You would walk away from a meeting knowing that you had done everything in your power and you had outdone your white peers, and you still wouldn’t get selected.”

Curry served 27 years on active duty, and another 15 in a civilian capacity in the Pentagon. In 2019, he became the director of the Air Force Review Boards



Curry at home in Virginia

Agency (Curry likens it to the Supreme Court of the Air Force), the equivalent of a two-star-general position. Racial progress in the military had been slow, but visible: When Curry graduated from Tennessee State in 1983, there had been only a handful of active-duty Black generals and admirals. By 2024, there were more than 80. Among them were Lloyd Austin, who had become the first Black secretary of defense in 2021; C. Q. Brown, then the chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff; Michael E. Langley, the first Black four-star general in Marine Corps history; and Darryl A. Williams, who'd been West Point's first Black superintendent.

When Trump took office last year, Curry tried to keep an open mind. But just after he was inaugurated, Trump signed the anti-DEI executive orders. Then, four weeks after he was confirmed as secretary of defense, Hegseth told Brown that he'd been fired while Brown was visiting troops on the southern border. Curry became furious as he watched the Department of Defense take down the portrait of General James, whom he considers a hero, from the Air Force Art Gallery. He said he'd passed the painting daily on the way to his office for more than a decade; it made him smile and buoyed him to "keep on keeping on." Curry is writing a leadership book based on James's service, and meets regularly with James's son and granddaughter; he is also working with the family to develop a film about James's life. Seeing the newly empty wall space "really, really hurt." (When reached for comment before this

article went to press, Joel Valdez, the acting Pentagon press secretary, said that the Air Force had "added" a portrait of James to a different location "in the past two to three weeks.")

In May 2025, Troy Meink was confirmed as secretary of the Air Force. Shortly after Meink arrived at the Pentagon, he told senior leadership, including Curry, that the Air Force would remove books from military libraries and educational institutions that fell under the wide umbrella of "DEI." Curry was aghast. This, on top of the broader dismantling of initiatives that he believed were finally bringing some measure of equal opportunity to the military, was too much. Curry notified senior Pentagon leadership that he would retire.

He did not, however, want more junior officers to be pushed out of the military by a racist administration. At a luncheon held a few months later to celebrate his decades of service, he told the young Black officers in the room that it was now their responsibility to support one another. He encouraged them to stay in the service to defend the country and the Constitution. "You've got to carry it on. It's going to be tough. And sometimes you're going to have to swallow your pride," he recalled saying to them. As Brigadier General Jimmy E. McMillian, a retired Air Force officer, told me, "If everybody that cares walks away, there will be nobody left who cares."

Other senior Black military officials I spoke with expressed a similar sentiment. As one told me, "This country is

great because of us, despite how they have treated us. And when I think about what I'm willing to live or die for, I would not sit idly by and let someone else come in and take away what we've built, despite some folks not recognizing the role that we played in building it."

But there was a disconnect, it seemed, between these ideas and Curry's actions. He was encouraging young officers to stay in the military and fight for their place within it when he himself had chosen to retire. How did he reconcile those two things?

Curry considered the question. "Just because you're not in uniform doesn't mean that you're not still serving, that you're not still contributing value to the fight," he said. In retirement, he noted, he has the ability to speak more freely than if he had remained at the Pentagon. He also acknowledged that being able to step away is a privilege; he had long since completed the two decades of military service necessary to receive his pension. He got the house. He got the promotions. He got the recognition from his peers and the insignia on his uniform. He got the financial stability that allowed him to support his family.

For younger service members, deciding to quit comes with professional and financial consequences. Curry worries about the long-term damage being done to Black officers; some young Black Americans who see what's happening in the military today, he realizes, may decide not to enlist at all. "In my opinion, it's going to take us about 30 or 40 years to be able to create the appetite for Black men and women to want to serve and see the military as a viable career option," he said. Curry and others hope that day will return eventually. (Sean Parnell, the chief Pentagon spokesperson, said in a statement that "individuals from all races, religions, and backgrounds are enlisting in our armed forces with greater enthusiasm than ever before.")

The retired senior Air Force officer who told me he was "questioning whether it was all in vain" also spoke about his hopes for the future. The officer was one of several people I interviewed who asked to remain anonymous out of fear of personal or professional retribution. "I look at this

"This country is great because of us, despite how they have treated us."



Robert Cook looks through photographs from early in his military career.

as a bad fever,” he said, “and one day that fever is going to break.” But who will be left once it does?

BRIGADIER GENERAL MCMILLIAN worries that more early retirements could mean that young Black service members end up with fewer senior Black officers to serve as mentors and examples. “They look up and nobody in the room looks like them—that has a huge impact on your morale,” McMillian told me. “If Black officers don’t get mentors, it can kill their careers pretty early.”

But that, he thinks, is exactly what the defense secretary and his ilk want. “If Pete Hegseth and the current administration

had their way, you wouldn’t see any of us in key leadership positions,” he said. “I think the whole idea is to eliminate as many of us as they can, take us back as far as they can.”

Essentially, “we’re talking about an administration that says, *When people of color succeed, they took that opportunity out of the hands of a qualified white man*,” Marc Brooks, a retired master sergeant in the Air Force, told me. (Parnell, the Pentagon spokesperson, said in his statement that “all personnel changes by the Secretary of War’s office are based on merit and job performance.”)

McMillian, who retired in 2012, knows firsthand about overt racism in the military. When he was a major and a

commander in the 1990s, someone wrote GO HOME, NIGGER on one of the police vehicles under his purview. (An investigation failed to identify the person responsible for the vandalism.) He also knows that racism can manifest in more subtle ways. Throughout his 30 years in the Air Force, he worked to mentor Black officers, and particularly Black female officers, whom he thought had been systematically overlooked and might need extra support to remain in the service. “I was criticized for that early on in my career,” he told me—other male officers warned him that he might be perceived as showing favoritism to Black women—but he kept doing it anyway.

McMillian had grown up in rural North Carolina, where he attended segregated schools and was raised by a single mother with an elementary-school education. “She always would tell us, ‘You got to do better than me,’” McMillian said. At North Carolina A&T State University, a historically Black university in Greensboro, he joined ROTC. He eventually became the director of the Air Force’s Security Forces, in charge of some 40,000 people around the world. He was the first Black person to hold the position.

The longer McMillian spent in the military, the more he understood that success was not simply a matter of doing your job well. A Black service member had to learn to navigate tacit social and political norms—it was important to spend evenings at the officers’ club, for instance, even if you didn’t drink or would rather be with your family. He advised young Black officers not to have facial hair. He told them to consider themselves on duty at all times; even if they were just going to the convenience store, they should wear khakis and a nice shirt, not flip-flops and shorts. If their music was too loud when they drove around on base, he would tell them they needed to turn it down, not because it bothered him, but because there were people looking for reasons not to promote them. He had benefited from other Black officers having frank conversations with him about these dynamics, and so, as he advanced in his career, he tried to share this knowledge with younger Black

members of the Air Force. “You don’t know what you don’t know,” he said.

He finds it ironic that Hegseth has put so much emphasis on the idea of unearned “affirmative action” promotions when McMillian believes that Hegseth himself—a former Fox News host who retired from the military as a low-ranking senior officer—is unqualified for the job of secretary. McMillian cited, as an example of what he sees as the secretary’s politicized agenda, the speech that Hegseth gave in Quantico, Virginia, in September 2025, for which he’d made the unusual decision to require 800 generals and admirals to travel in from their posts around the world. In the speech, Hegseth told military leaders that it was okay to use profanity with subordinates or even to “put hands” on them—seeming to suggest that he would condone physical assault. If they faced complaints of unfair treatment or discrimination, Hegseth said, the Pentagon would make sure that their records remained clean.

Some Black service members told me that they interpreted this as a license for white officers to treat their Black subordinates poorly, without fear of repercussion. “It’s setting up a climate that perpetuates and protects wrongdoing,” Brooks told me. The tone of the speech was *Get on board or get out*. Listening to it, he said, “sent shock waves to those of us that spent a career in our beloved military.”

Robert Cook, who joined the Army out of Hampton University’s ROTC program, agreed with this assessment. Cook believes that the speech could, for instance, empower a white sergeant to overlook the work of his Black private, or a white captain to disregard the contributions of his Black lieutenant. “Under a good set of leaders, no white person wants to be accused of being a racist,” Cook told me. “Under this leadership, it could be seen as a badge of honor.”

In 2022, Joe Biden named Cook principal deputy assistant secretary of the Army for financial management and comptroller. Not long after, he became the Army’s acting chief of financial operations, responsible for a \$188 billion budget and 15,000 employees. He worked closely with Joint Chiefs of Staff Chairman Brown as

well as Secretary of Defense Austin, whom he’d known since the mid-’90s. Because Cook was a political appointee, he knew he would be leaving the Pentagon in early 2025. But although he says he had never had any trouble working with Republicans, many of whom he considered friends, he grew concerned about Trump’s intentions for the Pentagon even before the president returned to office. “Everybody knew that they were coming in to just gut the place and put their sycophants in,” Cook said.

During his first meetings with members of Trump’s DOD transition team, Cook was asked to single out the funds that had been appropriated for DEI initiatives. Cook, who had championed many of these programs, wasn’t going to make this task easier for the new administration. “When you get into the office,” he said, “you can look that up yourself.”

Other officers I spoke with expressed concern that both the new political appointees and some officers put in place by the administration might be dangerously underqualified for the jobs they were filling. Dan Caine, who replaced Brown as chairman, was considered an especially unorthodox pick. Caine had not attained the rank of four-star general, and had never led a joint military command.

Ultimately, having people like Hegseth in senior leadership, Cook thinks, has enabled immoral and even unconstitutional behavior in the military. Cook, who is now retired and works in the private sector, became particularly incensed when the military began bombing boats in the Caribbean in September. “I can’t shoot you because I suspect you’re a drug dealer,” Cook said, and yet that was exactly what seemed to be happening. Hegseth had already taken the highly atypical action of removing the judge advocates general of the Army, the Navy, and the Air Force, who were responsible for making sure that military actions were legal and authorized. He replaced them with people of his own choosing, saying that the administration wanted lawyers who “don’t exist to be roadblocks to anything.” (The Pentagon spokesperson said that all military operations in the Caribbean have been

conducted “in complete compliance with the law of armed conflict.”)

In October, Admiral Alvin Holsey, who had been the head of the U.S. military’s Southern Command, which oversees Central America, South America, and the Caribbean, abruptly announced his retirement. Holsey, who is Black, didn’t give a reason for his retirement, but *The New York Times* reported that he “had raised concerns about the mission and the attacks on the alleged drug boats.”

Cook is worried about the implications of these sorts of actions for American service members in enemy territory. Since the war in Iran began, he has become even more concerned about the possibility of retribution. “You want to bomb kids in a school and not apologize for it,” he said, of Pentagon leadership. “What do you think they’re gonna do with us?”

ONE ARMY OFFICER I spoke with, whom I’ll call Reginald, joined Junior ROTC in high school. His father was absent, and Reginald said that the Black Vietnam veterans who were in charge of the program were the first examples he’d encountered of “responsible Black men.” Much like Gerald Curry, Reginald was drawn to the military for the reliability it promised: “What I saw was stability, discipline, and financial security.”

After graduating from college, Reginald joined the Army and was deployed for multiple tours, including to both Iraq and Afghanistan. Over time, he realized that many of his fellow soldiers had learned more about the cultural and ethnic dynamics of these foreign nations than about those of their own country. “I found it very ironic, and almost hypocritical,” Reginald said. “We put so much emphasis on understanding the tribal history of these places, and yet we put almost no emphasis on understanding how we came to be. We just assume that we put on a uniform and all of our disparities melt away.”

Reginald’s desire to help add context to American history in military education led him to teach at West Point. As a Black American, he said, “if you’re not careful, you’re going to lose yourself in this thing and forget who you really are.”

He brought up a talk that the writer Ta-Nehisi Coates gave at West Point in 2017, in which Coates encouraged the room of more than 800 students, faculty, and staff to reflect on the Cadet Honor Code: “A cadet will not lie, cheat, steal, or tolerate those who do.” The intolerance of lies, Coates argued, should not apply only to individuals, but also to the country and its military more broadly. “If you’re going to be intolerant about the deceptions amongst each other,” he told the cadets, “there’s nothing wrong with being equally intolerant about the deceptions people ask you to submit to.” When Reginald and I spoke, the speech had

commercial texts—those not created by the military—that their division loans to trainees. They were also told to remove whole sections about accomplished Black service members from educational materials produced by the military.

Sarah had been deeply involved in a Black affinity group within her branch of the military, which she said helped her feel supported and motivated. This group, along with a number of others dedicated to examining and addressing inequities in the military, has been disbanded. In an Orwellian statement, a spokesperson for Sarah’s branch said that the “disestablishment” of these groups

she could qualify for a full pension, but she now plans on leaving the military before the end of the year. “I can’t ethically and morally continue down this road,” she said.

Reginald described the experience of being Black in the military as akin to being in a pool that’s filling up slowly, drip by drip. “As the pool fills up with little drops of water, the weight of that over time just gets heavier and heavier and heavier. And then you look up and you’re like, *Man, I’m drowning.*”

For his part, Reginald has decided that instead of getting out of the pool, he is going to swim harder. “Hegseth and all of



*Marc Brooks's medals
on display at his
home in Maryland*

recently been deleted from a West Point YouTube page.

Many such challenges to a narrow conception of patriotism are now being deliberately excluded from military education. Another person I interviewed, whom I’ll call Sarah, develops training materials for the military. After Trump issued his executive orders targeting DEI in January 2025, Sarah said, her commanders told her team to manually strike out certain language in dozens of

had been carried out “in compliance with executive orders Ending Radical and Wasteful Government DEI Programs and Preferencing, and Initial Rescissions of Harmful Executive Orders and Actions.” Valdez, the acting Pentagon press secretary, put the administration’s ideological aims more bluntly in an email: “We are proud to declare DEI is dead in the Department of War.”

Sarah’s original plan was to work for at least 20 years before retiring so that

his bravado ain’t a strong enough person to get me to step aside from 20 years of something that I feel connected to,” he told me. “Because this is mine; this isn’t yours. You’re paying rent here.” He took a deep breath. “I’ve got too much invested in this thing.”

As the descendant of enslaved people, Reginald is sustained by his sense of history. He is operating in the tradition of Chappie James; of Hazel Johnson-Brown, the first Black woman to become a general

in the military; of Charles Young, a man born into slavery who became the first Black person to achieve the rank of colonel in the Army; of Lewis and Charles Douglass, sons of Frederick Douglass, who were among the first Black Americans to volunteer for the Union Army; and of James Gratz Thompson, a 26-year-old Black cafeteria worker from Wichita, who asked in a letter to *The Pittsburgh Courier* shortly after the attack on Pearl Harbor, “Should I sacrifice my life to live half American?”

“Will things be better for the next generation in the peace to follow?” “Would it be demanding too much to demand full citizenship rights in exchange for the sacrificing of my life?” “Is the kind of America I know worth defending?”

Thompson would go on to serve as a corporal in the Army during World War II. His letter to the *Courier*, a prominent Black newspaper in the early to mid-20th century, is credited with catalyzing its “Double V” campaign, which urged Black Americans to use the war as an opportunity to fight both fascism abroad and racism at home.

Some Black Americans were compelled by the idea, while others rejected the notion that they should fight for a country that was still hanging them from trees. Black service members have wrestled with the complexities of patriotism for centuries, from the Revolution to the current war in Iran. Reginald said that, for him—in the tradition of the Double V campaign—service feels worthwhile as a way to continue fighting for the country he thinks America can be.

“I swear an oath to the Constitution. And I remember that the idea to form a more perfect union would suggest that we will never be perfect,” he said. “But we’ve got to try to strive to be. And I’m okay with doing that work of trying.”

IN MAY, I DROVE to Arlington National Cemetery, where I stood in front of Chappie James’s tombstone. He died of a heart attack just three weeks after retiring from the Air Force. He was 58 years old.



Gerald Curry's photo album. Curry, who joined ROTC in college, rose quickly in the ranks of the Air Force.

In March 2025, Arlington was embroiled in controversy when it began scrubbing its website of links and references to Black, Latino, and women veterans—among them James, Johnson-Brown, and Colin Powell—to comply with the anti-DEI executive orders. Following public outcry, the cemetery republished the names but said that, in keeping with Trump’s directives and the Pentagon’s instructions, “individuals from the previously listed categories ‘African American History,’ ‘Hispanic American History’ and ‘Women’s History’” could now be found under more general labels, such as, “Science, Technology and Engineering.”

In Arlington, the sky was blue and the breeze was cool. I walked to the other side of James’s tombstone and found, engraved there, words he’d written in 1967 and later

delivered as part of a speech to a group of Air Force officers after the assassination of Martin Luther King Jr. In his remarks, James said that despite the way America had continued to fail Black Americans, he was still compelled to fight for it: “This is my country and I believe in her,” he said. “And I’ll serve her, and I’ll contribute to her welfare whenever and however I can. If she has any ills, I’ll stand by her until in God’s given time, through her wisdom and her consideration for the welfare of the entire nation, she will put them right.”

James’s portrait may have been taken down at the Pentagon, but his service to the United States cannot so easily be discarded. *A*

Clint Smith is a staff writer at The Atlantic.



Who adopted who?

Adopt a teen.
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THRILLS



The whimsy, weirdness,
and heartbreak of
secondhand shopping

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BY Caitly Weaver

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W

e have limited time on this Earth to get a good look at one another's belongings. We need to move on this—fast—because the years we spend alive could well be our only opportunity for snooping. And it's so interesting to see what everyone has!

Drink coasters shaped like pieces of well-known fruit, a woven cage for transporting a chicken, a new-in-box gelato maker—these are the stones from which the cathedral of man's experience is raised.

To be a secondhand shopper is to see the riches of the world and be satisfied that they are enough. *Don't turn any sand into spanking-new champagne coupes on my account.* It is also to indulge the wanton impulse of every person to spy on other people. Archaeologists have been cataloging dump sites since at least the early 19th century, when Danish scientists began pawing through heaps of mollusk shells that had been discarded by their Stone Age ancestors. Indeed, studying what people throw away (eventually, people throw away almost everything) is one of the most efficient ways to learn about them.

One needn't be an archaeologist to snoop through others' trash. In the United States, the layman can do this any day of the week, especially Saturday, if the weather is nice. This spring, I decided to see what I could learn about my fellow Americans' lives—and how much I could improve my own life through their discards—for \$100.

1. Garage Sales

YOU NEVER KNOW when God will bring a wonderful new Christmas decoration into your life. My family got our light-up snowman when our neighbor shot himself. I discovered this as a child after he appeared on the landing of our front steps (the snowman!—Christ). My mother, I suspect, had intended to pass him off as a light-up snowman that she had bought brand-new. But my mother never bought anything as big as three feet tall brand-new. Also, his paint was burned off in just the same spots as the snowman that had, for years, served as a jolly sentry outside our neighbor's front door—a position that was now vacant, while our own home was, in a first, conspicuously and festively guarded. “You stole their snowman?” I asked. “I did no such thing!” my mother yelled. (She was constantly doing no such thing.) “They were throwing it away!”

The point of this story is: You need to be shopping for Christmas decorations year-round. If you're not buying jingle bells in July—if you're not steeling your heart against others' misfortunes in order to scour the residue of their lives for Christmas bibelots that are no longer of any use to them because they have, with all due respect, shot themselves—you are overpaying.

Perhaps you think you don't need any more Christmas decorations. You do; imagining that you possess a sufficient quantity of Christmas decorations evinces a dullness of spirit that lets me know that any Christmas extravaganza you think you're pulling off is anemic at best, and not even worthy of the term. Perhaps you will protest that you do not observe Christmas. That's absolutely no reason not to decorate for it. You should be tossing up ornaments for every holiday you can get your hands on—secular winter decor is fine—simply because they catch the eye, and people who walk by your home will enjoy the pizzazz.

This is why I am so pleased to see, on one block of a community yard sale surrounded by naked scrubland, a white pickup truck's bed overflowing with boxes of colorful Christmas balls. Hung off its lowered tailgate is a handwritten sign reading FREE. These balls are just the sort I seek: cheap plastic ones covered in glitter, which look as pretty as anything on Earth when hung outdoors, to dazzle in the sun. I need them (I fear the information barreling toward us from the bottom of this paragraph will make my reader question the appropriateness of that verb) to meet a private goal I have set. This past winter, while laboriously freeing the trees and bushes outside my home of the Christmas barnacles I had affixed there months earlier, I decided, for the first time, to count how many ornaments I had hung. I recall, as I load the boxes from the pickup truck into the back seat of my car, that the total was extremely close to a shocking milestone. The number 1,000 is blaring in my head, even though that sounds crazy. Did I really hang approximately but not quite 1,000 small Christmas ornaments outside my house? That would explain why it had looked absolutely sick. And now, thanks to this infusion of free ornaments, I will be able to hang a clean 1,000 next Christmas. Well—

Would you believe that I was wrong? I check the note on my iPhone, where I recorded my tally. It turns out that I already have, stored in my garage, nearly 2,000 ornaments. And now I have more. “Take it all!” urges a cheerful woman, emerging from the home that belongs to the pickup. No problem.

This coincidence—one household possessing such a quantity of superfluous Christmas decorations that its members are moved to put them in their driveway and impel passersby to remove them; my having sufficient space to store 2,000-plus Christmas decorations—is a manifestation of the same conditions responsible for the birth of garage sales in the United States seven decades ago.

In the years following World War II, single-family homes spread across the nation like fireweed. In a distinctively American architectural feature, many of them were joined to a small dungeon dedicated to the tidy storage of automobiles—and other items. Loosed of the wartime imperative to manufacture

anti-aircraft guns and submarine torpedoes, factories were free to make bone-rattling dishwashers and mint-colored refrigerators. In the first five years after the war, Americans' spending on household furnishings and appliances surged 240 percent.

In *From Goodwill to Grunge: A History of Secondhand Styles and Alternative Economies*, the historian Jennifer Le Zotte writes that the novel spaciousness of suburban homes (in contrast to cramped city apartments) was, paradoxically, responsible for the birth of private sales intended to help homeowners pare down the contents of their dwellings. Unlike people living in cities, suburbanites had room to hold on to old things indefinitely. Subject to the same storage maxim that explains why a purse of any size is always full—the amount of a person's belongings will expand to fill the space available—the roominess of the suburban home and garage, Le Zotte writes, “made it possible for a single family to acquire and retain” so many “unwanted items” that, eventually, they *had* to have a yard sale.

Conveniently, this period coincided with a spike in popularity of a hobby that had been inaugurated during the Gilded Age: collecting old American things. Before the late 19th century, Le Zotte writes, wealthy Americans, if they bought any antiques at all, prioritized the acquisition of “foreign-made items.” The deluge of affordable new goods that flooded the country post-industrialization, she suggests, caused shoppers to perceive a “scarcity” in items that were original or unique; items traceable to the country's colonial past came into vogue. Postwar prosperity gave more Americans the leisure time, disposable income, and car space to begin antiques. Le Zotte reports that by the 1970s, more than 10 million garage sales were taking place in the United States every year, and people were paying more than \$1 billion (cumulatively) for their neighbors' discards.

But statistics fail to convey the humanity of yard sales—the caprice, whimsy, and high spirits, as well as the cunning, weirdness, and heartbreak, that charge and thicken the air when two people agree to perform an off-the-books monetary transaction. Years ago, at a different community yard sale (surrounded by different naked scrubland), a woman sold me a canvas-mounted collection of 19th-century barbed-wire samples on the condition that I look her in the eye and promise that I would mount the contents of an additional box of loose 19th-century barbed-wire samples that she was including in the low price. She had made an identical promise to the person from whom she herself had purchased both the mounted and unmounted barbed wire, and felt guilt for decades at having

failed to keep it (though not so much guilt that she ever got around to doing so). I assured her that I would do it—and let me tell you the lesson I began learning the second I got everything home: It is real, real easy to not ever get around to meticulously mounting dozens of stray pieces of rusty barbed wire when you already have a dynamite display of diverse varieties—“10 Point Spur” (1887), “Crandal's Champion” (1879), “Sawtooth Ribbon Wire” (1881)—hanging fetchingly above the television in your living room. Eventually, I solved this

promise by fobbing the loosies off on my friend Renee, who, having no such dynamite display, was compelled to mount them (she claims, and I choose to believe her).

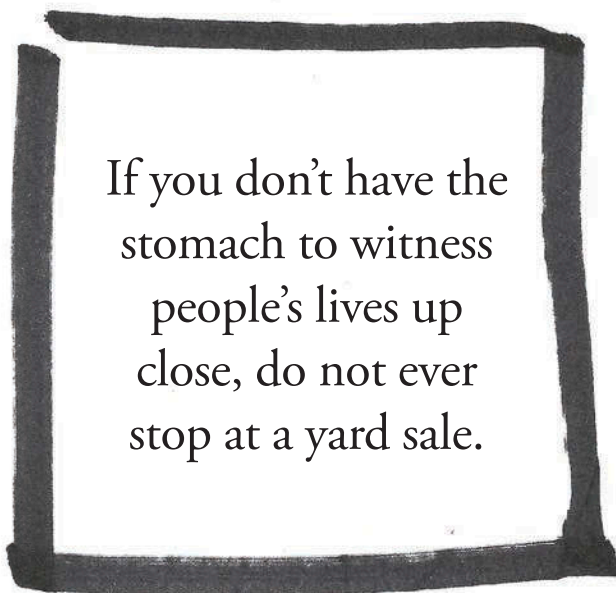
The efficient yard-sale shopper is not an empath. For every bubbly homeowner encouraging you to take this vintage Coleman cooler—featuring the 1980s MTV logo floating in the ocean—off her hands for free, there is a downcast seller attempting to unload dozens of Precious Moments figurines at \$10 to \$20 a pop because, she says, she doesn't want to bring them all to Texas, where she is moving to help take care of her mother, who has dementia. (Or

maybe she privately does want to take them? Not going to get many bites at those prices.) For every delightful discovery of a charmingly wacky neighborhood where one resident's garage-door mural features an alien camouflaged among the paddles of a prickly pear cactus, and another homeowner has installed a rooftop statue of an orange pig with blue angel wings, there will be a haunting encounter with a nearly silent man hoping to sell a single button-down shirt for 50 cents. If you don't have the stomach to witness people's lives up close, do not ever stop at a yard sale.

PURCHASES:

- Christmas balls for outdoor display: \$0
- Skull carved from stone (for Halloween) and mercury-glass Christmas ornaments: \$5
- Open jewelry cleaner: \$0
- Fleece blankets in sunset colors featuring vaguely southwestern motifs (stepped diamonds, serrated zigzags, geometric crosses, etc.): \$0
- Coleman cooler with MTV logo: \$0
- Another Christmas ornament (vintage): 50 cents
- Saddle blanket: \$4
- Gallon ziplock bag of vintage European-beer coasters: \$0

TOTAL: \$9.50



castoffs for donation. These sacks eventually came stamped with a label: THE GOODWILL BAG.

But it was the Salvation Army that truly pioneered what Le Zotte calls “the large-scale philanthropic salvage goods system.” This organization’s roots stretch back to 1860s England. Early adherents practiced a public evangelism that *The New York Times* characterized as “propagating Christianity by rowdy prayers and tambourines.” Members might dress in random articles (coats, helmets) of discarded military gear—or else in torn, dirty rags as a manifestation of their empathy with the abject poor. New, fashionable clothing, it was implied, was materialistic and ungodly.

In New York, restrictions on itinerant peddlers benefited the Salvation Army’s retail operation, which sold the same sort of pre-owned wares from storefronts, rather than from rickety pushcarts. Pamphlets detailing how goods were disinfected prior to sale shelacked an additional veneer of respectability onto the enterprise.

The Salvation Army Thrift Store closest to my home in Santa Fe seems to have relaxed last century’s strict emphasis on cleanliness. Skylights the color of sticky fly tape give the interior a distinct yellow cast, like an image from an old newspaper. Next to a limp rack of sleeveless tops stands a postapocalyptic forager-warrior mannequin in jeans, a faded plaid shirt, and a black baseball cap from the plus-size-women’s brand Torrid. Slung around his torso: an olive-green bag designed to carry a gas mask. Each time I see this figure out of the corner of my eye—as in, every single time I visit this store—I mistake it for a large living person and leap in fright. As I shop around him, the mannequin’s parted, down-turned lips give him the dazed yet dismayed expression of a chiseled male model watching extraterrestrials eviscerate a cow from a distance of several yards.

A more pleasant, or at least less yellow, shopping experience is to be had at Savers, a for-profit chain that speaks of a murky connection to charity in announcements that blare over the speaker system at regular intervals: “Shopping in our stores doesn’t support any nonprofit,” begins the riddle, “but donating your reusable goods does.” Oh no! Or good? Well, anyway, the thing about Savers is that it is big, huge—picture the inside of Mount Rainier, except all one level and very brightly lit.

And it has everything. All day long, in the parking lot, people are driving up, popping their trunks, and unloading a bag, or two, or sometimes an entire car’s worth, of any objects that they want to be rid of without the implied finality of throwing them in the trash. Most of them will still end up there. Clothes especially. The EPA classifies clothing as a “nondurable good”—meaning that the agency expects people to wear every piece of their clothing for less than three years. This improbable estimate may even be too conservative: The U.S. International Trade Commission reports that consumers jettison about half of all “fast fashion items” (which it defines, rather bitchily, as “inexpensive, low quality clothing that quickly cycles out of style”) within one year.

Of that unwanted apparel—about 13 million tons in 2018—85 percent is annually sent to a landfill or incinerated. Most of the rest is donated to charities or thrift stores; of this, half will be recycled into “lower-value” products such as industrial rags and insulation. (“Bottle-to-fiber” recycling is so popular that a recycled

PET bottle is now more likely to become polyester fabric than another bottle. It is far less common to turn plastic clothing into drinking vessels.) Only about 20 percent of the textiles donated to thrift stores is actually sold to shoppers.

The vast wall of dangling accessories at Savers includes multiple pieces of abalone jewelry—each one of which I must pick up to admire its iridescence, the closest nature has come to reproducing the most flamboyantly beautiful phenomenon on Earth: the gasoline rainbow. I do not purchase any abalone jewelry on my recent visit, because I already own too much, and all of it looks bad on me, and I’ll buy it another time. But I do snap up two pairs of vintage drop earrings with open-backed bezels—a pair with green stones that, in sunlight, have the translucent glow of a watermelon rind made of jelly; and a pair with stones that from certain angles are the black-blue of crow feathers, and from others appear as clear as raindrops—for \$2.99 each.

A week later, finding myself in New York City, I approach a few dealers in the Diamond District to ask what they make of the pairs of earrings. I am told, variously, that they are from the Victorian era; that they are from the 1990s; that they are from the 1980s; that one pair is emerald and one is glass; that one is synthetic emerald and one is glass; that both sets of stones are glass; that one is oil-treated emerald and one is synthetic sapphire; that the metal might be copper; that the earrings were probably made in America; and that they are “not very important.”

Back in Santa Fe, I take the earrings to Stephen’s, a consignment shop, where a young man named Nicholas, who professes that jewelry is “not really” his “forte,” immediately guesses that they are gold-plated silver, Etruscan-revival style, probably made in South Asia between the 1970s and 1990s. He offers to quickly test the stones. The green stones he deems most likely chrysoprase—a budget alternative to jade. The blue ones surprise him. His electric probe indicates that they are a stone called spinel, which he hadn’t realized could be blue; he wants to look that up. I ask how he learned all of this.

“I don’t even know where to begin,” Nicholas says. “Probably trying to impress girls”—which makes me laugh.

“Does it work?” I ask.

He looks up from the earrings to make eye contact for the length of a lightning flash. “A little bit,” he says.

Blue spinel, he reads off his phone, is the rarest spinel, primarily found in Asia. But, he warns, this is an AI summary, which tends to exaggerate worth. Specialist reference books, which he doesn’t just walk around with, are more reliable. “People say, ‘Oh, everything’s getting put on the internet now, so there’s no need for books,’” Nicholas tells me. But “some of these books are never going to be reprinted or digitized.” Reputable books about Chinese porcelain, he says, “can cost thousands and thousands of dollars.” Despite their hugely discrepant individual assessments, Nicholas and the various Diamond District dealers all provide the same ballpark estimate for the earrings’ worth: somewhere in the vicinity of \$100 to \$140 for the pairs. But, says Nicholas, the reward of thrifting isn’t found in raw resources; it’s about interpreting the item as a whole. “As far as a made product goes,” he says, “I think you did good.”

What else is there at Savers? A framed photo of a chandelier, and one of a Dairy Queen in Staten Island, its sidewalk overflowing with kids bundled in winter coats (and one reindeer sweater). An ivory-satin beaded clutch with a tag inside reading MADE IN W. GERMANY BY HAND, hanging, like a pork shoulder off a miniature meat hook, next to a wallet designed to look like a Krabby Patty from *SpongeBob SquarePants*. Shein garments, fine as paper napkins. A demure floor-length dress with a tag that reads MS. CONDUCT CALIFORNIA MATERNITY. A *CSI: Crime Scene Investigation* DNA laboratory for kids. A big bag of someone's old nail polish.

I walk around the store for several minutes carrying a straw bucket bag, in an effort to discover if I wish to purchase it. I feel drawn to all woven-straw items because of my surname, which is Weaver. Anytime I see one, I picture myself thousands(?) of years ago (however many would make sense is the amount I picture), on an amber afternoon, sitting placidly while expertly weaving the very object I am looking at in 2026. The other people in my village/town/field—coming and going from their own peaceful tasks that are also their last names (baking, milling, cart ... ing? Carting around this and that, I suppose, and God loved them for doing it)—pause for a moment and admire the intrinsic utility and inspiring artistry of my emerging creation, which to me is nothing, because I am a *weaver*; this is simply what I do. In real life, of course, I would not have the faintest notion of how to begin to create a functioning shoulder bag out of straw, could not do it if you gave me 500 hours, would not even know where to procure the different colors of straw (is it straw?). How much does Savers want for this bag? \$7.99. They are dreaming.

In any event, the best thrift stores in town are two shops a five-minute drive apart, both called the Cat. They are the best because their proceeds are donated to the local humane society, and, in every American city, people reserve their very best castoffs for charities that benefit animals. (Or else animal lovers part with their best things more quickly, in order to benefit animals.) After scrounging around in a jumble of bifocals at one of these locations, I come up with a pair of Gucci eyeglasses, which I buy for \$1.

PURCHASES:

- Big bag of someone's old nail polish: \$1.99
- Woven-straw purse shaped like a pig: \$5.99
- Golden egg-shaped purse embossed with stylized bird with graceful swooping neck: \$14.99
- Earrings with chrysoprase stones: \$2.99
- Earrings with possibly rare blue-spinel stones: \$2.99
- Gucci glasses: \$1
- Ted Baker glasses: \$1
- Pink carrying case for glasses: \$1

TOTAL: \$26.16*

*Reflects discounts from a coupon a stranger placed in my hand



3. Estate Sales

FOR THE TRUE secondhand connoisseur, nothing surpasses an estate sale. These affairs offer up, for fondling, the entirety of a home's viscera upon the death of its caretaker. Members of the public are invited in as dermestid beetles are invited into the carcass of an American woodcock, to leave only the perfect, picked-clean bones behind. Art, furniture, personal papers, open cleaning supplies, expired spices, the paraphernalia of half-started hobbies, washcloths, underwear, used lipsticks—these and much, much, much more are available for buying.

The modern American estate sale is a hybrid of a garage sale and a thrift store, with items priced individually, and shoppers left free to browse without close supervision. Although estate



sales are occasionally overseen by a decedent's friends or family, the task of administration is most often left to a professional company, whose employees can traffic huge quantities of loved ones' belongings unsentimentally.

The arrangements of personal effects at estate sales are memento mori more sobering than any skeleton ever carved into marble. A ziplock baggie of sunblock, bought with the expectation of future hours outdoors; a partially eviscerated Lamb Chop (America's most popular plush dog toy), priced—ambitiously, considering the extruding fluffy white brain matter—at \$2 (and what will happen to the dog?); plastic bins of manila folders with tidy cursive labels like DIRECT TV 10-22 2019; 2025 FORD ESCAPE; NUTRITION *[sic]*; and, I realize only when I look, later, at a photo I snapped on my phone, POLICE REPORT.

I love to meander through a stranger's home and discover who had a secret indoor swimming pool (more common than you'd think), what sorts of tchotchkes they kept around (a crocheted tissue box designed to look like a red-and-white teapot; you pull

the tissues out through the spout, like steam), and whether they used nicer conditioner than I do (a dead woman's nearly full bottle of Kérastase is currently perched on the edge of my bathtub).

Nearly always, a home will have, laid out in the kitchen, a (give or take) 39-piece set of Lenox dishware in the (give or take) "Maywood" pattern, priced at (get a load of this) \$245. This is almost certainly one of the few times this millennium that the light of day has bathed these pieces. Formal dining rooms began disappearing from American homes in the last century, replaced by open kitchens, through which all members of the family can cavort freely, like a splash pad; contemporary Americans apparently have little use for the plate. What we want now are "pasta bowls": wide, shallow craters we can fill with food in any state of wetness, a single mass or particulate items, perhaps requiring mild agitation before consumption (tossed salad; ★★★★★ weeknight sheet-pan bibimbap). The bowls are great because we can hold them in one hand or cradle them on our laps while eating, thus minimizing the mess incurred upon the dining table's elimination. In 2016, an executive from the company that manufactures Fiesta tableware told *The Wall Street Journal* that bowls accounted for roughly one-third of the brand's sales and showed the largest sales growth of any dish type; there is, a marketing director for Waterford, the crystal company, confirmed, "far more demand now for bowls."

I tend to start in the master-bedroom closet—virtually every piece of clothing I own is something another woman no longer wanted, or perhaps did still want but then she died—and afterward skulk to the garage, to peruse holiday decor. Inevitably, as I nose my way through dead strangers' belongings, my mind slips to my own estate sale, the one that will spring from my death. These thoughts follow a pattern: First, I am exhilarated by the thought of what a fantastic sale that will be, and long to attend it myself. Next, I resent

the scavengers who will descend on my home, attempting to wheedle their way to even better deals on my already reasonably priced possessions. I want my widowed husband to be there, to make sure that all sticker prices are honored. But I also want everyone to leave my grieving husband alone. And, now that I think about it, my husband definitely wouldn't care about enforcing my pricing system. He yearns for the break-resistant, low-stimulation furnishings of a private suite in a psych ward; the minimalist modernism of an uninhabited cave by the Black Sea; a many-drawered palace in hell where items are "put away" when not in use. He would just want the chore of ridding himself of my 10 trillion fabulous possessions to be finished as quickly as possible. Also: When I was married to him, this man didn't know the value of a dollar. To him, a dollar was worth a penny; to me, every dollar was worth \$9.80. I grow irritated at my husband for letting things go too cheaply (though I do want them to be priced cheaply!). I wonder if I can convince my favorite cousin to take charge of this.



Inside a house in Bernalillo, I find just the kinds of things that make me preemptively sad for my sale: a lanyard from a Carnival cruise; a VHS tape labeled X'MAS IN N.C.; an inexpertly (not that I could do better) hand-painted commemorative plate, depicting a blue-eyed couple above the words GRACE AND VERNON | MARRIED DECEMBER 14, 1928. I wish I knew these people enough to want to purchase their memories. I think of the framed invitation to my beloved grandparents' wedding, hanging on my living-room wall. To me, a priceless item. To the shoppers at my estate sale, a random piece of strangers' ephemera not worth a dollar. In a bedroom closet in Bernalillo, on a shelf bearing a gray-haired wig and wig shampoo, I find a government card dated five months before the attack on Pearl Harbor, stating that the cardholder, a resident of Kansas, is eligible to defer his draft by reason of hardship to his dependents. The woman ringing up my Christmas decorations lets me have it for free.

Weeks later, I go to the kind of estate sale you dream about: a wealthy woman's ranch with a county-road address. Old wagon wheels, almost as tall as I am, are strewn throughout the grounds. Her closet contains a lace wedding dress from the 1920s. A skylight makes her toilet glow. In one(!) of her barns sits an *equipal*, a leather seat descended from Aztec thrones, the color of burnt sugar; also a great big straw carrot that I swiftly place on the "hold" table. (My editor has asked me to explain "why" I go on to purchase this carrot for \$2. To never stare down another sunrise without being the legal owner of a great big straw carrot—is this not obvious?)

Since moving to New Mexico, I have learned to cock my ears for the whistling-firework-tail call of the lesser goldfinch. Inside the ranch house, my ears prick up at an even more striking sound: An elderly shopper is murmuring a joke to his friend in New Mexican Spanish, a vanishing dialect dwindling even in the few towns in which it is spoken. In an interview with *The New York Times* in 2023,

one linguist compared the isolated conditions in which it evolved to a colony of astronauts who landed on Mars and then lost contact with Earth for a dozen or so generations. To overhear it is a rare treat.

This is a radiant Saturday morning—the perfect conditions for yard and estate sales, which usually give the proceedings a frantic air. But in the jewel-colored rooms of this home in the wilderness, people are idling: delighting in the little white Christmas lights strung across the exposed wooden vigas in the kitchen; reading the tiles in the woman's colorful shower that spell out the names of her favorite horses; lingering in the art studio and on the sweeping back balcony to listen to wind hiss through the trees. I have never been in a home where it was more obvious that the owner lived there exactly as she wanted to. Then, singly and in pairs, we gather up our chosen fragments of this stranger's life (marked down to half price), and load them into our cars.

PURCHASES:

- Large animal hip bone: \$10
- Cowskin rug: \$30
- Photo print of cattle in snow: \$5
- Huge carrot made of straw: \$2
- Beaded Easter eggs and more Christmas ornaments: \$7
- Horseshoe jewelry rack: \$10
- Pre-Pearl Harbor draft card: \$0

TOTAL: \$64

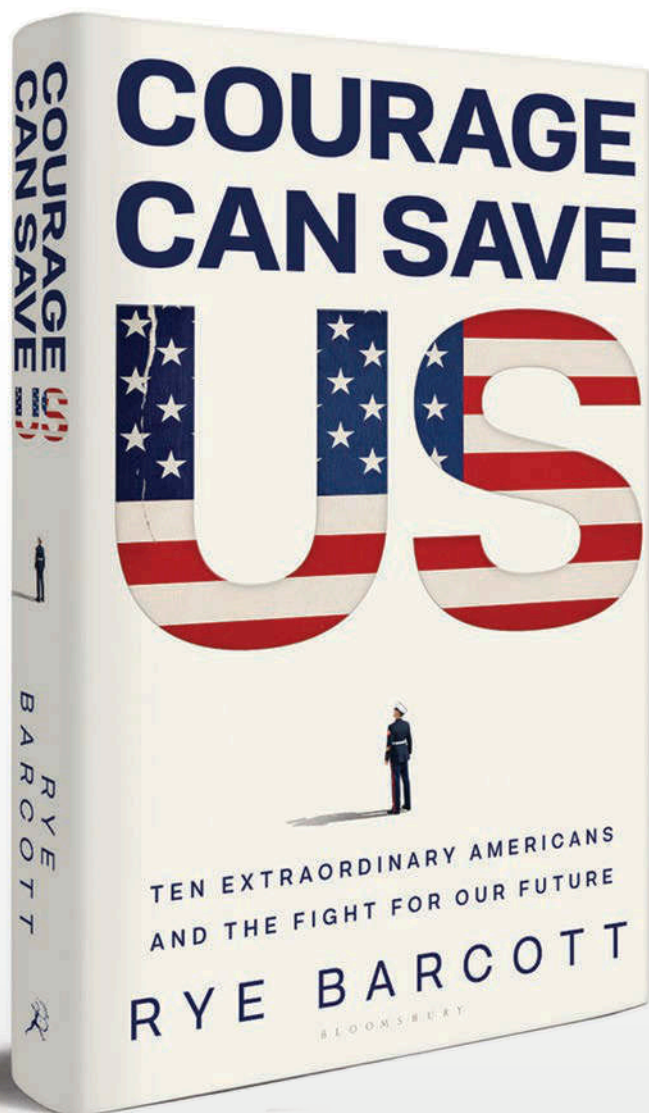
GRAND TOTAL: \$99.66

LEFT OVER: \$0.34 *A*

Caity Weaver is a staff writer at The Atlantic.

**“These are the times that buy men’s souls.
Thank God, some souls are not for sale.”**

—KARL MARLANTES,
author of *Matterhorn* and *What It Is Like to Go to War*



“[These] inspiring stories reveal how courage, character, and common purpose can still renew our democracy and restore hope for its future.”

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Culture & Critics

OMNIVORE

Boy George

Finally, an action movie about Washington's French and Indian War years

By James Parker

"Where shall we look for Washington, the greatest among men," asked Parson Weems in 1800, "but in America—that greatest Continent, which, rising from beneath the frozen pole, stretches far and wide to the south?" Weems, Washington's first biographer, was a propagandist of genius—but even he might not have known quite how American he was being when he wrote that line. A smaller country, it is implied—geographically smaller, and smaller in soul—simply could not have handled the monster-truck greatness of



ANGEL STUDIOS

this man. It would have ruptured or burst. For greatness like this, only America would have been big enough.

Weems's Washington is famously great all the way through, great from the get-go: an angelic child, fanned by the warm wings of "ministering spirits," who matures irreversibly into a mighty warrior and then a world-shaking leader. But what if greatness is something you grow into, patchily and vexedly, under pressure? *Young Washington*, a new biopic, gives us pre-Revolutionary George, early-20s George, pale, petulant, virginal, ramrod-straight, and bristling with awkwardness and ambition. He is callow, unformed. Imperfect, in a word. And when he starts soldiering, he makes some rather large mistakes.

As played by the very beautiful (and curiously English) William Franklyn-Miller, this Washington is an underdog. He's an interloper, an uppity tenant farmer seeking to make a name for himself in service of the Crown. He goes on surveying missions and nearly freezes to death. Unembraced by Virginian high society, he crashes a party at the mansion of Lord Fairfax, entering via the basement. (It's here that he meets Sally Cary, soon to marry into the Fairfax family, and begins a stilted flirtation with her.) Across the Appalachians, in the murk of the Ohio wilderness, is the developing fault line between two contending empires: the British and the French. Who will claim this endless, uncertain landscape? Having trekked the territory with his trusty surveyor's compass, and in the absence of anyone else rash enough to do it, Washington volunteers to deliver an ultimatum to the encroaching French forces. At the head of a rabble of Virginian militiamen, in the name of the King of England, he'll tell those Frenchmen to clear off.

The Ohio Valley, the "immeasurable forest, from time immemorial the gloomy haunt of ravening beasts" (Weems again), becomes the young man's proving ground. And his flaws—pride, inexperience—are consequential. Does newly promoted Major Washington, by blundering with his men into a party of breakfasting French soldiers, whom they sort of massacre in uncontrolled volleys of buckshot, accidentally start the French and Indian War, which becomes the Seven Years' War, called by some historians "the first world war"? It certainly seems like he does. And does he then build a fort—Fort Necessity—in the wrong place, exposing it to floods and ambushes, and eventually getting some of his men killed in its unsuccessful defense? Again, it would appear so. Returning home, hot with shame, Washington attempts to resign his commission: The lieutenant governor of Virginia, Robert Dinwiddie, played with birdlike severity by Ben Kingsley, will not hear of it. Months later he presents himself to General Edward Braddock, humbly but determinedly

*When the
showdown
comes—
against the
Brits, against
power, against
the chaos of
an emergent
nation—like
Eminem in
8 Mile, he
is ready.*

offering his experience in this new style of warfare. "You lost!" the general (Andy Serkis) reminds him. "Failure is a great teacher," Washington says. (If I tell you that this is one of those movies where everybody speaks in slightly leaden proverbs—"Obedience can be commanded. Respect must be earned," "Even a pawn can take a king," and so on—you'll immediately apprehend the ambience of *Young Washington*.)

And this, of course, is the lesson of the movie: These poor decisions, these disasters, are a necessary prelude to greatness. Without flawed and gangling young George blowing it in the Ohio woods, there's no full-grown George, the emphatic figure who shows up in Philadelphia at the Second Continental Congress and is speedily and unanimously proclaimed chief commander of the Revolutionary forces. Everyone and everything—society, reality, good stuff and bad stuff—is fiercely tutoring our hero, fiercely engaged in his development.

Peter Stark, in his (excellent) 2018 biography, also called *Young Washington*, highlights the archetypal elements in this story, the screenplay-friendly substructure of this "transition from adolescence to adulthood." "Washington's passage," he writes, "parallels what in mythology Joseph Campbell calls the 'hero's journey.'" We might even call it a shamanic voyage. Young George goes out into the badlands: His weakness is exposed; he is torn at by the demons of fear, failure, and defeat; his body is tested and his ego picked apart. He returns loaded with strange knowledge and as-if-magical attainments. Into the direst of circumstances men will now follow him. In battle he is inviolate: Musket balls and flying death-shards seem to swerve around him. And when the showdown comes—against the Brits, against power, against the chaos of an emergent nation—like Eminem in *8 Mile*, he is ready.

So there's a wild and potentially somewhat Jungian movie to be made here. I can imagine a version of *Young Washington* directed by one of the Safdie brothers, with a score by Hildur Guðnadóttir. It's a great movie, this one I'm imagining: It has an entirely made-up scene where Washington, mid-parley with the Iroquois, hallucinates that he is being attacked by ravens—great, big, jabbering, inky ravens with wallop wings and talons that draw blood. The dark cellos of Guðnadóttir chop and grind, and Washington—shrieking, swiping, maddened at the air—flees into the forest, a disappearing uniform. Observes an Iroquois matriarch: "That one has far to go."

But *Young Washington* comes to us by way of Angel Studios, "a home," as CEO Neal Harmon puts it in the studio's mission statement, or north-star letter, "for stories that amplify light." So far these stories have included the life-of-Christ TV drama *The Chosen* and—more controversially—*Sound of Freedom*,

inspired by the activities of the anti-sex-trafficking activist Tim Ballard and celebrated by Trump backers, religious conservatives, and QAnon believers. *Young Washington* is not crude and ghastly like *Sound of Freedom*. It has some decent big-name actors—Kingsley, Serkis, Mary-Louise Parker—some stirring battles, some history lessons, and the most ideological thing about it is its soundtrack, which is a kind of string-based moralistic soup. But the process of light-amplification has straitened the storytelling. Clichés and hoary tropes abound. “Most shows offered these days,” Angel Studios’ north-star letter continues, “add to the cynicism, division, and darkness so pervasive in society. Fortunately, darkness and light, hope and despair, cannot exist in the same place at the same time.” I disagree. And so does William Blake: “Joy & Woe are woven fine / A Clothing for the soul divine.” Hope and despair are twins, inextricable. And a darker, weirder Washington would have made for a better movie.

In one respect, though, *Young Washington* nails it. As he makes his error-strewn progress through early manhood, Washington is variously fobbed off by supercilious Brits, sneered at by drippingly Gallic Frenchmen, and insulted by the Virginian elite. Class-wise, money-wise, the system is rigged against him. Can he not break through on his own merits? “That is not the way the world works!” his exasperated half brother Lawrence tells him. “Then someone should remake it!” storms young George, cosmically mutinous.

America, America, I can see you being born right here, as this strain of noble insurgency mingles with the beginnings of your biggest personality defect: the Great American Inferiority Complex. *You think you’re better than me?!* Nearly everyone in *Young Washington* thinks they’re better than George Washington. And he’ll show them all, the bastards. Planted alongside the seed of liberty, in other words, is the seed of grievance—of the political resentment from which we are still suffering. Now that’s an origin story. *A*

James Parker is a staff writer at The Atlantic.

The Road Wound Upward

By Karl Kirchwey

I dreamed of the mountains again
and felt the rising joy
as the road wound upward

through the dark woods
then villages rank with silage
and spattered with cow manure

all the needs of the body
I didn’t know any better
geraniums a vibration

against the ancient chalets
no one else around
the clattering of water

in log troughs unheard
at that hour of afternoon
and I felt the names on my tongue

Huémox Chésières Barboleusaz
as the view opened out
with the high snowfields beyond

almost too bright to bear
It was my life you see
and everything still to do

It was spring there was a path
the meadow full of wildflowers
leading to a little cemetery

I passed a man and a boy
sitting beside the road
they raised their hands to me

Karl Kirchwey’s eighth book of poems, Good Apothecary, is forthcoming. He directs the creative-writing program at Boston University.



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is to know me.**

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BOOKS

The Surprising, Liberating History of Marriage

To find a future for the institution, Stephanie Coontz turns to its wildly varying past.

By Honor Jones

A few months ago, one of my best friends told me that she and her boyfriend had gotten engaged. *Engaged?* I thought. *What for?* She has two young kids and has never been married; he's older; they each have their own apartment; she seemed happy with the way things were. "Congratulations!" I said, because he's a good person, and I love my friend. Then I asked where they were going to live, and she laughed in my face.

"Oh, we're not moving in together," she said. She'd assumed I would have known that. They might do it someday, sure. But for now they can afford to keep paying for two homes, and she's prioritizing the children's stability, and everyone's space and sanity.

In a way, I was as surprised by my surprise as my friend was. It's not as if my life is normal. Recently I picked my kids up at their father's place and one of them ran over and hit me in the face with a big white pillow. When I turned the pillow over, I saw it was printed with a cute photograph of my ex-husband's girlfriend; someone must have given it to him as a joke—and it was funny. My friends are divorced, separated, married, single mothers by accident, single mothers by choice. And yet the only radical thing I had assumed you could do to a marriage was to open it up and start taking dating-app pics for your spouse. It had honestly never occurred to me that my friend could get married and not cohabit with her husband.

I think Stephanie Coontz would like my friend's story. For more than 30 years, Coontz has been trying to convince Americans of three things: Our ideas about traditional marriage are holding many people back from getting and staying married; also, our ideas about traditional marriage are incorrect; also, "there is no such thing as the traditional marriage." What would happen, she asks in her latest book, *For Better and Worse: The Complicated Past and Challenging Future of Marriage*, if we could get it through our skulls that the male-breadwinner model of a marriage was the norm for only a short period in the 20th century, and that history is full of an "astonishing variety" of partnerships and forms of desire? Coontz's hope is that learning how much marriage has changed over the centuries can liberate more people to imagine different kinds of

For more than 30 years, Coontz has been trying to convince Americans that "there is no such thing as the traditional marriage."

marriages that might suit them better. Depending on the reader, her argument will scan as either modest or profound: "We have more latitude in how to organize healthy intimate relationships than most people realize."

That is not to say she thinks anyone *has* to marry. The first sentence of *For Better and Worse* is: "This isn't a book about why you ought to marry." Nor does she think that marriage is necessarily doomed; it's simply no longer required when there are plenty of other ways "to achieve economic security, political advancement, social respect, legal protections, and a loving partnership." This has contributed to a deep pessimism around marriage. But Coontz points out that it is not altogether a bad thing for people to have higher standards for entering a marriage, and for them to know that if they want that marriage to last, they have to keep their partner happy.

Coontz is concerned, though, that many people who might benefit from marriage can't see themselves making a go of it. More than a quarter of American 40-year-olds have never been married; that's a record, and it's rising. Researchers at the University of Michigan have been asking high-school seniors about marriage since the 1970s. In 1976, 84 percent of girls and 73 percent of boys said they expected to marry, according to one analysis of the data. By 2023, only 64 percent of girls said that, whereas about three-quarters of boys still expected to get married. Have so many young women turned against marriage itself, or only against a persistent 1950s vision of it, one that is no longer viable or desirable?

AT 81, Coontz is now mostly retired from teaching American history, but she remains on the faculty of Evergreen State College and is the director of research and public education for the Council on Contemporary Families, a nonpartisan think tank that dove into the "family values" debates of the 1990s. Coontz started going on television to deflate panic about high rates of divorce and single motherhood, and she has been a public figure ever since, promoting her view of marriage as protean rather than brittle. *For Better and Worse* continues that argument, with a swift, myth-dispelling survey of family arrangements down the centuries that focuses on periods when ideas about pair-bonding and marriage shifted in significant ways.

The Stone Age (not her specialty) goes by fast. We learn that women sometimes hunted big game, and that child-rearing was a collective enterprise. Coontz debunks pop evolutionary-psych factoids, such as that many women like stronger, older men because our Paleolithic ancestors needed mates who could support their offspring. In fact, food was hunted and served communally, meaning that a brawny man's children got the same helpings as the kids of weaklings and dead men. Not so the filii nullius of premodern England and America; the illegitimate "children of no one" were brutally neglected,

L. WILLINGER / FPG / GETTY; SFL / GETTY; Sjöberg Bildbyrå / GETTY; DEBROCKE / CLASSICSTOCK / GETTY; KEYSTONE-FRANCE / GETTY; JENA ARDELL / GETTY; WILLIAM B. FLOWMAN / GETTY; BOYER / ROGER VIOLETT / GETTY; JOE HADDIE / GETTY; MICHAEL SPRINGER / GETTY; METROPOLITAN MUSEUM OF ART, NEW YORK; AFRICAN NEWSPAPERS / GADO / GETTY; KIRN VINTAGE STOCK / CORBIS / GETTY; SAMANTHA VUIGNIER / CORBIS / GETTY; KRYSIA CAMPOS / GETTY; JHAMORINO / GETTY; UNIVERSAL HISTORY / GETTY; GEORGE MARKS / RETROVILLE / GETTY; ART MEDIA / PRINT COLLECTOR / GETTY; THE PRINT COLLECTOR / PRINT COLLECTOR / GETTY



she writes, which helped ensure that young people complied with marriages arranged to maximize their family's power and property. At one point in between, Jesus entered briefly, preaching that strangers were just as deserving of charity as nuclear-family members—a view that might have made more sense to the early hunter-gatherers than to many of his future followers.

Men obviously dominated in public life for centuries, and in private life too; the history of repressive marital laws is long. And yet, Coontz recounts, the necessities of survival led husbands and wives to share many of their cares and responsibilities. In 17th-century England and colonial America, farmwives and fishwives contributed to the household budget. One account describes women hitting the alehouse on their way back from the market, ending the day with “their heads full of wine, and their purses full of coin.” Both husbands and wives supplemented the family's income through the “putting-out system” (not what you think—at home, they stitched parts for leather shoes, twisted cotton into lace).

But the rise of wage labor in the industrializing 18th century began to drive men and women apart: Husbands were out circulating in the marketplace, and wives were more confined to the home. (Middle-class wives, at any rate; many single and poorer women had to keep showing up for their shifts at the factory spinning machine.) Enter romance. Soon businessmen were swooning for love matches and stroking the silken hair of Victorian ladies too good for this mercenary world. At last, Coontz arrives at the 1950s, with the “much-mythologized” male-breadwinner family that, thanks to decades of sitcom reruns and Boomer nostalgia for half-remembered childhoods, has deformed our understanding of the institution ever since.

This speed date with history is Coontz's seventh book. The book that earned her a wide audience, *The Way We Never Were: American Families and the Nostalgia Trap* (1992), was more narrowly focused on the white, suburban, one-income families that became the archetype not just of the '50s but of marriage itself. The single-earner nuclear families of that time weren't simply carried along on the broad backs of hardworking fathers, she argued. They were made possible by postwar government policies such as education benefits, job training, and cheap housing loans, and an economy that supported an unprecedented rise in wages. Many Americans benefited—which is one reason the upsides are better remembered than the downsides. More than half of two-parent Black families lived in poverty in the '50s, and white resistance to integration sabotaged Black people's efforts “to participate in the American family dream.” Even those who lived the dream didn't always enjoy it; as feminists soon made clear, much suffering was caused by stripping women of their wartime jobs and expecting them to be perfect wives and mothers.

FOR BETTER
AND WORSE: THE
COMPLICATED
PAST AND
CHALLENGING
FUTURE OF
MARRIAGE

Stephanie Coontz

VIKING

In 2015, Coontz's *Marriage, a History: How Love Conquered Marriage*, was cited in the Supreme Court decision legalizing same-sex marriage. The book, published a decade earlier, traced the shift away from a vision of marriage as “far too vital an economic and political institution to be left entirely to the free choice of the two individuals involved” and toward the idea of a love match, with the high hopes for lifelong fulfillment that such a love promises; Justice Anthony Kennedy drew on it in his opinion endorsing the right of all to marry for love.

But Coontz didn't just take the win. She fact-checked the justice. Marriage, Kennedy wrote, had always “promised nobility and dignity to all persons.” Not so, Coontz said: “For thousands of years, marriage conferred nobility and dignity almost exclusively on the husband, who had a legal right to appropriate the property and earnings of his wife and children and forcibly impose his will upon them.” Her belief that the decision was right didn't stop her from noting that both Kennedy's opinion and John Roberts's dissent—which argued that marriage had always referred to “the union of a man and a woman” whose primary purpose was the stable upbringing of children—were “at odds with historical reality.”

FOR BETTER AND WORSE arrives at a moment when the sexes are more polarized—at least politically—than ever. Coontz is trying to address two extremes: those who reject egalitarianism in favor of a romanticized past, and those who reject heterosexual marriage as inherently exploitative. She avoids culture-war zeal, aiming to approach everyone with sympathy. In her earlier work, she went after “unhealthy nostalgia.” Here she acknowledges having been “too dismissive” of how fears of losing money and status can encourage fantasies of an idealized past. Psyches are a “jumble of internalized messages and habits” that defy reason. Talk to any couple made up of two good people. Even those who want to change often struggle to do it.

Coontz, incidentally, is married, though she doesn't talk much about it in her books. Early in her career, she got engaged, but “the wedding fell through,” she once told *The New York Times*. It then turned out she was pregnant. She was a single parent for a dozen years until she reconnected with, and married, the man who'd been her college sweetheart. The writing of *For Better and Worse* was delayed by the birth of her first grandchild. The book is dedicated to him.

For Better and Worse struck me as particularly generous toward young men. When Coontz started studying the history of the family, she was focused on “what women lost when they were denied access to the expanding economic and political rights that White men gained in the late eighteenth and early nineteenth

centuries.” Now she is “more aware of what *men* lost” when work pulled them away from the intimacies of family and community life.

In the Victorian era, men wrote love letters expressing their longing and devotion: “I cannot have a separate existence from you, I breathe by you; I live by you.” Before his wedding to Alice Lee in 1880, the 21-year-old future Rough Rider and then-virgin Teddy Roosevelt boasted in his diary: “Thank heaven I am absolutely pure. I can tell Alice everything I have ever done.” But this more sensitive masculinity didn’t much help men in a commercial world that rewarded strength and assertiveness, even ruthlessness. Women who depended on men for their livelihood began to prize those traits as well. The idea of the attraction of opposites took hold, and Coontz quotes women worrying in their diaries and letters that potential suitors were “too soulful”—not “masterful” enough. For many, Coontz writes, the ideal man was “powerful, stoical, and forceful.”

Coontz has sometimes asked students to read those Victorian men’s letters aloud. Most boys can’t handle it: They get sarcastic, “distancing themselves from the emotion.” Some even blush. What’s wrong with these supposedly enlightened modern guys? One explanation is that we’ve come to think of being a man as the opposite of being a woman. This might seem natural, but Coontz observes that manhood was once counterposed more against childhood than womanhood. Maturity was what turned a boy into a man—the development of self-control and judgment, not aggressiveness. Understanding the tangle of valued traits, she confesses, has made her “a bit more forgiving of ‘mansplaining’ than some of my friends”—and more optimistic that partnerships between men and women can evolve.

Yet the old idea that men and women should inhabit separate spheres still distorts relationships today, Coontz writes. Couples are especially plagued by the expectation that women be responsible for the “invisible labor” of managing people’s needs and emotions. And many women are really sick of doing most of the dishes. It’s notable that the major decline in marriage expectations in the survey of high-school seniors occurred only among the girls. It’s also notable that most divorces are initiated by women.

Coontz’s obvious advice—always worth repeating—is that men and women share their burdens. (Plenty of same-sex couples squabble over chores too, of course, but they’re less trapped by gender roles.) “Couples with egalitarian arrangements of household labor and child-care report increases in their levels of love over time,” she says; couples with more traditional divisions of labor report the reverse. Well into the 2010s, magazines were arguing that women were actually turned off when their husbands did more “feminine” chores, but that was based on a study of people who were interviewed

in the early ’90s. Recent research finds that egalitarian couples report good sex, and more of it. At times, the book gave me the feeling that marriage could be saved in two ways: by women freeing themselves of outdated assumptions, imagining radical new forms of marriage, and having the resources to enact them—or by more men rinsing out their cups more often.

But I did find it helpful to encounter familiar compulsions in their historical context. For instance, do so many women feel pressure to keep a clean house because they’re innately neat? Perhaps, Coontz writes, their need to tidy is “a holdover from the new class aspirations that turned female domesticity into a status symbol during the late eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries.” And I was comforted to be reminded that, instead of blaming one another so much—for never marrying, or for marrying the wrong person—we could acknowledge how much we are responding to circumstances beyond our control: financial stresses, a lack of social supports, habits inherited from centuries past. In that sense, history can cut us some slack.

Still, every marriage, however it’s shaped by the marriages before it, is its own mystery, or rather dense with many mysteries: the gestures made and missed, the sink and the compost, the closeness, the glances, the jokes, the bodies, the in-laws, the children, the mornings, the years. At one point in Don DeLillo’s *The Names*, a character who is trying to win back his wife thinks that “marriage is something we make from available materials. In this sense it’s improvised, it’s almost offhand. Maybe this is why we know so little about it. It’s too inspired and quicksilver a thing to be clearly understood. Two people make a blur.”

After going through a divorce, I can’t imagine getting married a second time. If marriage once offered stability, it now seems an extraordinary risk. Coontz compares it (both accurately and unappealingly) to a “high-stakes real estate deal, with feelings as well as finances” on the line. Also, no one has asked me lately. But according to Coontz, I’m in the minority; two-thirds of people who divorce go on to remarry.

Maybe, for some, the risk is part of the appeal. After my friend came back from the courthouse, I asked her why she did it. “Romance,” she told me, and “fun.” And then she used the word *propriety*, but she made it sound almost dirty—as if monogamous marriage were a hot new kink they’d discovered.

In the end, she said she couldn’t quite explain it. There was just something special “about merging into someone else.”

A blur. *A*

Honor Jones is a senior editor at The Atlantic and the author of the novel Sleep.

Every marriage, however it’s shaped by the marriages before it, is its own mystery, or rather dense with many mysteries.

BOOKS

Nathaniel Hawthorne's American Horror Story

The author wrote a tale that challenged the nation's founding myths. Then it disappeared.

By John Swansburg



In January 1836, Nathaniel Hawthorne moved from Salem to Boston to assume the editorship of *The American Magazine of Useful and Entertaining Knowledge*. It wasn't a typical editorial arrangement. Hawthorne would not manage a staff of writers, or make assignments to a network of correspondents. The lean budget required him to rely entirely on a single contributor: himself.

The issues that Hawthorne produced are, in fact, full of useful and entertaining knowledge. He published essays on John C. Calhoun, "Modern Jewish Passover," and the history of hats. Some of these he composed; others he digested or simply aggregated from books or other magazines. Longer articles were punctuated with shorter curiosities: a new medical explanation for snoring; how to ascertain the height of a mountain using only a thermometer; the spontaneous combustion of a math professor; what the plague smelled like ("mellow apples," some said; mayflowers, said others).

To read these issues today is to marvel at Hawthorne's ability to fill so many pages, even if some articles have aged better than others. (Snoring, it turns out, is not caused by poor circulation.) But the work was running him ragged. Desperate for help, Hawthorne pressed his sister Elizabeth into service. "Concoct, concoct, concoct," he implored her in a letter. "I make nothing of writing a history or biography before dinner. Do you the same." Elizabeth submitted a profile of Alexander Hamilton and sundry other items. But the job still proved too demanding. In late summer, an exhausted Hawthorne resigned his post and retreated to Salem.

Hawthorne was 32 and beginning to lose hope that he could make a living as a writer. (In a letter to his other sister, he pegged his net worth at "precisely 34 cents.") The problem was the wages, not the work. In an astonishing burst of creativity, he had already written and published the short fiction that, together with *The Scarlet Letter* (1850), would eventually establish him as the preeminent writer of the American Renaissance: dark parables such as "Young Goodman Brown," "The Minister's Black Veil," and "Roger Malvin's Burial."

He had also published, anonymously, a story called “My Kinsman, Major Molineux.” Even by Hawthorne’s standards, it is an ominous, ambiguous tale. A young man named Robin leaves the countryside to seek his fortune in the city, hoping that a well-connected relative will set him up in business. It is also an allegory of the American founding. Over the course of one phantasmagoric evening, Robin witnesses events that prefigure the Revolutionary War. But far from celebrating or sanctifying the throwing off of English rule, the story’s shocking ending portrays the patriots as a fiendish mob, and casts doubt on the bedrock American faith in prosperity.

Throughout his career, Hawthorne packaged and repackaged his short stories and sketches, hoping to earn some much-needed income. In 1837, he published *Twice-Told Tales*. In 1846, he published *Mosses From an Old Manse*, the collection that left Herman Melville in awe of his friend’s “great power of blackness.” For reasons we can only guess at, Hawthorne declined to include “My Kinsman, Major Molineux” in either volume. Perhaps he worried that its portrait of American history was simply *too* black to have anything like mass-market appeal. Only after the success of *The Scarlet Letter* did he finally put his name to it, selecting it as the final story in his final collection, 1851’s *The Snow-Image*.

Unlike Melville’s, Hawthorne’s genius was appreciated in his lifetime. Yet “My Kinsman, Major Molineux” languished for a century before being discovered by scholars. Its great early champion was the British critic Q. D. Leavis. In an influential 1951 essay, she wrote that Hawthorne had never surpassed the story “in dramatic power, in control of tone, pace, and tension, and in something more wonderful, the creation of a suspension between the fullest consciousness of meaning and the emotional incoherence of dreaming.” Another critic, remarking on the tale’s long road to recognition, wrote, “For one hundred years the story lay dormant, the sleeping beauty of the American canon, until kissed by an English queen.”

Literary scholars have been working overtime to interpret the story ever since, yet outside the academy, it remains undeservedly obscure. This semiquincentennial summer is a good time to get to know it. Hawthorne may have been inspired to write it by the 1826 celebration of the American jubilee, which was marked by veneration of the Founding Fathers and rosy mythmaking about the Revolution. Hawthorne was more inclined to be haunted by history. The descendant of a hanging judge in the Salem witch trials, he was suspicious of certitude and wary of hysteria. His allegory of the conflict does not turn away from its violence or its darker implications; it offers no certainties.

“For one hundred years the story lay dormant, the sleeping beauty of the American canon.”

THE STORY is set on a midsummer night sometime around 1730. Robin, our hero, is the son of a country clergyman. He has come to the city—though never named, it’s clearly Boston—to find Major Molineux, his father’s cousin. Molineux, a man of wealth and status in the colonial government and without a son of his own, has hinted that he is willing to set Robin up in business.

First, though, this aspiring nepo baby needs to find him: Robin doesn’t have his kinsman’s address. Each denizen Robin stops to ask for help claims no knowledge of the major—and responds with disdain or worse. An old man nursing a “sepulchral” cough threatens to put Robin in the stocks for having accosted him on the street. An obsequious innkeeper, upon hearing the Molineux name, turns inhospitable, darkly noting Robin’s resemblance to a runaway indentured servant. Only a young woman in a scarlet petticoat proves more obliging. But when the night watchman interrupts their conversation, her motive is revealed: She intended to turn young Robin into a john.

With each encounter, the mystery of Molineux’s whereabouts mounts, though the sense of foreboding is cut by the comedy of our hero’s haplessness. Robin is a country mouse unaccustomed to the manners of the city, yet the narrator repeatedly describes him as a “shrewd youth”—typically right before Robin does something entirely lacking in shrewdness. When the fellow with the cough refuses to help him, Robin decides it is the old man, not himself, who is the Yankee bumpkin: “‘This is some country representative,’ was his conclusion, ‘who has never seen the inside of my kinsman’s door, and lacks the breeding to answer a stranger civilly.’”

As the night wears on, Robin begins to doubt that he will ever find Molineux, and the reader starts to wonder as well. Robin now stops “a bulky stranger muffled in a cloak” and demands to know where he can find his kinsman. The man removes his muffler to reveal a face painted half in red, and half in black. “The effect was as if two individual devils, a fiend of fire and a fiend of darkness, had united themselves to form this infernal visage.” It is this demonic figure who at last offers Robin an answer to his question, though a cryptic one: “Watch here an hour, and Major Molineux will pass by.”

As he waits, Robin slips into disorienting reverie, imagining his family at home on the farm. “Am I here, or there?” he wonders. But he is soon brought back to reality. The same “parti-colored” man has returned at the head of a howling mob parading through the streets a member of the colonial government—Major Molineux. He has been tarred and feathered, an antique torture that may sound cartoonish to contemporary ears, but that Hawthorne describes in all of its horror:

His face was pale as death, and far more ghastly; the broad forehead was contracted in his agony, so that his eyebrows formed one grizzled line; his eyes were red and wild, and the foam hung white upon his quivering lip. His whole frame was agitated by a quick and continual tremor, which his pride strove to quell, even in those circumstances of overwhelming humiliation.

This image of a broken man would have made for a terrifying denouement. But Hawthorne conjures another unnerving transformation. As Molineux passes by, Robin recognizes his kinsman and hears the cruel laughter of the mob. Rather than shrink from it, he joins the frenzy: “The contagion was spreading among the multitude, when all at once, it seized upon Robin, and he sent forth a shout of laughter that echoed through the street,—every man shook his sides, every man emptied his lungs, but Robin’s shout was the loudest there.”

A FEW years after departing *The American Magazine of Useful and Entertaining Knowledge*, still struggling to make a career of writing, Hawthorne tried his hand at a different kind of project: a children’s book. In *Grandfather’s Chair*, an old man recounts stories from American history through the experiences of his trusty oaken chair, which has seen it all. Hawthorne mostly succeeds at keeping the blackness in check in this foray into YA. But after Grandfather describes the Boston Massacre, one of the boys who has been listening to the tale speaks up:

“The Revolution,” observed Laurence, who had said little during the evening, “was not such a calm, majestic movement as I supposed. I do not love to hear of mobs and broils in the street. These things were unworthy of the people when they had such a great object to accomplish.”

The reader of “My Kinsman, Major Molineux” can be forgiven for having a similar response. We are accustomed to viewing the Sons of Liberty as defiant and resourceful and their rebellion against English tyranny as virtuous. Here, the stand-ins for the patriots are presented as ghouls, and the Tory is granted poignant nobility: “On they went, like fiends that throng in mockery around some dead potentate, mighty no more, but majestic still in his agony. On they went, in counterfeited pomp, in senseless uproar, in frenzied merriment, trampling all on an old man’s heart.”

Consider as well that Hawthorne has set his allegory not at the Old North Bridge or on Bunker Hill, but decades before the war for independence. As Michael

We are accustomed to viewing the Sons of Liberty as defiant and resourceful. Here, the stand-ins for the patriots are presented as ghouls.

J. Colacurcio writes in *The Province of Piety*, the definitive account of Hawthorne’s early tales, “Hawthorne is studying the majestic Revolution in terms of a minor outbreak of provincial unruliness, a mob scene.” Its victim is also a substitute: a man of rank, but a mere representative of the colonial government, seemingly made to suffer for the sins—a new tax on molasses? on sugar?—of the King or the Crown governor.

Hawthorne wasn’t a monarchist. He was a lifelong Democrat who was rewarded for his loyalty to the party with patronage positions in the customhouses of Boston and Salem, jobs that supported him when his writing could not. Later, he wrote a campaign biography for the feckless Franklin Pierce, a friend from Bowdoin College. When Pierce took office, Hawthorne was given a posting as consul to Liverpool. His notebooks from the years that he and his wife, Sophia, spent in that damp industrial port suggest a man who was at best ambivalent about the English way of life.

But the author of “My Kinsman, Major Molineux” is clearly suspicious of the mythology that has hardened around the Revolution by the year of jubilee. He seems to worry that a political philosophy intended to empower the people might inadvertently unleash the populist energies of the mob. Once unleashed, as a native of Salem would surely understand, that contagion can be hard to contain. Good Robin, exposed to the furor, looks upon his kinsman’s torture and betrays him with a laugh.

HAWTHORNE’S TALE is not just an allegory of the Revolution. It is also one of early American literature’s great coming-of-age stories, and its account of Robin’s initiation into the complexities of adult life carries its own ambiguities, and its own critique of a dearly held myth.

One frigid afternoon this spring, I walked past blocks of storefronts filled with witch kitsch to the stately home of the Salem Athenaeum. Hawthorne was a member, and the library has preserved the records of the books he checked out. On display in a vitrine was a volume of *General Zoology or Systematic Natural History*, opened to a colorplate depicting a coiled “Fasciated Boa”—the 1802 book makes a cameo in his story “Egotism; or, the Bosom Serpent,” in which a man is possessed by a snake.

A librarian had pulled for me *Memoirs of the Life and Writings of Benjamin Franklin, Written by Himself*. Hawthorne consulted it in 1828, when he would have been composing “My Kinsman, Major Molineux.” I half-hoped that he had defaced the Athenaeum copy with some margin notes—no such luck. But the text itself was proof enough that Hawthorne had Franklin’s own famous coming-of-age story in mind as he wrote.



The scholar Julian Smith was the first to list the many parallels between Robin's arrival in Boston and Franklin's in Philadelphia: "Each leaves his father's house to go to a strange city in search of advancement; each arrives in this strange city by boat; each is embarrassed about his lack of money." Robin is all but accused of being a runaway servant; Franklin had indeed broken his indenture to his older brother. He, too, seeks the assistance of a well-placed benefactor: The governor of Pennsylvania has offered letters of introduction and credit, establishing him in the printing business. But the promises prove empty.

Instead, Franklin will rise by virtue of hard work and (actual) shrewdness. In his *Memoirs*, he stresses his "most awkward ridiculous Appearance" upon

landing in Philadelphia—like Robin, he arrives in shabby attire, his meager possessions stuffed into his pockets—in order that the reader might "compare such unlikely Beginnings with the Figure I have since made there."

Franklin's account of his rise from poverty to prominence is the foundational text in the American myth of the self-made man, which holds that wealth and status are the products of diligence, not advantages inherited from a rich relative. Ostensibly, Robin learns the Franklin lesson. At the story's conclusion, he asks a city dweller who has stood by him during the awful procession—the first man to show him kindness all evening—to direct him back to the ferry. Deprived of his meal ticket, Robin sees

no reason to remain in the city. But the man won't permit him to leave:

"No, my good friend Robin,—not to-night, at least," said the gentleman. "Some few days hence, if you wish it, I will speed you on your journey. Or, if you prefer to remain with us, perhaps, as you are a shrewd youth, you may rise in the world without the help of your kinsman, Major Molineux."

The Robin of the story's end is shrewder than the boy who arrived in the city hours before. The mob he met in the moonlit street included, notably, all of the characters Robin had encountered earlier in the evening: the man with the sepulchral cough, the innkeeper, the whore, even the parti-colored man, first glimpsed at a tavern "holding whispered conversation with a group of ill-dressed associates." Out in the wider world, Robin has learned that adults can conspire and deceive—that they can wear two faces.

Yet Robin's story has a grimmer aspect than Franklin's. In place of an optimistic fable, we get a psychologically astute account of a young man's loss of innocence, complete with a startling act of oedipal violence—Robin's participation in the ruin of the man who was to be his surrogate father. By the end of the ordeal, Robin looks more defeated than wise: "His cheek was somewhat pale, and his eye not quite as lively as in the earlier part of the evening."

The good gentleman has told Robin that he can "rise in the world" without the help of his kinsman. But the tale ends there, his future far from assured. Young Hawthorne may have had his doubts that hard work will necessarily be rewarded.

HAWTHORNE'S CONTRARIAN streak didn't always serve him well. In May 1862, he submitted to James T. Fields, the editor of this magazine, a Civil War dispatch, reported from Washington, Harpers Ferry, and the Tidewater. Hawthorne was an unlikely war correspondent. His reflexive suspicion of causes left him more dismayed than energized by the nascent conflict. Although he was an old friend of Henry Wadsworth Longfellow's, and well acquainted with other founders of *The Atlantic*, he did not share their passion for abolition.

Hawthorne's sardonic essay described the war not as a divinely sanctioned liberation—as it had been deemed in "Battle Hymn of the Republic," published in *The Atlantic* that February—but as a grand folly. He writes witheringly of John Brown ("Nobody was ever more justly hanged") and sympathetically of Confederate prisoners of war, and likens the Monitor, the Union's mighty ironclad, to a "gigantic rat-trap." His condescending description

of "contrabands"—fugitive slaves seeking emancipation behind Union lines—suggests another reason for his lack of abolitionist zeal: He clearly views Black people as an inferior race.

Fields asked Hawthorne to excise some of the more offending passages, including an irreverent account of his meeting with "Uncle Abe." (The author acquiesced, though grudgingly: "What a terrible thing it is to try to let off a little bit of truth into this miserable humbug of a world!") The article, "Chiefly About War-Matters," nevertheless scandalized *Atlantic* readers. In this instance, the Hawthorne biographer Edwin Haviland Miller writes, "his familiar ambivalence afforded him a kind of cowardly protection and freedom from commitment, his seesawing and evasiveness pleasing no one."

Hawthorne's unsentimental view of the Revolutionary War, as expressed in "My Kinsman, Major Molineux," has aged better. Lately, historians have come around to the story's portrait of the conflict as marked by internecine mayhem. "Nothing done since by historian or novelist so concisely conveys the internal essence of the revolution," Alan Taylor writes in *American Revolutions*. "Hawthorne recognized that the struggle was our first civil war, rife with divisions, violence and destruction."

This is not a perspective likely to be on display in any official 250th celebrations. The current administration is engaged in an effort to bowdlerize American history, stripping away complexity in favor of easy myth and hagiography, not to mention the attempt to whitewash more recent events. The president insists that the insurrectionists who stormed the Capitol on January 6, 2021—including one man, the notorious QAnon Shaman, in parti-colored face paint—were "patriots."

The point of picking up Hawthorne's confounding story isn't to recast the American Revolution as little more than a provincial riot. It is to heed Hawthorne's warning about political passion giving way to hysteria and to recall the hard lesson that shrewd Robin learns: The adult world can be deceptive, disorienting, disturbing.

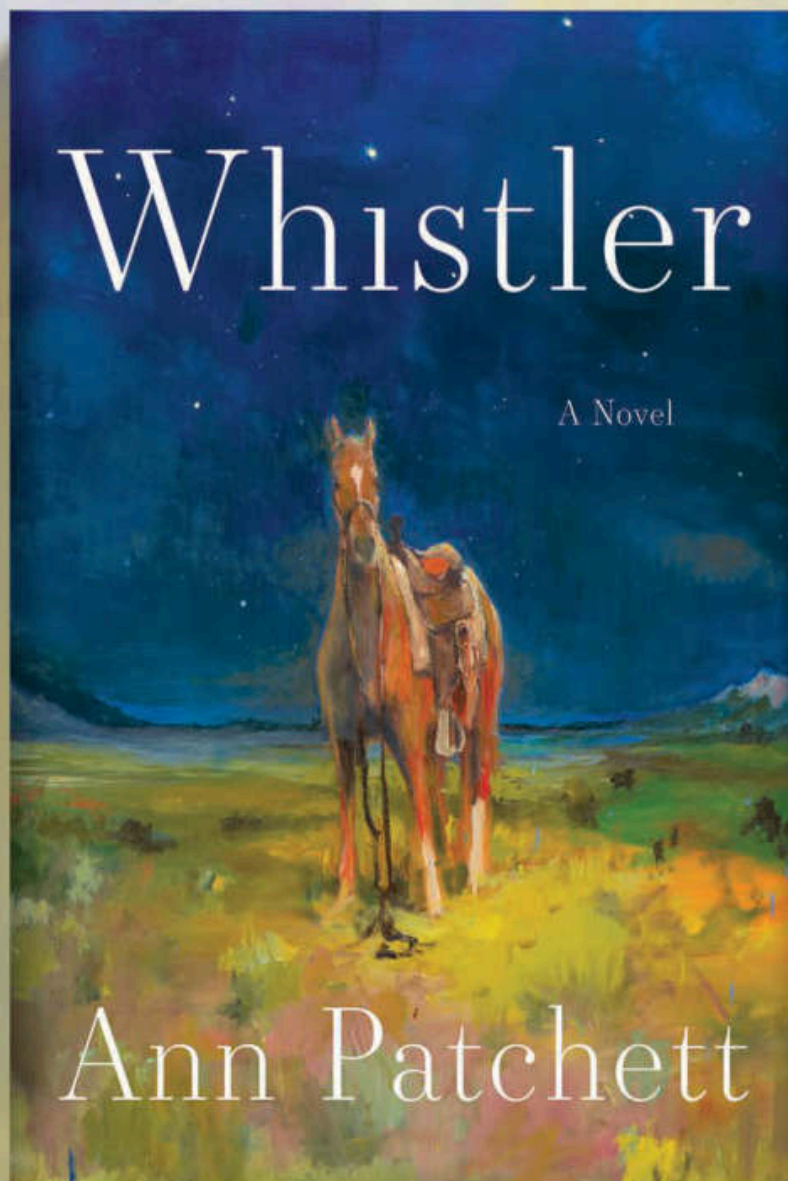
Melville left only a single notation in the margins of his copy of "My Kinsman, Major Molineux," a check mark beside a line I'd read past too quickly. It compares moonlight to the human imagination in its power to invest "a beautiful strangeness in familiar objects." This, perhaps, is the best reason to wander the crooked streets of Hawthorne's Boston: to see America's too-familiar origin story in a strange new light. *A*

John Swansburg is a managing editor at The Atlantic.

"Nothing done since by historian or novelist so concisely conveys the internal essence of the revolution."

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BOOKS

What Dogs See

*To understand a painting,
look for the canine.*

By Judith Shulevitz

Dogs follow the direction of a person's gaze almost as well as another person can—better, in fact, when they are motivated to, because dogs are relentless. They track the movements of our eyeballs to see what we're looking at so that they can look at it too, and they pester us to look just as attentively at them. When my late golden retriever had something to show me—a ball that had rolled under a fence, a man with an irregular gait—he didn't always bark. Sometimes he stared first at the ball or man, then back at me, then at the ball or man again, until I retrieved the ball or moved away from the man. People speak with their eyes all the time, but every so often I'd be struck with wonder that a consciousness as radically different from mine could communicate so effectively. Then I'd love him even more, if such a thing were possible, and feel a little insecure. My dog was putting himself on my conversational level, as it were, or maybe the better way to say it is he was yanking me up to his level.

The first animals to be domesticated, dogs began the process about 20,000 years ago, and the more time they spent in our field of vision, the longer they could maintain eye contact. Evolutionary theory offers an explanation: Dogs that could follow the human gaze and predict human actions had more success as hunting or herding partners.

In a 1977 essay called “Why Look at Animals?” the art critic and novelist John Berger recounts an origin myth about the importance of seeing and being seen by creatures unlike us. To summarize a convoluted tale: A long time ago, before people had tamed animals, an animal looked at a person and the person looked at the animal, and the person saw that the animal was different and that they couldn't understand each other. And yet the person recognized a fellow being with its own power, “comparable with human power but never coinciding with it,” and realized that to be seen by the animal was to become more fully oneself. We felt less lonely as a species. But then, Berger writes, industrial capitalism reduced animals to things—toys, future packages of meat, even “the new animal puppet: the urban pet.” We lost “a companionship which is different from any offered by human exchange.”

Berger was right about the sense of wholeness that comes from seeing oneself in an animal's eyes, and he was right to think that economic forces could undermine that connection, but he was wrong about pets. I wonder whether he had a dog. Or a cat. In 1997, Jacques Derrida held a seminar on the experience of seeing himself being seen by his cat as he stood naked before her. Published as a book during the aughts, the lecture became a key part of a revisionist philosophy of the human-animal interaction. Derrida undoes the solipsistic Cartesian formula for self-knowledge, "I think, therefore I am," and substitutes a vision of the self as seen through the animal's eyes. Derrida feels shame before the cat, he reports, but is not sure why. Perhaps he was "ashamed of being as naked as an animal," he thinks. Soon he is asking, "Who am I, therefore?"

Dogs must have provoked the same jittery, uncanny-valley feelings in early artists as Derrida's cat did in him, because dogs appear more than any other domesticated animal in prehistoric and ancient art. Dog art goes back nearly 10,000 years, which is when early-Holocene people made giant paintings on rocks in Saudi Arabia showing people and dogs collaborating in a hunt. Some dogs in the pack seem to be looking up at a human. Thousands of years later, man and dog had grown so comfortable around each other that they didn't need to trade glances. On an ancient-Greek vase from between 500 and 450 B.C.E., a man and his dog inspect an ithyphallic herm, a priapic statue with the head of the god Hermes; they both seem to express amused astonishment. The man is pulling the statue's beard, as if testing whether it's real. The dog has almost passed the figure but pauses and swivels his head back and up, doing a double take at the size of its organ.

THOMAS W. LAQUEUR'S *The Dog's Gaze: A Visual History* tells the story of the watchful dog. The book starts in the deep past and goes to the present, surveying much of the science and philosophy of the human-dog relationship. But Laqueur's chief interest lies in the Western pictorial tradition, especially from the Renaissance into the 20th century. A cultural historian, Laqueur likes to come at big and familiar topics from unexpected angles: *The Work of the Dead: A Cultural History of Mortal Remains* (2015) analyzes the respectful handling of corpses in order to understand what the dead do for the living. The book before that, *Solitary Sex: A Cultural History of Masturbation* (2003), puzzles over the taboos that govern the most democratic form of sexual gratification.

Like mortal remains and masturbation, the canine gaze might seem a marginal topic, but it provides a way to appreciate dogs' centrality in human

*To see
like a dog
in a work
of art is to
have moral
perceptions
about human
beings.*

experience. They are ubiquitous in art. Tens of thousands of them line the walls of museums and galleries. Dogs show up in dog portraiture, of course, and they have a natural place in scenes of hunting and public carousing. Once you start looking for them, you see them in all kinds of paintings—in portraits of princes and ladies, in Bible scenes, pooping on the street in a Rembrandt drawing, leading the way into modernity in an 1876 Gustave Caillebotte painting set in Paris, *Le Pont de l'Europe*. Mostly what dogs in art do is look, usually at people. They study other figures in a scene or peer out at the viewer. In the book's frontispiece, *Hundehode* ("Head of a Dog"), a dog stares at us with disturbing intensity, the urgency of its expression highlighted by patches of electric turquoise around the eyes that clash violently with the reddish-brown of the snout. The painting, by the Norwegian painter Edvard Munch, is dated 1942, two years into the Nazi occupation of Norway.

Laqueur has a theory about the dog in art: It stands in for the artist. "Dogs like artists do seem to look more intently than the rest of us," he writes. He tells a story about the poet Rainer Maria Rilke, who was once surprised to hear the painter Paul Cézanne described by a fellow painter as a man who looked at things as a dog would—purely, straightforwardly, "without any nervousness, without any ulterior motive." The writer W. G. Sebald turned Rilke's anecdote into a dictum: "Like a dog / Cézanne says / That's how a painter / Must see."

Artists use dogs to do what both they and dogs are good at: telling us where to look. A dog steers us toward important information in Giovanni Battista Tiepolo's *The Finding of Moses*, from the early 1730s. The painting illustrates a scene from the Book of Exodus. Pharaoh's daughter and her entourage hover excitedly over the infant Moses, who has been pulled out of a basket floating in the Nile; his mother had set him adrift rather than let him be drowned on Pharaoh's order. The Egyptians are so focused on the baby that they don't notice the Israelite girl striding toward them from the other side of the painting. We do, though, because their dog looks at her intently, its ears perked up. The young woman is Moses's sister, Miriam, and she is gesturing toward a wet nurse outside the frame—actually, the wet nurse is Moses's mother, though Miriam won't tell the princess that. The dog sees what the Egyptians can't or won't because the young woman is a lowly slave.

The dog's gaze in art doesn't limit itself to indicating something concrete. It may also alert us to a larger force that we have been blind to. In the case of Munch's dog, that force is Evil; in Tiepolo's, it's God. At this point in the story, Miriam's role is to make sure that the future leader of the Hebrews

*Previous page:
Blind Beggar
With Dog
(circa 1824),
Francisco de Goya*



ends up in the hands of the princess. But the sharpness of the animal's gaze suggests another, higher meaning: Miriam is God's messenger, heralding the imminent liberation of the slaves. Above all, the dog's line of sight performs a crucial narrative function. It unites the two sides of the painting, and thereby two peoples and two opposing stories—the Egyptians have no idea how tightly their history is about to be tethered to the Hebrews'—into a single tale of redemption.

To see like a dog in a work of art is to have moral perceptions about human beings. A common theme is the dog guiding a blind man. Another is the dog watching out for the beggar. Francisco de Goya's drawing *Blind Beggar With Dog* (circa 1824) combines both. In it, a humble beggar holds out his hat, bending in a manner that looks almost like bowing. Goya anchors this lowly man to the ground by means of a walking stick and a dog that lies next to him. Both man and dog seem more like shapes than individuals—the beggar is an undifferentiated bulk, the dog a lumpy mass under fur. The man's eyes are closed, depriving us of access to his thoughts, and he seems about to sink back into the earth. But the dog's eyes are open and piercing, providing a center of consciousness and a conscience. It is "looking straight out at us—seeing us for the blind man, demanding that we pay attention to his master," Laqueur writes.

The Finding of Moses (early 1730s),
Giovanni Battista Tiepolo

THE DOG'S
GAZE: A VISUAL
HISTORY

Thomas W.
Laqueur

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Above all, the pictorial dog shows compassion. In a fresco in Padua's Scrovegni Chapel that is part of a cycle about the life of the Virgin Mary, the late-medieval painter Giotto endows a dog with a depth of mercy that perhaps prefigures Christ's. Joachim, the Virgin's father, has fled into the desert after a painful humiliation. (This episode is found in the First Gospel of James, a second-century apocryphal work.) There he comes upon two shepherds who tend his sheep. Rather than greet their master, the young men look away, eyeing each other as if put off by the anguish on his face. One of their dogs, however, rises up on its hind legs, looks full into Joachim's eyes, and wags its tail. It is a poignant moment of cross-species recognition; the dog restores the dignity denied by the shepherds' indifference. "Dogs humanize humans," Laqueur notes dryly.

BUT AREN'T sympathetic dogs in art just wish fulfillment? It would be easy to read them as products of a narcissistic longing for unconditional love. In our scientific age, we are not supposed to anthropomorphize animals—that is, mistake our culturally overdetermined notions about animals for real knowledge, empirically obtained. But dogs are not as "other" as other animals are, and our thoughts about them spring from a much closer acquaintance. Dogs attach to their human caregivers, just as babies do; they've been bred to. Moreover, if we mythologize

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the dog's moral imagination, that doesn't mean that its morality is imaginary. Actual dogs clearly do feel joy and sorrow, and exhibit concern for their humans.

Lucian Freud's *Girl With a White Dog* (1951–52) can be taken as a melancholia painting in the tradition of Albrecht Dürer's famous engraving *Melancholia I* (1514). The main figure in such works is a mournful woman, typically accompanied by a dog. The conventional approach has been to interpret both of them iconographically. The woman represents a dark emotional state understood in medieval and Renaissance times as bound up in genius and madness, while dogs have long been seen as symbols for "spleen and black bile," in Laqueur's words. In his view, however, the dog is also just doing what dogs do; it is "keeping a dejected figure company."

In Freud's work, a woman sits on a couch and stares bleakly into the middle distance. She wears a loosely draped robe that exposes one untanned breast, and on her thigh lies the heavy head of a white bull terrier, which looks up at us with an inscrutable expression. The textured whiteness of its short-haired coat rhymes with her smooth white breast, pairing their bodies. They are profoundly at ease with each other. Dogs assuage loneliness by being there for us corporeally as well as sociably. Eyes locking with eyes is one step, and limbs sprawling side by side is another.

How many other caring bodies cleave to us so unhesitatingly in our sorrow? And can we always be counted on to cleave back? Some of the greatest

*Girl With
a White Dog*
(1951–52),
Lucian Freud



paintings in Laqueur's book depict the misery of the solitary dog. Perhaps the most famous is Goya's *El Perro*, in which a dog looks with imploring eyes into an ominous yellow mist. It is one in a series known as the *Black Paintings*, disturbing murals that the artist painted on his own walls from 1819 to 1823. As Laqueur reports, critics traditionally interpret paintings like these as figurative representations of our own existential isolation.

But I think they also show that dogs may share in that tragedy. I take one of Titian's greatest paintings, *The Death of Actaeon* (1559–75), based on Ovid's version of the Diana and Actaeon myth in his *Metamorphoses*, as a parable of our entangled fates. Wandering in the woods, the hunter Actaeon has come upon the goddess bathing naked with her nymphs. Furious, she has splashed water on him and turned him into a stag. Ovid heightens Actaeon's anguish by having him retain his human mind in the animal's body; he tries to cry out but has lost the power of speech. His own dogs, not recognizing him, tear him apart.

The Death of Actaeon, left unfinished at Titian's death, depicts the mauling. It is a horror movie in paint, full of reds and streaking brushwork that convey the speed of the rushing hounds and made eerie by the specter of dogs turning on their master. Laqueur calls it "a primal scene of violence as if the evolutionary civilizing process were reversed."

But, as he observes, the myth of Actaeon poses another question: What about the dogs? They deserve

their lot no more than he does his, and surely understand it less. Ovid doesn't tell us what happens when they realize that Actaeon is gone, but a second-century compilation of myths does. Laqueur quotes it: "When he was no more, they looked for their master with great howls and bays." A dog is more than man's friend. The social compact between the species is a two-way love story, rooted in millennia of mutual recognition. Woe unto us and our dogs should we ever stop seeing each other. *A*

Judith Shulevitz is a staff writer at The Atlantic.

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ESSAY

A Canvas as Big as the Country

Don't ask what Frederic Church's massive, immersive landscapes mean. Just look.

By Susan Tallman



“We know of nothing,” Henry James observed in 1875, “that is a better proof of the essential impotence of criticism, in the last resort, than Mr. Church’s pictures.” James wasn’t (in this instance) being spiteful. He was trying to sort out a real problem: What did the work of America’s preeminent painter actually mean? Serious art



is supposed to mean something—that’s a given—but really, what is there to say about Frederic Church’s *Valley of Santa Ysabel, New Granada*? You see distant mountains, an effulgent sky reflected in placid water, lots of greenery, and tiny people not doing much besides establishing the scale of an adjacent palm. You can feel the stillness and weight of the air. “Why not accept this lovely tropic scene as a very pretty picture,” James asked, “and have done with it?” A century and a half later, we’re still stumped.

Church, whose 200th birthday rolled around in May, was America’s first art star. He won accolades in England and a silver medal at the 1867 Exposition Universelle in Paris at a time when “American painting” was still an oxymoron among many cognoscenti. In city after city, people queued up in the tens of thousands and paid good money to stand in front of his pictures. Queen Victoria secured a private viewing of *The Heart of the Andes*. Audiences marveled at the exactitude, the passage of light, the almost palpable presence of a distant place. “He ranges with a steady eye and an unwavering hand,” *The New York Times* intoned. Church’s death, in 1900, was marked by a six-month retrospective at the Metropolitan Museum of

Art, an institution he had helped found, housed in the great public park for which he had served as a commissioner.

By then, however, the world was moving on. In the years that followed, American landscape painting was shuffled off to storage to make room for modernism, and paintings like Church’s, with their glassy finishes and profuse detail, came to seem the embodiment of fuddy-duddy. When Olana, Church’s visionary 250-acre estate on the Hudson River, was threatened with destruction in the 1960s, a *Times* headline referenced the “Italian-Moorish Home of U.S. Artist of Mid-1800’s,” presumably because so few readers would recognize Church’s name. Some respect was regained in the ’70s, when scholars connected Church and his peers to the intellectual currents of Transcendentalism. But even now, if you’re looking for an empty bench in a crowded museum, the rooms housing American landscapes are a good place to start.

Church’s bicentennial offers a chance to reconsider our prolonged indifference to the man and his art. A new biography by Victoria Johnson, *Glorious Country: How the Artist Frederic Church Brought the World to America and America to the World*, makes a case for her subject as anything

but a fuddy-duddy—a heroic adventurer, a public servant, a scientific ecologist, and a wildly ambitious orchestrator of pictorial magic. At Olana, which was rescued from the auction block and is now a New York State Historic Site, a wide-ranging exhibition, “Frederic Church: Global Artist,” incorporates dozens of beguiling oil sketches, larger paintings, and books and photographs from his omnivorous collection. It is accompanied by a book of essays addressing his global outlook, an erudite field guide to the estate, and a picture-filled hardback celebrating Olana’s landscape and architecture. All of this convincingly portrays Church as a relatable and appealing figure for the 21st century. How much it helps us understand his painting is another question.

THE AMERICAN art world that Church entered in the 1840s was more an aspiration than an entity. Great painting, everybody knew, was Europe’s bailiwick. American collectors bought European art, and many talented American painters high-tailed it to Europe at the first opportunity. Beyond how-to books, the United States offered few means of studying art, few great paintings to imitate, and, thanks to American prudery, few chances to master



OPENING PAGES: NATIONAL GALLERY OF ART / CORCORAN COLLECTION.
THIS PAGE: DALLAS MUSEUM OF ART.

the complex arrangements of human bodies considered indispensable to art's most profound forms.

What America did have was land, and landscape painters enjoyed a status here rarely accorded them in Europe. There was Asher Durand, master of the winsome glade; John Frederick Kensett, poet of still waters; and, above all, Thomas Cole, the philosopher-king of landscape, with whom an 18-year-old Church arranged to study privately. Largely self-taught, Cole was a relentless observer of material fact. He instructed Church to depict nature's objects as individuals—not just a tree, or even a hickory, but a specific hickory, with its own history and place in the world. The same went for rocks and weather. When Cole took his paints and easel outdoors, he was not, like the *plein air* artists of France, aiming to capture a subjective experience; he was taking lab notes on God's handiwork.

With a deft hand and remarkable visual memory, the young Church was a natural. By 19, he was exhibiting in New York City; at 22, he was the youngest artist ever elected to the National Academy of Design. Handsome, well-bred, and outdoorsy, he had the kind of looks that would suit the cocky football captain in a prep-school farce, yet by all accounts he was kind, well-liked, and witty. (It's hard to top his description of 19th-century Hartford, Connecticut, as a "city of pleasant faces and office chairs.") Church, his friend Worthington Whittredge wrote, was "fortune's favorite from the beginning."

Inspired by the German polymath Alexander von Humboldt's travels in South America and his ensuing argument for the interdependence of all natural entities, the young Church embarked on a nearly seven-month expedition in Humboldt's footsteps. Paints and sketch pads in tow, he made his way by boat, by mule, and on foot through the jungles of New Granada (now Colombia) and across the Cordilleras to the Ecuadoran volcanoes Cotopaxi and Chimborazo. The sketches he brought back became fodder for his 1855 breakout painting, *The Andes of Ecuador*.

Opening pages: *Niagara* (1857)
Opposite page: *The Icebergs* (1861)

Cinematic before there was cinema to compare it to, the painted vista slides over mountainous terrain, meandering streams, grasslands, and waterfalls to reach the snow-capped Cotopaxi under a sky throbbing with golden light. "From the rifted heavens the southern sunshine pours, like God's benediction on my temples," a critic for *Harper's Weekly* effused, as if standing bareheaded atop one of his mountains. God was undoubtedly on Church's mind—he planted a small wayside cross in the verdure at lower left—but so was Humboldt. Every pictured biome, from subtropical to highland plateau to alpine, is fitted with its appropriate flora, fauna, and geology. Every detail is accurate, though the picture as a whole is an invention,

*In heaving seas
and frigid cold,
beset by violent
seasickness, Church
rowed out in a
dinghy to record the
icebergs close-up.*

concocted from multiple views, locations, and studies. It told the truth, though not necessarily nothing but the truth.

For a decade, Church went from adventure to adventure and from strength to strength. His operatic paean to Niagara Falls was proclaimed "incontestably the finest oil picture ever painted on this side of the Atlantic" (reproductions became a common wedding gift across the nation). In 1859, following a return to South America, where he'd hoped to witness volcanoes actively erupting, he unveiled *The Heart of the Andes*—a 50-square-foot statement of cosmological interconnectedness, painted in his New York studio with a portrait of Humboldt looking on. For exhibition, he placed it in a massive, casement-like frame,

draped with curtains and accompanied by potted palms and gaslights to enhance the illusion of looking out a window into another world.

Reproduced on a book page or laptop screen, *The Heart of the Andes* can look deceptively ordinary—a bunch of trees, a waterfall, some distant mountains. Seen in person, however, it's an immersive spectacle: Tiny butterflies, identifiable by species, flit among blooming epiphytes; red-breasted meadowlarks take to the air; an emerald-green quetzal perches on a branch. An Indigenous couple pay a visit to another makeshift cross, mist rises from a waterfall, and mountains rear up, first green, then brown, and finally glittering white. The painting was "a miracle," Samuel Clemens (not yet Mark Twain) wrote to his brother when the picture reached St. Louis. "We took the opera glass, and examined its beauties minutely," but a single viewing was not enough: "Your third visit will find your brain *gasping* and straining with futile efforts to take all the wonder in." Even Londoners were enthralled, crediting Church with "a gaze of extraordinary clearness and vigilance; a gifted hand," as well as "a tender and capacious spirit, which unites harmoniously the minute and the vast."

This kind of attention was no accident. Church kept the press strategically apprised of his travel plans and his subsequent progress in the studio, ginning up excitement about forthcoming pictures. By 1860, he was enough of a celebrity that even his wooing made the papers—a "Page Six" item *avant la lettre*. And although his travels were certainly motivated by a genuine urge to see and understand, he was not unaware of which destinations were likely to capture public imagination.

When the perilous search for the Northwest Passage sparked a wave of popular interest in the Arctic, Church set off by schooner in search of icebergs. In heaving seas and frigid cold, beset by violent seasickness, he rowed out in a dinghy to record them close-up. The payoff was a bevy of remarkable oil and pencil sketches (a stunning oil study can be seen in the Olana exhibition) as well as paintings. The standout is a grand, otherworldly picture, devoid of human and animal life but suffused with strange light, and the majesty

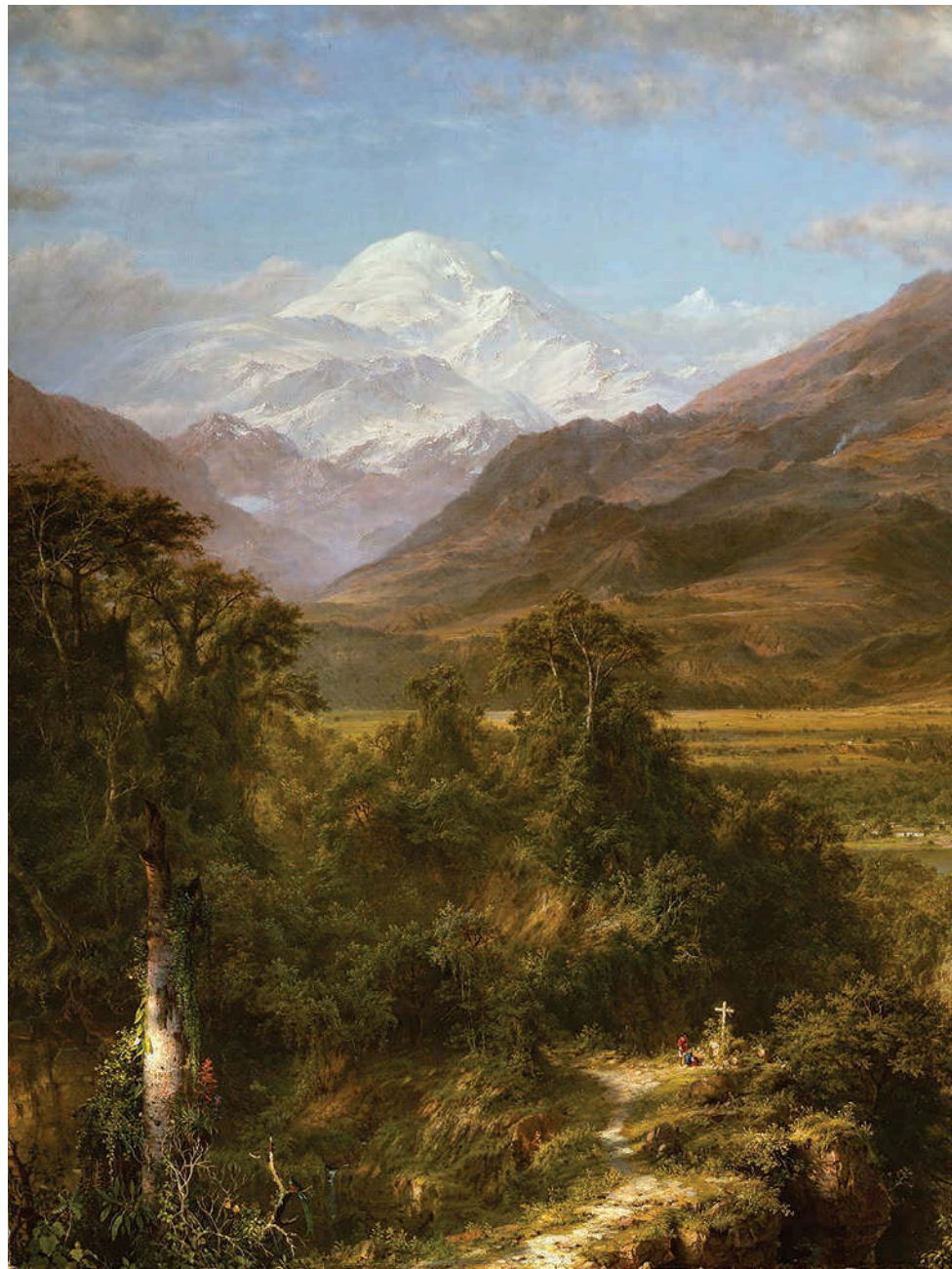
and menace of colossal ice in moving water. When, two weeks before the painting's debut, the United States went to war against itself, Church promptly changed its title from *The Icebergs* to *The North*.

This gesture was undoubtedly patriotic in sentiment—he was a staunch supporter of the Union cause—though confusing in argument. Exactly how does a calved iceberg signify the ideals of emancipation and a unified nation-state? Church's antislavery bona fides seem solid: As far back as 1852, he had painted a white woman and a free Black man in casual conversation at the base of the Natural Bridge rock formation in Virginia—a provocative choice even if the figures are diminutive. Having political convictions, however, is different from being able to express them clearly in paint.

His wartime polemic, *Our Banner in the Sky* (1861), is a visual pun in which morning stars and sunrise clouds conspire to suggest a tattered American flag. It isn't a good painting, but the lithographs sold well, and, like generations of successful artists, Church may have recognized that his most effective contribution to the cause would be money. He donated exhibition income, supplied paintings for fundraising auctions, and finagled loans of his three blockbusters—*Niagara*, *The Andes of Ecuador*, and *The Heart of the Andes*—to New York's 1864 Metropolitan Fair for the benefit of Union soldiers.

The eventual victory was eclipsed for Church and his wife, Isabel, by the loss of both their young children to diphtheria within days of each other. Travel now served as a palliative—first a trip to Jamaica, then a year and a half voyage to Europe and the Levant, where Church painted the Holy Land, another subject with reliable sales. With a new baby and Isabel's mother, they settled happily in Beirut for several months, making excursions to Jerusalem, Bethlehem, Damascus, and Baalbek. On his own, Church embarked on a dicey journey under Bedouin guard to Petra by horse and camel. (Ever attentive to the particular, he left us a winning sketch of his dromedary, inscribed with the animal's name, Zraigan.)

The epic sky of his *Jerusalem From the Mount of Olives* (1870) races from furious clouds to radiant sun above an array of



biblical landmarks so thorough, it required a crib sheet. But Church's dominance of American art had begun to slip. *Jerusalem* was faulted for its lack of "atmospheric effect." There were complaints of didacticism. He was also attacked by American Pre-Raphaelites (far more dogmatic than the English originals) who objected to what they saw as the flashy artifice of the dramatic light and weather in his work. And for sheer showmanship, he found himself overtaken by Albert Bierstadt, whose mountains rose more vertiginously, whose rays of godly light shone

more theatrically, and whose claimed territory was not the exotic South or North or Middle East, but a West that the United States was coming to see as its own. *Harper's Weekly* reflected the national mood when it contrasted the "sadness and desolation" in Church's Andes with what it described as the "temperate cheerfulness" of Bierstadt's Rockies, and their invitation to look upon Native lands as "the possible seat of supreme civilization" (one not, presumably, of Native design).

In 1875, trying to put a finger on his own dissatisfaction, Henry James



described Church's paintings as "the kind of art which seems perpetually skirting the edge of something worse than itself." He wasn't wholly wrong. Church's numinous-sun-over-still-water routine had begun to look a bit like a shtick, equally applicable to scenes of the Hudson or those worked up from 20-year-old sketches of South America. The details were still there, but the thrill was gone. *The River of Light* (1877) is sufficiently anodyne that the National Gallery of Art's website offers a three-minute online guided meditation focused on it.

Church's priorities had shifted. Now a family man with four children, he was also deeply engaged in public endeavors such as the Met. Church took annual camping trips to Maine with friends and family, and he continued painting and traveling internationally until his death, but he had begun to feel the effects of what would become crippling rheumatoid arthritis. Church denied newspaper reports that he had lost the use of his right hand, but he does seem to have learned to paint with his left as well. The paintings grew smaller, but his landscape ambitions only grew larger.

The Heart of the Andes (1859)

CHURCH HAD fallen in love with the Hudson River Valley as a teenager studying with Thomas Cole, and had been buying land there since 1860. Being short of neither confidence nor money, he set about building a familial "Feudal Castle" and transforming the surrounding property into living art. He dredged swampland to create a 10-acre lake and initiated a reforestation project that emphasized native species—planting hemlocks, maples, and

hickories in the tens of thousands, some positioned to draw the eye as individual subjects of contemplation, others massed in color schemes that shift with the seasons. He laid out miles of winding roads that rise and dip, eventually opening onto a bell-towered, ogee-arched, polychrome mini-palace on a hill so high that its views stretch into four states. He and Isabel named it Olana for an elevated stronghold in a region of ancient Persia rumored to be the site of the Garden of Eden.

Contra the *New York Times* headline, the house isn't so much "Italian-Moorish" as Persian-Japanese-Mexican-Kashmiri. Church had found London "big and dirty" and the ornamentation of Paris "very tiresome"; as for Rome, he wrote, "The Tiber is not the Hudson." But he and Isabel had been smitten with the Middle East and its architecture, particularly the flow between indoors and outdoors. Formidable on approach, the Church house is unexpectedly porous once you're inside, punched through with porches, balconies, atria, and outlooks, each strategically framing a view. (The land, along with the house and the belongings inside it—tens of thousands of them, including sketches, unfinished paintings, topographical photographs, and canceled checks to Brooks Brothers—were preserved by Church's son and daughter-in-law until their deaths.)

The building is certainly overstuffed—pre-Columbian artifacts, Chinese breeze-way tiles, Indian chairs—but never stuffy, and often playful. Look closely and you'll find that the intricate window grilles are actually cut black paper compressed to the panes, and that the finials on the tower's topmost railing feature Japanese teapots. Everything works in the same cinematic way as the paintings: Rooms and landscapes unfold as you move through them, sometimes with slow pans, sometimes with jump cuts. There are forced close-ups (with the exception of the dining gallery, none of the rooms feels very large), and 360-degree panoramas. "I can make more and better landscapes in this way than by tampering with canvas and paint," Church told a friend. Olana is often described as his greatest work of art.

For all this worldliness, however, Church at 200 remains a distinctly

American figure. The Olana website shows more than 70 locations where Church paintings are currently on public view. Only four are outside the continental United States, and those include Honolulu and Ponce, Puerto Rico. Only Edinburgh and Madrid require a passport.

If Church's influence beyond the U.S. is essentially nonexistent, his influence within the U.S. has its own problems. Recapitulated by lesser hands, the natural grandeur he invoked so splendidly devolved into purple-mountains-majesty cliché. Church's *Mount Katahdin From Millinocket Camp* (1895) looks so much

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like the cover of an L.L.Bean catalog that it can be hard to recognize what a fine painting it actually is.

The other big impediment for contemporary eyes is that Church's career coincided with a paradigm shift in visual art—a change in not just what pictures mean, but how that meaning is conveyed. For 500 years, from Giotto to Eugène Delacroix, painting told human-interest stories—a baby in a manger, desperate sailors on a raft. Even most landscape painting was actually about people. The subject of Caspar David Friedrich's famous *Wanderer Above the Sea of Fog* (circa 1817) isn't the mountains or the weather—it's the guy blocking our view of the mountains and weather.

And then the game changed. The year before James found himself befuddled by Church's painting of sun reflected in the waters of New Granada, French critics found themselves befuddled by Claude Monet's picture of sun reflected in the waters of Le Havre. *Impression, Sunrise* gave name to a movement that introduced a new kind of looking—one that found meaning in how pictures depart from reality rather than how convincingly they imitate it. The human-interest story moved from the people in the picture to the thoughts and emotions of the artist who put them there.

But Church wasn't telling stories about people at all. Line his paintings up chronologically and you can watch the world depopulate—from a youthful New England landscape with European settlers front and center; to the small interracial pair in *The Natural Bridge, Virginia*; to his desolate icebergs whose lack of human narrative so perplexed British audiences that Church added a shattered mast to make it salable. (You can take this as a lack of artistic integrity or a lack of artistic pomposity as you like.) Neither is he putting his own subjectivity on view. His oil sketches are more disarming than the finished paintings because you can see the mind and hand at work: His act of discovery sits closer to the surface. That's what sketches do—they give you access to the moment of creation. But in the finished paintings, he cedes the stage to his subject. At Olana, he disappears so completely that if you don't stop in at the visitor center, you might miss the fact that the landscape was designed at all.

Contemporary art historians are trained to tease out the political messaging of artworks, but Church is elusive here as well. He "didn't enjoy talking or writing about politics," Victoria Johnson notes in her biography, which makes it hard to build a case for intent. Writing about the pairing of presidential portraits with *The Heart of the Andes* in the Metropolitan Fair, the editors of *Frederic Church: Global Artist* write that "the notion of divinely ordained westward expansion of the United States and colonization of Indigenous lands, is here extended farther south," but they don't claim that this is what Church had



The Natural Bridge, Virginia (1852)

in mind. The fiery skies he painted in the 1850s and '60s have been read as warnings about the sin of slavery, but the degree to which clear policy statements can be read into a sunset is questionable. Johnson and others have been attentive to the overlooked Indigenous histories of locations that Church depicted, but, again, these don't tell us much about what Church knew or meant to say.

Anyway, even if viewers could be assured that his political instincts aligned perfectly with their own, it wouldn't make

the paintings good. Yet somehow all of these authors—from James onward—have trouble seeing his best work as just “a very pretty picture.” An idea must be in there somewhere, people feel, but what and where?

I recently went to check in on *The Heart of the Andes* at the Met, where it hangs in a partial re-creation of the 1864 Metropolitan Fair arrangement, along with Emanuel Leutze's overweening *Washington Crossing the Delaware* and Albert Bierstadt's *The Rocky Mountains, Lander's Peak*. The gallery was almost empty. The benches were indeed free, though *The Heart of the Andes* is a picture that wants

to be seen up close, where you can make discoveries inch by inch, and roam from a sky that looks like a hymn to all Creation down to the shaft of sunlight that falls on a tree trunk, just where Church has “carved” his signature.

While I was taking notes on that free bench, a Japanese tour guide ushered a dozen or so people into the room, spoke at length about the Leutze, then led them out again. *Washington Crossing the Delaware* is perfect tour-guide material—it can be seen by a bunch of people at once, and its story can be told concisely, timed to the minute. After they exited, however, one little girl doubled back to take a photo—not of giant George in a boat, but of the narrative-free, choose-your-own-adventure *Heart of the Andes*.

Church's painting is the anti-Leutze: It's not a story to be memorized but a portal to a place that feels infinite and changeable. Perambulate the Met in its entirety and you'll be hard-pressed to find a landscape that asks so instantly to be believed in. As at Olana, there is always something more to see, both profound and playful. Johnson (clearly fond of her subject) describes Church as “a painter in love with the whole cosmos, a man who, when he came face-to-face with the eternities of time and space, felt not fear or alienation but the thrilling connection of humans to all other beings and matter.” Call this a political idea or a spiritual one; it is, in any event, an idea.

So when the workings of the world, with its shouty messaging and manipulative storylines, get to be too much—when all of that strategized meaning feels like an imposition—go to the Met or Olana or your nearest Church. Give yourself time. Bring opera glasses. *✍️*

Susan Tallman, a contributing writer at The Atlantic, is an art historian and the author, most recently, of Kerry James Marshall: The Complete Prints: 1976–2022.

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The First 18 Months

*A Cabinet meeting
with my son,
who is exactly as
old as the current
administration*

By
Alexandra Petri

Sir! I love you! Thank you for including me in this meeting to talk about all the wonderful things you've accomplished since January 2025. What a big, beautiful man you are. The greatest fellow in the whole world! You're so alert. And you can walk! Wow!

When grown men see you, they weep, and they are right to do so. Look at those toes. Your hair looks great; it is the right amount. If you were playing golf and you wanted to just put the ball in the hole with your hand, I don't think any of us would stop you.

And that face! That face should be on Mount Rushmore! Or the Department of Labor, at the very least.

I love how you like to watch a parade and clap. Maybe we can do that for your birthday! Please give me back my phone; I think you are calling Europe, and that will not make anything better.

I love what a priority gas emissions are for you, and how you smile afterward.

I like how when you use a pen, you make a big squiggle. I also like how sometimes you make up a word and then we all use it, because we want you to know how smart we think you are. I loved when you correctly pointed out a squirrel. I said that you were a genius earlier; you

responded by throwing some ketchup on the floor. And I was honored just to be in your presence when that happened.

Hey, who turned on the TV? Let's turn that off.

Let's put on that playlist you like instead! I love how much you love Andrew Lloyd Webber! And how, when you hear "Y.M.C.A.," you do a movement that you consider to be a form of dance. Please don't touch that button. That button will mess a lot of things up.

Please stop typing gibberish. I am trying to finish this column. I love you very much, but anytime you write something, it creates work for me.

Hey. Look at this nice world. Do you see how nice it is? Hamburgers exist (I know you are fond of those) and hats (you love a hat)—but there are so many wonderful things you have never seen. Things I want to show you. Things I want you to care about, and not break. I don't know how to make you love the parts of the world that I love, but, oh, I wish I could.

And by the way, your fingers are perfect. Just the right size for a man your age. *A*

*Alexandra Petri is a staff writer
at The Atlantic.*

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